She-Ra: Champion of Power

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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by Firebird_X

Summary

You all know the twist. Two Horde cadets, one recently made a Force Captain, the other destined to be left behind, "borrow" a skiff and go for a joyride. Instead of Adora, Catra is the one who falls, the one who finds the Sword, the one burdened with a destiny meant for another.

This is not that story.

When Catra reached her sixteenth birthday (not that the Horde tells her what that is), Shadow Weaver takes Catra's first life. What happens next changes the fate of Etheria...

Notes

Me: Most. Important. Deadline. Of my LIFE.

Also me: Want Cat-Ra. WANT.

Yes, just what I need, another Turn Right Timeline, but...this is relevant to Turn Right, plus I'm a sucker for Catra getting all the love. Fair warning, this is not going to be an episode-by-episode remake, and it's going to time-skip a LOT.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Last Magicat

The boy with the "shoot me in the abs" shirt slapped his strange device, glaring at the glowy slab. "Come on! Come on!"

"Ugh!" the sparkly girl replied, rolling her eyes. "Please tell me we're not lost!"

The cat watched them trudge through the Whispering Woods, the girl looking around impatiently, the boy still messing with his screen-thing. "The signal's overloading the tracker pad. A little!" he said, smiling. "Nothing we can't handle." The girl gave him a sideways glance the cat appreciated. "Look, the sword's tech, the cat-lady has the sword," he continued.

The cat froze, heart pounding enough to blur what they said next. *They want me,* she thought, eyes narrowing. *Why?*

The bickering stopped when a giant beetle chittered towards them. The girl chuckled and grabbed the boy's arm. "Bow? What was that?" The cat huffed as she noticed "Bow's" quiver. *Wow, that's an on-the-nose nickname.*

"How should I know, Glimmer?" Bow blurted. The cat froze again. *Princess,* she realized, tail lashing and ears back. *Crap.*

"You know these woods better than anyone!" Glimmer shot back. The cat smirked.

The beetle burst into their clearing. Glimmer and Bow screamed, grabbed onto each other, and vanished in a burst of sparkles. *Huh.* The cat stared at the empty spot for several seconds. *...huh.*

Then the beetle rushed past the cat's hiding spot, skidding to a halt, and she recognized the claw marks on its back. "Fred?" she cackled. "Is that you?"

Fred turned, red eyes dimming as he hunched down. The cat laughed and leaped down beside him, walking up and patting his

side. Fred relaxed, eyes glowing brighter again. “Relax. We’re buds, remember?” He leaned into her paw, letting her rub him for a minute. “Look, leave those two alone, okay? She’s a princess. The Horde’s full of crap, sure, but princesses are still bad news.”

“Excuse you!” Glimmer reappeared in a burst of light, all indignant scowl and fists on hips. “What’s that supposed to–”

Fred howled. “Great, you pissed him off,” the cat sighed. “Cool it, Fred, we don’t want–”

Ignoring her, Fred charged. The cat grabbed Glimmer–

The world turned into inside out and upside-down shimmering light, then righted itself before the cat had time to react. She dropped onto the branch she, Bow, and Glimmer were on, gripping it with all four limbs. “What the hell, Sparkles?” the cat snarled. “I was trying to help you.”

“Well I was helping you,” Glimmer replied, crossing her arms and looking away. If she wasn’t still dizzy, the cat would have laughed at the little princess’ huff. “And my name is Glimmer.”

The cat laughed anyway. “Yeah, never calling you that, Sparkles.” Glimmer glared at her.

“Uh, Glimmer, maybe we shouldn’t antagonize the lady we’re here to ask for help?” Bow suggested.

The cat stood, brushed herself off, and looked from archer to princess. She knew she must be a sight, her only clothes a sleeveless maroon tunic and long black boy-shorts. “Don’t worry about that. Answer’s already no.”

Glimmer’s glare somehow became more furious. “You don’t even know why we’re here!”

“You either want my help with monsters or the Horde,” the cat said, cutting Glimmer’s rant short. “Since you’re a princess, my money’s on the Horde. At least it would be if I had money.”

"We could help each other," Bow replied, gentle but quick to keep his friend from digging herself any deeper. "You're already fighting the Horde. The stories say you've taken out tanks. Imagine what we could do together." That tone was kind, considerate, and familiar – but only from one voice she'd heard before.

And oh, if that didn't hurt. *Adora...* The cat shook her head. *Not yet. Shadow...the Horde won't let her go on missions for at least a year.* She scowled at Bow. "I'm waiting for someone. There's no way I'm getting mixed up with Rebels or princesses."

Glimmer threw her arms in the air. "Oh, come on! Who could you possibly be waiting for in the middle of the *Whispering Woods?"* Fred's howl cut off Sparkles' rant, the two Rebels clinging to each other.

"Oh for Hordak's sake, get a room," the cat sighs, as much to shock them as anything else. It works a little too well, as she waits for two minutes while the pair splutters between outrage at the invocation of Hordak and embarrassment at her stating the obvious.

"How are you the Wildcat of the Whispering Woods?" Glimmer finally settles on, her face almost apple-red.

Catra is so startled that her name slips into her mind for an instant. "The *what?"*

Bow stares for a moment. "The hero of Thaymor. Elberon's shield. The ghost of Erelandia." The cat's cheek fur flattens so tight she's afraid they might see her blush, eyes wide and ears back. "You drove off an entire Plumerian invasion single-handed, blew up a dozen tanks outside Greenfield, and rescued Alwyn's farmers when the Horde kidnapped, like, *all* of them." Glimmer's anger was already gone, her eyes as sparkly as her hair. "That's just the stuff we could confirm. You're a legend, miss Wildcat."

It was Catra's – the *cat's* turn to splutter. "I am *not* a hero!" she exploded, arms in the air like Glimmer's had been. They were both

grinning, now. “I’m not!” She leaped to the tip of the branch, causing the whole thing to sway. “You don’t know *anything* about me,” she spat, ready to leap.

“Wait, please!” Glimmer begged. The cat froze. “I – I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have – ugh!” The princess grabbed her hair, then sat down as well as any hairless simian can on a branch barely wide enough for her butt. “I...know I can come on kinda strong. It’s just...we were losing, before you showed up.”

The cat snorted. “You’re still losing, Sparkles,” she pointed out.

“Then help us,” Glimmer replied, somehow demanding and pleading at once. “If we don’t know you, then tell us.”

The cat stood and turned, branch wobbling until she was halfway back to the marginally-balanced duo. “You wanna know who I am? I’m a monster from the Horde!”

The two stared. “But...but you’re our age,” Bow whispered.

“And? Do you even know where Horde soldiers come from?” the cat demanded.

Glimmer snorted. “They recruit criminals,” she said, glowering as much as a human glitter-bomb can. “Mercenaries. Pirates. The scum of Etheria.”

The cat glared at her. “How long has the Horde been kicking your tails, Sparkles?”

“Thirty years, give or take,” Bow blurted before Glimmer could stick her foot back in her mouth.

The cat nodded. “Top marks, Crop Top. Now, one more question, just one. In thirty years, how many kids do you think have spent their whole lives in the Fright Zone?”

Bow gasped. Glimmer’s whole attitude drained away as she went pale. “That was you?” Bow whispered.

The cat shrugged. “Me and ten thousand other cadets, yeah.” She looked away. “Only differences were, I had a friend, and...Shadow Weaver.”

It almost hurt when they gasped again. “The sorceress?” Glimmer asked, hands over her mouth.

Catra nodded, unable to speak for a moment. “She hated me. Liked *hurting* me. But my...friend...she was Shadow Weaver’s favorite. It was almost as bad as being, well, me.” Her name refused to go back into its cell, not with the witch in her head. “My first memory is the two of them arguing over me while I was trapped in a box. I must’ve been...five? About Leena’s age.”

Bow smiled. “Your friend from Greenfield?” he asked. Catra bristled, biting back a hiss. “She cares about you, you know. She made us promise to be nice to you.”

Catra – *NO.* The cat ran her hands over her hair, forcing it down. “Promises.” she huffed. “We promised we’d always look out for each other. It couldn’t have been a year after they took me.”

“But you had to leave,” Glimmer insisted. “The Horde’s evil! Besides, Shadow Weaver was hurting you, right?”

The cat hissed and pushed back some fur, showing off a tiny handful of her scars. *Again with the staring,* she thought, rolling her eyes. “I stayed anyway. For my friend. Until Shadow Weaver killed me.”

Glimmer scoffed until Bow shook her head. “No, Glimmer, she’s telling the truth! Stars, you’re a magicat!” he blurted, his smile enormous.

The cat blinked. “I can’t do magic,” she explained, “not without the Sword, anyway. Shadow Weaver said–” The cat stared into the forest, falling onto her butt. “I’m an idiot. *Shadow Weaver* told me I can’t do magic. She made a whole thing out of it.” Catra jumped to her feet, pacing as much as the branch allowed. “Of *course* she lied to me! That’s what she does, isn’t it?”

Glimmer looked from Bow to Catra and back. “The legend is, magicats have nine lives,” Bow explained. “That if there’s a way for their body to come back, it will, eight times.”

Nodding, the cat crouched, looking for the Sword. “I aced a test. ‘Secondary maturity,’ or something. Scored better than my friend and – well.” She rubbed over her heart. “When I came back, I felt it. Eight lives left.” She made fists. “I crawled back to the bunks, begged Ad – my friend to leave with me. She begged me to stay. I was going to.” The cat laughed. “But then, THEN, you know what she said?” They shook their heads. “She said she *needed* me...to be more careful. Careful!”

Catra growled and stood, catching the Sword glowing in the distance. “I thought, for a second, she needed me to *stay.* With her. And you know what?” she snarled, whirling on the princess and her...person. “I would’ve. I would’ve stayed, and let the Horde ruin me, and burned down Greenfield and Elberon and Thaymor and *Brightmoon* if she just *wanted* me.”

The cat glared at the Sword, hating it almost as much as she hated herself. “But no. I was just her pet all along. Turns out Shadow Weaver was right about something after all, even if it was by accident.” She turned that glare back on the duo. “So that’s who I am. I’m not the good guy. I’m not a princess, or a knight, and I’m *definitely* not some magic chosen one here to save the world. I wreck Horde stuff to hurt Shadow Weaver. That’s it.”

And then she laughed again, and somehow it was worse this time. “And that’s...that’s not even the best part,” the cat rambled, pressing her hand to her face. “No, the best part is, after I saved Leena and thought I might be worth something, I found the Sword.” She laughed, because why not? “I thought I had something that was mine for once, something cool and beautiful and powerful. I found the Sword...and it wants *her.”*

Bow swallowed. “Your friend?” he asked.

"Yep," the cat said, popping the "p" as she crouched to leap towards the Sword. "There's a weird glowy blue lady in the Sword. She knows that I know Adora, and – scut." The cat winced. *I had to say her name,* she despaired. "Blue lets me use the Sword while we wait for her. Because of course *Adora* has some magical hero destiny. I'm the one who left, I've got the whole Horde afraid of me, and she thinks the princesses are evil because *Shadow Weaver* tells her, but somehow she's the hero and I'm still the monster."

The cat deflated, spent, waiting for the two to recoil from her. *Still felt good,* she thought, *even better than telling Razz. I don't think she even heard me, crazy old bat.* They hadn't stopped staring. "What? Are you brain-damaged now or something?" she huffed.

All at once, they were hugging her. The cat froze. *Flark, I gotta stop doing that,* she thought, but somehow she couldn't move. "That's...horrible," Glimmer whispered. "And don't you dare listen to that stupid Sword."

Finally, it was Catra's turn to stare. *What?* Her brain wouldn't accept what was happening. "Weren't you listening?"

Glimmer loosened up on the hug enough to look her in the eyes. "Yes. Now you listen to me, Wildcat," she said, and for some reason, the cat couldn't look away. "My mom has this...thing she likes to tell me, when I don't feel like I'm worth anything." The cat's eyes bulged. *But she's a princess!* she thought while Glimmer rolled on like a tank. "Mom says, 'we are our actions.' Sure, it's not...ideal that you think you wanna hurt the Horde more than help people."

The cat glared. "'Think?' Excuse you," she retorted.

"You're Leena's hero, you know," Bow said, and *damn* that smile of his, anyway.

"But you still saved all those people! And you would've saved me from, uh, 'Fred,'" Glimmer giggled, "if I'd needed it."

“Listen, uh...Wildcat?” Bow paused. “What is your name, anyway?”

The cat thought for a moment. “You’ll hear them call me ‘Catra,’ because Shadow Weaver’s a creep,” she replied, “but Shadow Weaver murdered Catra in the Fright Zone.” She forced her expression hard. “Catra was a monster. She died five months ago.” Then she grinned. “I like Wildcat. Call me that.”

“Great!” Glimmer grabbed her hand. “Let’s get the Sword and go!”

Wildcat’s grin vanished. “Whoa, wait, no no no, I’m not going anywhere,” she blurted, yanking her hand free. “The stupid Sword still wants stupid Adora, and the Horde won’t deploy her for at least a year.”

Bow bit his lip for a moment. “Wildcat,” he said, working his way through each word, “I get that you want to keep your promise. But you need to take care of yourself first.”

Wildcat looked away, tail lashing. “What? No, she never kept her promise, I even left, like, a note about it. I’ve got a deal with Blue, that’s all.” She huffed. “It’s *not* because I like her.”

Glimmer’s sigh was as explosive as her magic. “Okay, gonna ignore the weirdly specific denial for a minute there,” she muttered. “Look, we want to defeat the Horde. You want to defeat the Horde. From the sound of it, your – the Sword wants to defeat the Horde. So, back to where we started, shouldn’t we work together?” Sparkles smiled, and it ached how much that fearful, hopeful smile was like Catra’s. “If you come to Brightmoon, you can tell us how the Horde works, and we can give you a home and food and clothes and stuff! And we can fight them, together.” She wrung her hands. “Besides, we don’t care about whatever messed up garbage the Horde fed you. You’re good enough for us.” Wildcat’s heart pounded like a cannon, caught between yearning and disbelief. “And maybe...we can even be friends?”

Wildcat's ears went flat against her head. "I don't do friends. Not any more." Somehow, that made the two of them sadder than ever. "Come on," she sighed. "Let's see if the Sword'll cooperate." She leaped through the forest, Glimmer teleporting with a yelp and Bow swinging from an arrow with a *rope* on it. *Dorks. No wonder they don't stand a chance against the Horde.*

Wildcat thought about that as they approached the clearing. *Not without me, anyway. And...not that I'd ever tell her...but Sparkles has a point. I can't beat the Horde alone either.* They gasped at the sight of the Sword, all blue crystal and golden steel and shining like a miracle. *That's it, though. Allies against the common enemy.* She strode towards the Sword, bracing herself.

This is not *because I like them.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora reached for Catra, hand probing for her best friend, her other half, her...something that no one else had. Her miracle.

There are no miracles in the Horde. Only cold steel and colder truth. There was no Catra. There was only her headpiece and a sheet of paper, a single sentence scrawled on it:

"You never kept your promise."

"AH!" Adora sobbed, sitting bolt upright in her bunk.

Her squadmates groaned. "Go back to sleep, Adora," Lonnie groaned.

"Honestly," Tavor added, "I've been on Shadow Weaver's bad side more times in the last four months than the rest of my life together."

"Sorry," Adora muttered. She checked on the others, all drifting back off. *Tavor's having trouble sleeping again,* she noted. *I should ask Shadow Weaver to ease up on his sorcery lessons.*

"Ah, Adora, you're awake, excellent," Shadow Weaver said, gliding in. All five cadets leaped to their feet, saluting. "At ease, all of you." The squad relaxed as one, Kyle even daring to yawn. "I know that you still have half an hour in your sleep cycle–"

"No trouble at all, Shadow Weaver," Adora blurted, straightening, "whatever you need."

Shadow Weaver smoothed out an unruly lock of hair. Adora forced herself not to flinch. "Such a good girl," she said, voice soft with that not-menace Adora had feared since… *No. I can't dwell on Catra. Not yet.*

Not until I can save her.

"I'm afraid I have bad news, however." Adora locked up, going pale, heart crashing in terror. The others all stared, eyes wide – even Tavor, a little. "The rest of you may come or stay, but Adora, you need to see this."

Adora followed, the others trailing behind her. *"A suggestion is just a sarcastic order,"* she remembered Catra quipping. They entered a room with two dozen seats all facing the far wall. A few yawning Force Captains filled less than half of them, Grizzlor and Octavia looking particularly bleary-eyed. Scorpia, on the other hand, was as chipper as ever. "Hey, cadets!" She waved.

"Scorpia," Shadow Weaver hissed. The Scorpioni gulped and turned. The cadets sat, and Shadow Weaver flipped a switch. Lights dimmed while a screen came to life on the wall.

It was footage of a battle. Five tanks, a full platoon of soldiers, and what looked like a hundred bots, were all fighting some golden blur – and losing. Badly. Adora's eyes widened. *Princess,* she realized. *With that speed, a new one. Angella's death-child just vanishes.* In the background, defenseless civilians screamed and fled. Most of them looked like farmers, spilling out of a transport the princess had wrecked. *Monster,* she thought with a scowl.

Then the princess slowed to human speed, and Adora's heart *stopped.*

It wasn't Catra, exactly. She was almost half a meter too tall, as muscular as Adora, dressed in a weird red top and blue boots inlaid with a ton of gold. She had her hairpiece back, except that was gold too. And her sword...it was unlike anything Adora had ever seen.

Balance must be restored.

The voice was gone almost before Adora realized it was there. She shook her head and focused, because whatever else changed, those eyes...blue and gold and Adora's concept of beauty...it *was* Catra. Her Catra.

And she was fighting the Horde. Worse, it was *effortless.* Catra was unstoppable, but not conflicted. At all.

Catra grabbed the last bot and smirked into its camera. "Hey, Shadow Weaver," she quipped, then stabbed the screen.

The image froze in mid-slice. Lights came back on, but Adora felt blind. She could hardly breathe. "This footage is three weeks old," Shadow Weaver reported. "After we were repulsed from Elberon and Erelandia, Lord Hordak sent Force Captain Dreer to Alwyn. Dreer is my oldest student in the Horde. He was specifically armed and prepared to deal with this new princess."

"What we did not know was that *she* was ready for *us."* Shadow Weaver's eyeslits narrowed at the picture. "Catra is a vicious, feral monster...but one thing she is not is stupid. With power like this, it is only a matter of time before the princesses approach her, if they have not already."

Adora shot to her feet. "No!" she cried. "Catra wouldn't – she'd never – I know she had problems, Shadow Weaver, but she'd never side with *princesses!"*

"Oh, Adora," Shadow Weaver sighed. "The evidence is before us. Catra has somehow *become* a princess. In all my years, I have only witnessed such power and ferocity from Queen Angella herself."

"Angella," Adora snapped, grasping the name like a lifeline. "She must have done something! Changed Catra, somehow!"

The Force Captains grumbled, but Shadow Weaver stroked her chin, considering. "It is...not impossible," she admitted. "Indeed, I wondered how a creature with her inherent lack of magical potential mastered that weapon so quickly." Then she shook her head. "That is neither the point nor the matter at hand. This is the result of but a single defection. All of you are to remain vigilant for further...malcontent, by order of Lord Hordak himself."

They all saluted, Adora lingering as the others filed out. She turned and stared at the image, transfixed. In an instant, conjecture became certainty. *They did something to Catra. Took her from us. From me.*

This time, I'm going to keep my promise. You'll see, Catra.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"How can she think she's bad?" Glimmer blurted, staring.

Wildcat shook her head at Leena, the little satyr girl giggling around Wildcat's legs, while Leena's mom – Hemli – apologized and tried to corral the child. "Wilykat! Wilykat!" Leena laughed.

"Wil*d*...cat," the magicat insisted, hands on hips.

"Do you think it'd be dangerous to tell Wildcat how cute she is?" Bow gushed, eyes shining.

Glimmer snorted. "You're my best friend. I'll buy you a tombstone." Bow gulped and nodded.

"Leena!" Hemli finally snapped, while her husband stood back and hid a chuckle behind one hand. "Poltan, don't you dare," the woman added, and his chuckling stopped. Leena froze, eyes wide.

"It's okay Miss Hemli," Catra said, the sentence almost all one word as it came out. She ruffled Leena's hair. "Get going, kid, your mom wants you."

"Bye Wilykat!" Leena laughed, running towards her mother.

Catra bristled. "WILDCAT!" she hissed. The people of Greenfield chuckled almost as one.

Bow cleared his throat. "So. You never told us what the Sword said."

Wildcat's eye twitched. "No. I didn't." She huffed and looked away. "It'll cooperate until Adora gets out. After that, you can deal with her."

"Ca–Wildcat," Glimmer corrected, sighing at Wildcat's sharp glance, "have you thought that maybe we'd want you to stay even without the Sword?"

Wildcat snorted. "No." Bow's eyes went wide and sad again, but Glimmer just drew herself up. *This is not okay.* She took a breath to argue, but Wildcat went very still. Then one ear twitched. She whirled to face Greenfield's people. "Tanks!" she cried.

The villagers only panicked a little, retreating in something almost like good order. Wildcat looked at the gem in the Sword hilt. "Time to keep your end of the deal," she muttered, then stabbed it skyward. "I. *Am.* SHE-RA!"

It was amazing to watch. Wildcat transformed into a *princess,* wearing a sleeveless red dress with a gold moon-burst and trim – including shoulder pads that looked as deadly as her claws. Skin-tight shorts underneath the skirt protected her modesty. Knee-high blue boots with more gold trim, golden bracers, and a golden mask framing her face completed the ensemble.

Then Wildcat – She-Ra – became a blur, slicing through the tanks like Glimmer through cake. Glimmer looked at Bow, who tugged her backwards. “Should we help?” Glimmer asked.

“When she slows down?” Bow ask-answered. They turned their attention back to the...well, “battle” would be generous.

Then there was an explosion of blood-red lightning and crawling darkness. The blast threw Wildcat back, and she howled, flipping in the air and using her claws to brake herself. Someone slammed a tank hatch open, and a massive ursid climbed up. A skywing elf strode out from behind the tank, conjuring darkness-born magic circles. Another elf-like figure took shape from the shadows around him. “Ah, Catra,” the shadow-woman drawled. “Still clinging to...pretensions, I see.”

Wildcat shook herself off and stood, crouching with the Sword held out to slash. “Shadow Weaver,” she retorted, her grin feral. “I’d call this taking me seriously, but you’re hiding in Horror Hall, and you sent these two idiots.” She pointed at the ursid and the boy-elf. “What, you like seeing people who *aren’t* me get beat up?”

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other again. She pointed at the elf. He nodded and pointed at the ursid. Glimmer teleported behind the Horde forces. Bow did that thing where he just...vanished. “Surrender, Catra,” Shadow Weaver said, the mocking drawl giving way to snarled command. “I might spare this pathetic village if you do.”

“My name...is *Wildcat!”* She-Ra turned into a blur again, but this time, the attacks were more methodical. She stabbed a tank or smashed through a group of bots, then zipped back when the shadow-lightning lashed out for her.

Gotcha! Glimmer cheered, teleporting on top of the Shadow Weaver...shadow...and blasting it with all her magic. It screamed and vanished. “Hah!” Glimmer laughed, punching some Horde soldiers who flailed at her in terror.

Then the elf guy grabbed her in an invisible grip, shadow-circle pulsing. *Telekinesis!* Glimmer realized, thrashing, but some other magic surrounded her as well. *I can't teleport!*

"Hey, Dreer."

The guy holding her screamed just before She-Ra punched him hard enough to send him flying into the ursid, who was already caught in a net arrow. "Hey, Grizzlor," she added, voice flat, and punched him in the gut. Then she stabbed down, putting her Sword through the engine. The tank died. "Run. Now."

They ran. Wildcat's snarling crouch melted away when Grizzlor picked up a few of his fallen soldiers. "Huh. When did *he* catch feelings?"

Glimmer, freed the moment Wildcat had punched Dreer, hugged her. The magicat bristled, dropping out of She-Ra an instant before Glimmer let her go. "Sorry. Just...y'know, thanks!"

She huffed and looked away. "You helped me first. I'm not so much of a jerk I was just gonna leave you there." Bow swung over and landed next to Glimmer. The two grinned at each other, plan forming in an instant, and they smiled at Wildcat as one. Her eyes widened, tail lashing. "S-stop it! This is *not* because I like you."

"Yeah, it's totally because you like us," Bow replied. "Best Friends Squad for the win!"

Wildcat and Glimmer both stared at him. "Yeah, never calling us that," Wildcat quipped.

"I was thinking...the Glimmer Group," the princess replied.

Wildcat stared at her. "How did you come up with something worse than 'Best Friends Squad?'"

Bow squeed. "You heard her! It's official – Best Friends Squad forever!"

Wildcat spluttered. “I did not say that! What is wrong with you people?” Glimmer laughed in spite of the ‘loss,’ watching Wildcat and Bow argue over squad names. *Best Friends Squad, huh? Yeah, we’re gonna win in the end.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“You don’t even have fangs,” Wildcat muttered. “How do you drink blood?”

Glimmer and Bow stared at Wildcat in horror. Queen Angella’s jaw dropped. “I do not – partake of anything that was once living!” she objected. “Unless one counts eggs,” Angella added, looking a bit thoughtful.

“Wildcat! You can’t just talk about people having fangs!” Glimmer blurted.

“Really?” Wildcat blinked, probing her own fangs with her tongue. “How do you manage without ‘em?” She turned back to examine Angella. “Oh, what’s an egg?”

Bow gasped. “We need to get her to the dining hall, stat!”

“Master Bow,” Angella sighed. He gulped and stopped talking.

“At least she’s the one with a brain,” Wildcat quipped. Glimmer swayed in place. *I should stop before I kill her,* the magicat thought. “Sorry, Your Majesty,” she continued in a sorry-not-sorry tone. “My closest contacts the last few months have been a little girl and a giant beetle.”

Angella shook out her wings. “A giant beetle.”

“Leena named him Fred. No idea why.” Wildcat shrugged.

“And you are She-Ra,” the queen whispered.

That stopped Wildcat cold, jaw going slack. “How...”

"The Sword," Angella explained, waving at the hilt peeking out from Wildcat's back. "I know the legend of the warrior called She-Ra. They said she would return to us in the hour of our greatest need to bring balance to Etheria." She descended from her throne, towering over the normal-sized Wildcat, looking her over. "You would pledge to stand with us against those you once served?"

Wildcat frowned. "I've been 'standing against' them for months now, and I didn't 'serve' them, I was property." Angella's gaze was, in spite of somehow being the exact opposite of Shadow Weaver's, just as intense. "But yeah, allies against a common foe, like Glimmer said. Sounds good."

"While hardly an oath of fealty, that will suffice for now," Angella conceded. "So long as you are an ally of Brightmoon, you are welcome in this castle." She smiled at Bow. "Now, I believe there was mention of the dining hall?"

"Yes! Let's eat!" Glimmer cheered, grabbing Bow and Wildcat.

"GLIMMAH–" Angella began.

Then, after the world got swirly again, Wildcat was surrounded by smells unlike anything she'd ever known. Glimmer fell onto a bench. "Whoo. My first time with three people. I'm just gonna...sit here for a minute."

"I'll grab us some dinner," Bow offered, rushing toward the kitchen.

"Those smells are *food?"* Wildcat blurted. "I mean, I got my claws on contraband a few times, but–"

"Try this!" Bow offered, shoving a plate towards her. There was delicious-smelling pink stuff, delicious-smelling yellow stuff, and...decent-smelling green stuff. "Salmon with potatoes *au gratin* and seasoned green beans."

Wildcat tried a bite of the pink stuff. Her eyes almost exploded, it was so good.. *Oh, I'm stuck with 'em,* she realized.

Wrong Turn

Chapter Summary

> Adora comes for the Rebellion. Catra has a plan. Shadow Weaver, alas, has a better one.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Bow!" Glimmer whispered.

Bow looked up from his his latest work, a flare arrow to bring down shadow-puppets, to blink at Glimmer. "Why are you whispering?" he asked.

Instead of answering, Glimmer grabbed his shoulder and teleported them just outside the library. "Sh," she said, finger over lips. Bow rolled his eyes and followed her in.

He froze at the cutest sight ever – and after a year of Wildcat, that was saying a lot. She was curled up on the largest table in the mail hall, a book fallen open beside her.

Wildcat's sketch book. Bow's eyes went even wider. "That's…" he whispered. Glimmer nodded and tugged him over. He looked at the open pages to find a group image of the Princess Alliance, the Best Friends Squad front and center. "She's really good."

"I know, right?" Glimmer gushed quietly, carefully closing the book – then opening it to the first page.

"Glimmer," Bow objected. The page was covered in clearly older sketches, most of them self-portraits. None of them were especially flattering, though her talent was clear even then.

"This may be our only chance," Glimmer replied, flipping through the pages. The first several were of the Best Friends Squad,

Wildcat usually drawn with her signature glare at various Brightmoon antics. She was there helping Glimmer nab some cookies, then catching Bow from falling after a failed grapple arrow. One was captioned 'why do I put up with them?' as Glimmer and Bow held each other and screamed at the sight of 'Fred' the super-beetle. Glimmer's smile faded until they got a few pages further, finding a two-page spread of them fighting off a Horde phalanx. Perfuma and Mermista were throwing tanks around, while Bow fired paste arrows to provide cover for She-Ra, and Glimmer helped Micah with a spell circle. "She drew those glyphs perfectly," Glimmer realized, fingers tracing along the circle.

"I think she has perfect visual memory," Bow suggested, turning the page before he could stop himself. *We...really shouldn't,* he thought, but kept going anyway. Wildcat had gone to colored pencils by then, and Bow could almost smell the greenery around the Heart Blossom. Her portraits of Perfuma had captions like 'too pure for this world' and 'how is anyone nicer than Adora?' One had a Wildcat head sticking her tongue out, but another was Wildcat's defense of Perfuma when Shadow Weaver had tried to use shadow-puppets to kidnap her.

The next section was of Salineas, as beautiful as Plumeria in its own way. Somehow, Wildcat's art made Mermista's perpetually-bored expression flattering. Notes included 'at least this one's cool' and 'what does she see in him?' – the latter a reference to Sea Hawk. Wildcat had done a smiling headshot of him, except his mustache was glowing like She-Ra's Sword. Two pages recounted the attack on the Sea Gate, with Wildcat fighting Octavia while the others dealt with the rest of the Horde attack.

Mystacor was next, and the drawing of the floating island was almost loving. After that, Wildcat had recorded Castaspella's lessons in exacting detail. The first art of Shadow Weaver herself made an appearance, one image towering over a quivering cat-girl who had to be young Catra, the other fleeing in terror from a She-Ra with an evil smirk. Castaspella had only one caption: 'I guess she's okay.'

Then came Beast Island, and a whole section on its creatures. Pookas, giant beetles, flame-bats, signal vines, and giant serpents were all magnificently detailed. Micah's image was downright amazing, and even the expression on art-Wildcat was more resigned than anything when Micah hugged her. That one was captioned 'learning magic = totally worth it.'

After that came a character study of Angella. Bow found it fascinating to watch the art of the queen evolve from a towering, imperious figure to a mix of humorous encounters and warm kindness. One was the group hug of Glimmer's family reunited. Another was Angella hugging Wildcat, saying "thank you" while Wildcat's ears and tail shot up. Inevitably, one was a headshot of Angella shouting "GLIMMAH!" – spelled just like that. "Is it me," Glimmer whispered with a grin, "or does Wildcat draw a lot of hugs?"

Bow nodded and turned the page, grinning back. A few pieces depicting a tiny old woman who was half made of hair, with enormous glasses and carrying a basket. 'Who is Razz?' one said, while another answered 'a crazy old witch, that's who.' They both chuckled. There was but a single page depicting Light Hope, though the one opposite had several transformations for the Sword. Light Hope had but a single caption: 'how does a hologram have a stick up her tail?'

The next section was a series of studies of Dryl and its princess, Entrapta – easily Wildcat's best friend outside of Brightmoon. Glimmer groaned at the 'this is a Dryl' pun over a long shot of Entrapta's castle. Another drawing was of Wildcat and Entrapta cackling over an exploding robot, while another Entrapta image had her hugging stolen/reprogrammed/adopted Horde drone "Emily." Finally, there was an image of Entrapta and the Best Friend Squad fighting Force Captain Scorpia and her formidable squadmates, Dylamug and Callix. Wildcat had drawn Dylamug's huge face with a ridiculous sneer, and Callix was marching like a robot, but Scorpia looked like some living engine of destruction – with an absurdly cheerful expression. The last drawing was of Wildcat and Glimmer laughing at Scorpia's squad fleeing, Callix

carrying Dylamug's torso while Entrapta examined the latter's limbs.

A series of images of Netossa and Spinnerella came next, and they seemed to express...curiosity, if Bow had to guess, the first art of them marked with 'what is a wife?'. There was art of the two competing to take down the most bots, Netossa smirking while Spinnerella rolled her eyes with a fond smile. Another had the two dancing in preparation for the upcoming Princess Prom. (Bow snickered at the handful of tiny Glimmers and Frostas beneath the wives, comparing the younger princesses: Glimmer was "smol" and "fyrc" while Frosta was "smoller" and "fyrcer".) The last had She-Ra glaring at a chagrined Netossa, who was holding an amused Spinnerella wrapped in...a net? The note just said: 'Spinny *wanted* this?'

Glimmer blushed worse than Bow had ever seen and turned the page. They both froze. Shadow Weaver finally got her due in a series ranging from mocking parody, where she was a stick figure in a weird, jagged-toothed mask, to sheer terror, where Shadow Weaver seemed like an evil counterpart to Angella. Black dragon's wings spread from her back, her hands were like claws, and a small Catra clung to another girl cowering from a demon ten feet tall. Even worse was the one drawing, erased and corrected so often the entire thing was mercifully blurry, where Shadow Weaver tortured Catra with crimson lightning. Catra's body convulsed in mid-air, her limbs bent at near-impossible angles, while Shadow Weaver reached out, hands grasping as if Catra's pain was not enough.

Bow flipped past the Shadow Weaver section, to find the next pages blank. "Still plenty of room," he whispered, preparing to close the book.

"Wait," Glimmer breathed, stopping him. "Where's her friend, Adora?" She went to the back, to find sketches of a muscular blonde with a large poof of hair and a wicked staff. Going back to front, the sketches improved. "She...left the whole other end for her," Glimmer realized, going through page after page. There were

several pieces of the two sparring. ‘Even these odds, Lonnie’ captioned a picture of Catra stomping another girl into the ground. One was of that same girl and a lizard-man using Adora as a battering ram, charging at Brightmoon with the blonde’s hair poof and large forehead labeled ‘ultimate weapon?’. A stick-figure boy trailed behind, arms waving in the air. Bow snickered.

The last few pages were far more detailed, each one increasingly defined. They were all straight character pieces, Adora laughing, eating a brick-shaped bar like a madwoman, doing staff drills, standing at attention, sleeping in a painfully plain bunk. Tucked in a corner was a small Adora missing a tooth and a Catra hiding in a blanket, labeled simply, ‘You promise?’ ‘I promise.’ Glimmer looked up. “They promised to...what was it, again?” she muttered.

“‘You look out for me,’” Wildcat growled, Glimmer and Bow leaping back with a yelp, “‘and I look out for you. Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other.’ It was the only Horde lie I ever believed.” She snatched the sketchbook away and snapped it shut. “I don’t have a good track record with promises.” Wildcat waved the book in the air. “For example.”

“Wildcat we’re sorry–” Bow began.

“It wasn’t in your room–” Glimmer blurted. They looked at each other, chagrined.

Wildcat snorted and leaped to her feet, holding the book away from them. “I should’ve known better. And yeah, looking at the group shot was totally fair. But you said this was *mine.”*

“It is!” Glimmer insisted. “It’s just, there’s so much you don’t tell us, and we worry about you.”

Bow sighed, guilt pressing down his shoulders. “That doesn’t make it okay, though. Wildcat, you have every right to be mad. Is there any way we can make it up to you?”

Wildcat’s eyes narrowed, then she looked away, tail lashing. “You’d better keep the important promise. When Adora has the

sword, I get to keep my room."

Glimmer spluttered in horror. "Wildcat," Bow jumped in, "it wouldn't be a Best Friend Squad without you."

Wildcat's cheek-fur flattened. "Whatever," she mumbled, darting out.

Glimmer swallowed. "So, uh, how mad do you think she is at us?"

Bow didn't have an answer for that.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora followed dutifully as Shadow Weaver led her down the corridor. "Lord Hordak has been watching you. He thinks you are a fine candidate for Force Captain." *Catra's defection has proved more fruitful than I dreamed,* the sorceress mused.

"Really?" Adora blurted. "Force Captain? Lord Hordak said that about me?"

"Oh yes," Shadow Weaver assured her. "He sees great promise in you. In fact, he has chosen you for the honor of leading a squadron against the rebel stronghold of Greenfield."

"Catra's Greenfield?" Adora stared. "I mean, we're finally seeing active duty?"

"Indeed," Shadow Weaver continued, summoning the Force Captain badge. "Absent her constant distractions, your squad proved most effective in this latest simulation. Clearly, assigning Tavor to your unit was worth the sacrifice."

"Thank you, Shadow Weaver...but," Adora continued, and the hidden smile vanished, "Catra, she'll be there. Are you sure the others are ready for her?"

"I will join you in shadow form," Shadow Weaver assured her, straightening her hair. "And they will have you, the youngest cadet

ever to make Force Captain, leading them into battle." Adora swallowed and nodded. "Remember not to let the deceptions of the princesses lead you astray," she insisted, Adora nodding again. "They will make Greenfield seem harmless and defenseless, until the moment they descend upon you."

Adora straightened. "I'm ready, Shadow Weaver."

The smile returned. "I know, Adora. This is what I raised you for. Now is your chance to prove yourself." Adora pinned the badge in place. "With you at the forefront, we will...retrieve Catra, and crush the Brightmoon Rebellion once and for all. Do not disappoint me."

Adora swallowed. "I won't, Shadow Weaver."

The smile grew. "I know that as well, Adora."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Wildcat looked out over Greenfield, indulging in a soft hiss. *They're fine,* she noted, watching half the adults work while the other half played, along with most of the children. It looked peaceful and happy, still alien to Wildcat even after eighteen months free of the Horde. *I guess I just...wish I knew how this is enough for them.* She glanced back towards Brightmoon, even Wildcat's senses only able to pick up a hint of reflection in the distance. *There's, like, a castle barely five miles away. Sure, being royalty is work, but–*

Her hearing picked up tanks rumbling in the distance. Wildcat grinned. *Hey, Shadow Weaver,* she thought, darting into the woods and racing from branch to branch. Her smirk faded as she approached the Horde company.

Because it *was* a Horde company – half bots, true, but from the sound of them, the force was two hundred strong, complete with tanks and skiffs. *Trap,* Wildcat realized, grin vanishing, *one I can't avoid.* She pushed back her horror as the people of Greenfield heard the approaching units, panic starting to set in. *Breaking out*

the big guns, this time? Wildcat pressed the appropriate signal icon on her tracker pad and tucked it in her third favorite tree.

Wildcat's smile returned for a moment when she spotted Scorpia emerge from the tree line with her squad. *My favorite sparring partner,* she thought. Then the thought died at the sight of Dreer and his team. *Both of them?* Wildcat leaped back to her tree and raised the alert on her pad to its second-highest danger level.

By then, the people of Greenfield were in full retreat, a few screaming, but most accustomed to the attacks. Wildcat circled around to flank them–

Wildcat's blood became ice-water at the sight of Leena stomping towards Scorpia, the tiny satyr marching with a soldier's determination. *Oh crap!* Wildcat gasped, transforming her bracer into the Sword and holding it high. "I. *Am.* SHE-RA!" she cried.

And she was.

She-Ra became a living thunderbolt, slicing through tank cannon and scattering bots in a rush. Even Wildcat's hearing wasn't enough to make everything out given her speed, but she knew the commanders were shouting orders to target the Champion of Power. She smirked again. *Take your best shots, losers–*

Wildcat was furious with herself for being even the least bit surprised when crimson lightning and grasping shadows struck at her from the earth. *Flark. Serves me right for getting distracted,* she cursed herself. "Ah, Catra," Shadow Weaver drawled, her voice coming from every direction. "As foolish and predictable as ever."

"She-Ra!" Leena cried.

With a roar of absolute fury, Wildcat erupted in golden power, throwing off both lightning and darkness. "Go!" she snapped at Leena, then rushed at Dreer. *Scorpia's too nice, she won't go after a kid,* She-Ra hoped. Shadow Weaver's spell had reduced her speed enough for Dreer to scream and dive for cover behind a

tank. Wildcat slashed through the tank's treads and armor with the Sword, strength unaffected by the dark spell.

Scorpia attacked on cue, leading with her tail, then trying to grapple. Even without her light-speed, Wildcat was still the fastest creature on Etheria, dodging both attacks and kicking the princess in the gut. "With the Rebellion, and I'm still fighting princesses," she quipped. "My life is weird."

"I'm the only princess in the Horde," Scorpia objected, one eyebrow raised.

"Really?" Wildcat said, smirking as she hopped back. "I could've sworn Callix was the tiara type."

The rock-man took the bait, howling and charging. "Don't Callix she's baiting you–" Scorpia warned. His eyes bulged just before She-Ra slammed a fist into his gut, leaving Callix on his knees, rocky shell cracked. Another sorcerer fired a bolt at She-Ra. Wildcat indulged in another smirk, transforming the Sword into a shield and deflecting the blast.

That was when Lonnie threw open the hatch on the tank beside the sorcerer and leaped out wielding a combination staff/stun baton, crackling with red electricity. Catra froze. "Lonnie," she whispered.

It was Lonnie's turn to smirk. "You afraid of me, *princess?"* She fired a stun blast at Catra.

She-Ra deflected the bolt with the Sword, changing it back. "Don't be more stupid than you can help, Lonnie," Wildcat snarled. *That's right, I'm not Catra any more,* she told herself. "My name is *Wildcat.* Where's Adora?"

Adora emerged from the tank, carrying a stun staff. "Catra," she whispered. For an instant, everything – Greenfield, the invasion, the Rebellion, the Horde – all faded away. Mismatched eyes met blue, and Catra remembered thinking of Adora every time she watched a storm give way to skies the color of home.

Then Adora kept talking. “Catra, whatever I did, I’m sorry, but this isn’t you, it *can’t* be!”

She-Ra shook off her tunnel vision with a snarl, darting away from Scorpia’s tail. “It’s what you didn’t do, Adora,” Catr–Wildcat retorted, driving Scorpia back with a speed-boosted punch. *Speed’s still weak, but it’s better than nothing.* She circled around her old squad as Rogelio and even Kyle emerged from the tank, the sorcerer standing with them. “You know what Shadow Weaver did to me.”

“Nothing you didn’t deserve, beast,” the sorcerer spat. Adora rebuked him with a shove. “What?”

“Right, a five-year-old deserved to be electrocuted once a week,” Wildcat sneered. Adora paled. “We gonna do this or what? Since Adora’s obviously okay with terrorizing civilians now–”

“We’re here to liberate them!” Adora shouted.

“Wow,” Leena said, peeking from behind a log. “You’re really stupid, aren’t you?” Catra couldn’t help a snicker.

“The princesses did something to you,” Adora pleaded, lowering the staff and taking a step towards her. “Catra, please, I know you’re better than this.”

“Catra died the day I left. My name is Wildcat.” She pointed the Sword at Adora. “And I am She-Ra, Champion of Power.”

Adora grimaced, taking another step. “It’s that Sword, Catra,” she continued, holding out her hand. “You can fight this. Just give it to me, and we can all go home.”

Wildcat blinked. *Wait, is it gonna be that easy?* she wondered. *We have an arrangement, Catra of Brightmoon,* Light Hope reminded her through the Sword.

Relax, Light Brite, Wildcat quipped. *I keep my promises. Besides, this is too good a chance to pass up.* She spun the

Sword in her hand. “Okay,” she agreed, and rushed to Adora’s side.

Adora stared at her, mouth slightly agape. “Wait, what?”

Then Catra slapped the hilt in Adora’s hand, and everything went sideways.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora looked around. The world was gone, replaced by some blue and purple nightmare of princess crystal. A tall blue lady who looked wrong somehow stood before her. When Adora swing her staff at the lady, it flashed through her. “Hologram. Great,” Adora groaned.

“You have been chosen, Adora,” the holo-lady insisted.

“The Horde chose me!” Adora said, focusing on Shadow Weaver’s training. *It’s not real, remember who I am,* she reminded herself.

“The Horde has disrupted the balance,” holo-lady replied, flickering around her. Images of war and flame appeared in every direction. “Etheria needs a hero. Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?” *No – it’s tricks, lies –*

Crimson lightning kept her senses grounded. “Light Hope, stop! You’re hurting her!” Catra cried in the distance.

Adora permitted herself a faint smile. “She’s not yours, ‘Light Hope,’” the blonde smirked, “not yet.”

“The magicat was not chosen,” Light Hope said, appearing in front of Adora. The soldier yelped, leaping back. “Her ability to channel the She-Ra is an...anomaly. You are the rightful Princess of Power.”

Somewhere, Catra groaned. “I will *never* be a princess,” Adora snapped.

“This isn’t working, Light Hope!” Catra cried from somewhere. “Stop telling her who you think Adora is and *talk* to her!”

Shadow Weaver’s chuckle echoed as if from deep below. “Too late,” the sorceress whispered.

Crimson thunder lashed out and broke the spell.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

As Adora threw the Sword aside and fell to her knees, Catra – Wildcat – rushed towards the blonde, all danger forgotten. “Light Hope, I swear, if you hurt her I’m going to take the Sword and shove it in the biggest processor I can find–”

The magicat yelped and dodged Scorpia’s tail with half a centimeter to spare. “Wow, you’re nicer than I thought,” Scorpia said, almost smiling.

Wildcat scowled back, claws flared. “Trust me. *I’m not.”*

“Tavor!” Adora cried, clutching her head. The sorcerer with Lonnie fired a shadow-bolt at Wildcat. She was able to dodge that, but Scorpia lashed out with her stinger, and Lonnie fired stun bolts, and Shadow Weaver’s puppets swarmed, and Dreer joined in with more lightning, and without She-Ra there were too many, too loud, too *much*–

Fred charged through, shielding her from the lightning and baton fire. “Fred?” Wildcat groaned, shaking her head to regain her bearings. Fred went claw-to-claw with Scorpia, the two a match in strength, and the Scorpioni princess’ tail unable to pierce his armor. He pushed Scorpia back with his greater bulk, then body-checked her aside and turned towards Shadow Weaver. Fred unleashed an ululating roar, bracing to charge.

Before even Wildcat could move, a tank blast echoed across the battlefield. The magicat froze as Fred collapsed, a neat hole cutting through him from head to tail. “Fred!” Wildcat screamed, rushing to the giant beetle. It was no use; even if she had the

Sword, no magic could help. "You *killed* him!" She hunched down, snarling, pushing aside how stupidly outnumbered she was–

"Wildcat!"

Glimmer was everywhere for a few seconds, grabbing the Sword before punching Tavor, kicking Lonnie, and blasting Scorpia. Bow fired goop arrows into bots and soldiers. Micah and Perfuma focused on the literal heavy artillery, his sorcery and her vines taking out the tank cannons.

"You!" Adora snarled, focusing on Glimmer. She forced herself to her feet, firing stun bolts as she stalked towards both magicat and princess.

Glimmer teleported them back to Leena, who cheered. "Sorry we're late," Glimmer said, her smile wavering. "Does this make up for it? And, y'know, the sketchbook. Thing."

Wildcat took the Sword., "It's a start, Sparkles." Glimmer grinned at the nickname. "Can you stall them? I'm gonna need a minute."

Glimmer's grin turned fierce. "We're going to do a lot more than *stall* them, She-Ra." She vanished in a cloud of glitter.

"Do the thing!" Leena cheered.

Wildcat groaned. "Get back to your mom, Leena," she ordered.

Leena pouted. "But–" she began.

"GO!" Catra yowled, claws out and fangs bared as she pointed to the retreating civilians. Leena gasped, eyes wide. She stared for a second, shaking, then ran for the woods.

Catra sighed, ducking behind the log for cover. *Great, Catra. That's perfect. You can't scare Force Captains, but you can manage little kids just fine.* She groaned again. *And I'm calling myself Catra again after three minutes around Adora. And Fred's*

gone. D'ast. Catra glared at the Sword. "Okay, Bright Dope, get out here and talk."

Greenfield rushed away as Light Hope's creepy holo-brain-chamber appeared around Catra. "There is nothing to discuss. You must continue to serve as She-Ra."

Catra froze. *What? I – I can still be – no!* She shook her head. "Oh no you don't, Lite Brite. We had a *deal.* I protect the Sword and the Rebellion, and *you save Adora.* I held up my end, so *get to work!"*

"I...misjudged Shadow Weaver's influence," Light Hope admitted.

Catra rolled her eyes. "Oh, wow, it's not like anyone warned you about that *oh wait."*

"I am aware of my error. Adora is still required," Light Hope continued, flickering red for an instant. "I will assist you to the best of my functionality." She looked at Catra for a long moment, turning a deeper blue for an instant. *That's new,* Catra realized. "My systems calculate that the power of She-Ra has deemed you worthy. Did you not want this?"

Catra froze, tail lashing. "Observations indicate that you are conflicted. Based on current data, you no longer need to decide between liberating Adora and remaining She-Ra," Light Hope reported. "Will you fight for the honor of Grayskull?"

Catra scoffed at that. "Never heard of it." She held the Sword high. "I. *Am.* SHE-RA!"

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer rushed across the battlefield, fighting her fatigue as much as the Horde, punching soldier after soldier with sparkling fists. Bow had literally pasted Shadow Weaver's creepy students to tanks after Glimmer pummeled them, but Scorpia was way too fast for someone that big, and Adora was every bit as skilled as Wildcat had warned them–

– which she proved by grabbing Glimmer's arm when she teleported in to attack! The Force Captain spun Glimmer through the air, slamming her into the ground. The air erupted from the princess' lungs, and Adora stood over her, stun staff poised to strike. "You," she growled.

Glimmer bared her teeth, unable to push away the memory of the shattered Fred. "Yeah, *me,"* she snapped.

"I. *Am.* SHE-RA!"

Glimmer swore she heard music as Wildcat transformed back into the Champion of Power, though her shorts were now leggings that reached her blue and gold boots. "Whoa," Glimmer breathed. (Note: Catra's transformation music is this awesome remix I found: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=c3oU4LJVLx8) Even as She-Ra became the now-familiar rainbow blur – *Wait, is she slower?* Glimmer wondered – Shadow Weaver's magic lashed out, trying to blast her.

It didn't work. She-Ra smashed through every one of the bots, scattered the troops, and dispelled whatever the sorceress was doing to project herself from the Fright Zone. Dad countered Shadow Weaver's magic, while She-Ra stopped several feet away from Perfuma and Scorpia, who were – just looking at each other? "Perfuma! Stop staring at her pecs and plant-punch her!" Glimmer objected.

"Relax, Petals," She-Ra added, grabbing Scorpia's arm, "I got this." Scorpia yelped as She-Ra threw her into Dylamug and Callix, the trio collapsing into a heap. Perfuma blushed and drove back most of the remaining troops.

Adora tore her staff from a paste arrow trap and turned towards Bow with a scowl. Glimmer teleported to Bow's side, ready to fight the Force Captain, but She-Ra sliced through the staff before the rest of them could do anything.

Then Wildcat and Adora stared at each other, neither moving. "Catra," Adora whispered, scowl vanishing.

Wildcat winced, tail lashing. "You gonna take the Sword, Adora?" she asked.

Adora's expression hardened, setting into a defiant glare. *"Never,"* she insisted.

She-Ra sighed. "Okay." She grabbed Adora, there was a blur, and the blonde was wrapped in paste and a tarp Wildcat had appropriated from somewhere. "Hey, Rogelio! Got a package for you!" She tossed the Force Captain into the air. Adora yelped.

A lizard-man grabbed the captain out of the air, hissing at Wildcat. She-Ra smirked. "Hey, any time you and Kyle wanna defect, they'd be happy to take you. He could even be your boy-toy back in Brightmoon."

Not only did Rogelio and a blond boy blush, so did Adora. "Catra!" the boy whined. Wildcat cackled.

"Retreat!" Scorpia cried, and the Horde soldiers fled. She-Ra watched, turning the Sword back into her bracer as the people of Greenfield cheered.

"That – was – amazing!" Glimmer cheered with them.

Wildcat let out a tiny, distressed whine and looked at Fred. "Not amazing enough," she muttered.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"I can't believe you buried a beetle," Sparkles mumbled.

"A giant beetle," Micah corrected. "Back on Beast Island, he would've been a month of food."

Catra shrugged. "Yeah, but...I mean, he wasn't exactly my friend, but...I dunno. Fred bailed me out. It felt...right." She exhaled,

long and tired, and looked away. “And...you guys can call me Catra, I guess. If you want.”

Glimmer and Bow stared at Catra, shocked. “But...what about leaving Catra in the past?” Bow asked, taking a step closer. “Shadow Weaver, the bullies, the Horde?”

Catra bowed her head. “Yeah. All it took was one look at Adora and I wasn’t Wildcat any more. Shadow Weaver got to her, and I...I let it happen,” she muttered.

Micah scowled. “You did no such thing, Wil – Catra,” he retorted.

“She must make her own peace with the universe,” Perfuma added with a nod.

“I *promised,”* Catra whispered.

“Hey,” Sparkles blurted, teleporting into Catra’s face. “Quit it.” Catra hissed. Sparkles ignored her. “She never kept her promise,” the princess began.

“We were kids,” Catra blurted.

“Don’t care,” Sparkles huffed. “You tried to reach her. You spent a year with the most awesome magic on Etheria, and as soon as Adora showed up you tried to give it to her to save her, even though you were afraid we’d get rid of you. Which is stupid, by the way!” Glimmer yelled, poking Catra in the shoulder. “Even if we weren’t best friends, *which we are,* General Juliet’s never seen a strategist like you. Juliet!” Sparkles threw her hands into the air. “Not to mention, you are ridiculously awesome in a fight even without the Sword! And you’re, like, the only girl friend I had before *you* started getting me to be friends with the other princesses! What do I have to do to convince you I don’t *ever want you to leave?”*

Catra stared for a long moment. *She – she...* Catra hugged a stunned Sparkles. “You’re all right, you know that...Glimmer?”

The princess sniffled. “You called me Glimmer,” she gasped.

Catra chuckled through a sob. “Don’t get used to it – Sparkles.”

Glimmer sniffled through a laugh. “And you ruined it,” she said, clearly not meaning it, “Wildcat.”

Catra laughed outright. “Fair,” she admitted. She let Glimmer go, looking grave again. “You would’ve been better off with her, you know,” she said. “I would’ve been evil, but Adora would’ve won this thing for you.”

“Maybe not, Catra,” Bow said. “So maybe she finds the Sword in a year, and maybe you stay, but without you, would the Rebellion have won anything yet? Or rescued Micah? Or united the princesses?”

“Except Frosta,” Catra pointed out.

“We’ll get her at Princess Prom,” Glimmer insisted, looping her arm through Catra’s. “Let’s go home, okay?”

Catra looked north. She couldn’t see the castle...but in a way, she *could,* shining and safe and – and *happy.* “Home,” she admitted, blinking back tears. “That sounds great.”

Chapter End Notes

I thought writing full-time (I don't have to go to the evil office Horde place EVER AGAIN YAAAAY!) would give me more time to write Turn Right Timeline stuff. Ha ha silly me.

Anyway, here it is. Catra and Adora finally meet again. Oh look it's Angst O'Clock again I gotta go.

All-Princess Brawl

Chapter Summary

> No matter how different the timeline, Frosta WILL host the Princess Prom. There, Adora is no match for Catra, no matter whose side each is on…but Shadow Weaver has plans of her own.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra's eye twitched as the hopeless dorks who were somehow her two best friends…

"I'm going with Perfuma," Bow explained.

"What!?" Glimmer exploded.

...made complete fools of themselves in front of each other. Catra slapped her forehead and groaned. Bow, somehow, was stupid enough to keep talking. "She asked and I said yes. I didn't think it would be a big deal."

"It's not. It's fine," Glimmer replied. *It's a stupidity contest,* Catra decided, wondering if jumping off the balcony was an option, *and they forgot to invite me. Or knew I'd lose.* Glimmer, meanwhile, kept digging. "I'm just surprised. When did you two even talk about it?"

"Oh, she was super slick," Bow insisted. Then he described the most un-slick pickup line in the history of Etheria. Catra fell back onto the bed, groaning again.

"That's super slick?" Glimmer retorted, making her first non-moronic statement since Bow's announcement.

"I thought it'd be fun," Bow explained. *I can't watch this any more,* Catra decided, getting up and walking towards the pair. "And Perfuma's cool."

"Yeah, she's fine," Glimmer said, and Catra died a little inside. "But we always go to events together. We have our whole routine. We wear matching outfits, we share inside jokes and then we eat ice cream aftrrmmph?" Catra's hand on Glimmer's mouth stopped the agony at last.

"Okay, no," Catra drawled.

Bow stared for a moment. "Uh, 'no,' what?" he asked. Glimmer let out a questioning grunt through Catra's palm.

"'Uh, no,' I'm not going to stand here and watch you two make an emotional suicide pact," Catra explained, then took her hand off Glimmer's mouth. "Glimmer, talk to him."

Glimmer stared at Catra. "I kinda was talking to him," she huffed.

"No, you were talking *at* him," Catra retorted, crossing her arms. "Seriously, it took me three months to figure out that you guys aren't dating–"

"What?" they both blurted.

"–and I didn't realize why until just now," Catra finished, shaking her head. "How did the two of you slow down the Horde by yourselves at sixteen when you're both this unbelievably *thick?"*

To Catra's eternal relief, they were both blushing. "It's not like that!" Bow blurted. Catra's hearing was sharp enough to hear Glimmer's heart shatter.

"W–we're best friends! That's all," Glimmer stammered out. "I mean, who wants to be a royal consort, right? And my Mom's super-scary about...you know, this stuff…" Glimmer looked away, voice fading to nothing, while Bow's eyes widened with the first signs of a clue.

Catra smirked. “I dunno. If you were my girlfriend, I’d deal with it.”

Glimmer met Catra’s eyes in amazement. “Y-you would?” The poor girl actually sniffled.

“Yeah. I mean, who wouldn’t think you’re worth it?” Catra let her smirk spread. “Besides, your mom’s not so bad, and I bet we’d turn every head at this Princess Prom thing…” she glanced at Bow moving only her eyes. “...unless Crop Top has something to say. Like, *right now.”*

“I...I didn’t think you liked me like that,” Bow whispered.

Glimmer’s jaw dropped. “What? How did you not think – you’re a genius, you’re the nicest boy in the world, and come on, abs!” she blurted, waving at the muscles in question. Both of their blushes deepened. “But me – I’m little, I’m angry, I’ve got half a Runestone–”

Bow took Glimmer’s hand. “You’re kind, you’re brave, and you never give up. Not when all of Etheria’s against you.” They froze, looking at Catra.

“About. Flarking. Time.” Catra smirked. “Don’t you worry about Petals, Bow. I think showing up with She-Ra on her arm ought to fix things with her.”

“Um...I hate to say this, after…” Glimmer held up their hands, still clasped, “this, but you can’t go as She-Ra. No weapons allowed.”

Catra blinked, then unsheathed her claws. “That’s gonna be kind of a problem, Sparkles,” the magicat pointed out.

“Oh! Natural weapons don’t count,” Glimmer added, pulling Bow closer. “I mean, we’re princesses. It’d be kind of hard for Spinnerella to not be around air, right?”

Catra chuckled and shook her head. “I’ll let you two make out now,” she said, retreating as the two stammered out things they

probably thought were words. *This is gonna be fun,* Catra thought, even her inner voice all in on the sarcasm.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra stared at Adora and Scorpia entered the Ice Palace. *Oh, this is going to be* so *much fun,* she thought, smirking. She glanced at Perfuma, who was ogling Scorpia while trying to still look dignified. "Good idea, Petals," Catra said.

Perfuma turned back towards Catra and blushed. "Wh-what?" she stammered.

"We need to keep an eye on them," Catra explained. "You watch Scorpia. I'll keep an eye out for Adora," she continued, wiggling her ears, "and other senses for their squadmates."

"Oh! R-right," Perfuma agreed, heading for Scorpia with just the slightest quiver in her step.

Catra watched for long enough to be sure that was interest rather than fear – Mermista pivoted towards the flower princess, Sea Hawk trailing behind – then she smirked and sauntered towards Adora, hands in her jacket pockets.

"That's Frosta? But she's like, *ten!"* Adora blurted. Loud enough for the whole party to hear.

Catra was about to cackle when Frosta replied, voice colder than her ice palace, "I'm eleven and three quarters." The Champion of Power kept her reaction to a smirk. *Kid has respect issues. I get that.* Frosta laid down the law, Scorpia got them out of the mess, and the pair began to circulate.

Just before Catra could begin stalking them, Glimmer and Bow appeared beside her. It would be years before she would admit that the sound she made was a yelp of surprise and not a warning hiss. Seeing that they were still holding hands dampened Catra's frustration. "Catra, it's her!" Glimmer blurted, pointing at Adora.

Catra smoothed out her tail. "I noticed," she drawled, smoothing out her jacket for good measure. "Calm down. Adora's a tank in a straight fight, but she's useless with people." She glanced around. "New people. We need to keep an eye out for her squad, Lonnie, Rogelio – Entrapta?"

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other. "Uh, Entrapta's on our side," Bow said as gently as he could. "Aren't the–"

"Ugh, no, Entrapta's here," Catra groaned, "and it looks like she's alone." She glanced up at the balcony, where Entrapta watched the ball with intense eyes and a recorder in one hair tendril.

The Best Dorks Squad shared another look. "Princesses *can* bring a plus-one," Glimmer explained, "but we don't have to."

Catra swallowed a hiss. *Seriously, how did these people survive Hordak without me?* she wondered. "She's here, alone," Catra explained, trying to keep it simple, "and the Horde is here, too."

They finally got it. "Uh-oh," Bow blurted.

"Yeah," Catra sighed. "Look, I've got Perfuma watching Scorpia, and Misty's watching Perfuma. I need you two on Traps while I mess with Adora."

Glimmer's chuckle was almost diabolic, but Bow frowned. "That sounds kinda mean, Catra," Bow objected.

"She's with the Horde, Bow!" Glimmer retorted, fists on hips. "We've given her, like, every chance to figure out the Horde is evil!"

Catra grimaced. "She'll figure it out someday. Right now, we need to bury her chances with Frostbite. Just look out for Traps, okay?" Glimmer and Bow nodded.

Taking Adora apart was so easy, Catra almost felt sorry for her. Adora actually fell for her "Hey, Adora" note in the trash. Then Catra crept up on Scorpia, which almost had Adora leaping at

them. Instead, Catra held up a shrimp plate for the Horde princess. “Try these, Your Highness,” she offered with a smirk.

Scorpia, the poor thing, ate it up literally and figuratively. “Mmm! Mmm. Oh, these are so good. Adora, you have to try this.”

“Scorpia!” Adora cried, yanking the plate from the princess’ pincers. “Don’t eat anything Catra gives you, it might be poisoned!”

Catra cackled. “Always so *dramatic,* Adora. I wouldn’t poison Scorpia...here. I could get the Rebellion in trouble.” She waved while her former (still, still, still) best friend seethed.

While Adora and Perfuma glared at each other, Catra wandered through the halls, soon picking up the scents of her old squadmates. *Adora can’t do anything in front of everybody. This should only take a minute or two.* The Wildcat stalked through the corridors of Frosta’s palace, making note of actual guards while closing in on Lonnie–

The beeping sound made her freeze in a moment of true irony. She looked up, spotting the dim red light and soft rhythm that only her senses would notice at her distance. With a few leaps, Catra was able to reach it, claws dug into the ceiling ice.

Heat bombs.

Catra’s amusement died a brutal death. Heat bombs would cause widespread devastation through the entire castle. *Exactly what I would’ve done if I was still...* Catra couldn’t let herself finish the thought. She disarmed the heat bomb, then dropped down in front of a real guard. “Saboteurs in the castle,” she told him, shoving the heat bomb into his hands. “A tall, gray skywing elf, a big lizard-man, and two humans about my height – a muscular girl the color of my fur and a skinny boy as pale as your ice.”

The guard gaped at her. “N-now just a minute–” he began.

"That thing's a heat bomb, and they must've brought at least a dozen," Catra snapped, another guard heading towards them. A quick sniff told her it wasn't a Horde impostor. "Now move!"

The guards moved.

It took her three more minutes to disarm the remaining heat bombs, and by then the guards had cornered her squad-plus-Tavor. *Frosta's going to be embarrassed,* Catra thought, noting Lonnie and Rogelio holding off the Snow Kingdom's forces enough for Tavor to melt his way through the wall, Kyle his final 'defense.' Catra shook her head and leaped in, bouncing off Rogelio's head just like in practice, only to plant her feet in Lonnie's abs. "Hey, Lonnie," Catra drawled.

Lonnie glared up. "You!" she snapped, kicking up at her. Catra laughed and launched herself at Tavor, tripping Kyle with her tail, while the guards pinned the other two at last. The distracted sorcerer was the work of a single blow to bring down.

"You kids have fun," Catra smirked to the astonished guards, furious Horde soldiers, and embarrassed Kyle. "I've got a dance date."

She rushed back to the main hall just in time for the announcement just in time to pair back up with Perfuma. "Catra!" the petal princess gushed, as though Catra hadn't ditched her for almost half an hour. Catra had the good grace to feel bad. "Are you all right?"

"Fine, just making sure no one turns up the heat," Catra quipped, finding herself enjoying the dance with Petals. "You're good at this."

"Thank you, Wildcat," Petals replied, and Catra had to work not to purr. *Can't ruin Phase Three, business before pleasure,* she reminded herself.

Catra found herself dancing beside Glimmer, who was almost glowing even without her magic. "Thank you," she whispered, and

Catra's tail puffed out.

"N-no big deal," Catra mumbled. Then Glimmer laughed, spinning back to Bow, and Catra was with–

Adora. At last. "I don't know about you, Adora, but I am having a *blast,"* Catra quipped, dancing close to Adora (she wants this can't want it not allowed but oh stars how she does).

"Whatever it is you're planning, it won't work," Adora retorted, glaring.

"You sure?" Catra purred, leaning in close to Adora. "Because maybe," she continued, dipping Adora, the blonde held up only by Catra's arms, "it already has."

Adora grabbed Catra by her jacket. "What do you mean?" she demanded.

Catra leaned in, whispering in Adora's ear. "Where's your squad, Adora?"

Adora hauled Catra into the air. "What did you do to them?" she cried.

"Who, me?" Catra asked, pointing at herself with her tail. "I haven't done anything. Maybe you should ask our revered hostess, instead."

"What's that supposed to–" Adora began.

A wave of ice crashed into Adora, imprisoning her in a pyramid of sorts. Frosta glared at her with cold fury that impressed even Catra. "Princess Ball is a ceremony of unity. Violence is strictly forbidden."

"You don't understand," Adora pleaded.

Guards dragged Adora's squad over, more escorting a chagrined Scorpia behind them. "I understand perfectly," Frosta replied, her

voice colder than her palace. “As hostess, in accordance with the rules set down over the centuries, I hereby revoke your invitation. You are to leave my kingdom and never, ever return.”

Catra crouched beside Adora’s prison as Frosta marched off, giving orders to her guards. “Oops,” she mocked. “Maybe bringing the all-losers squad with a satchel full of heat bombs wasn’t the brightest idea, even for you.”

Adora’s eyes widened. “Heat bombs? I would never have–” the blonde stopped there, glaring at Catra. “You set us up,” she said, sounding angry, and a little heartbroken.

Catra slammed her claws into Adora’s frozen prison. “Me? I don’t pull Horde crap any–” again, Catra stopped, eyes going wide. “You’re the worst liar in the world,” she whispered.

“Exactly!” Adora demanded, punching the ice.

“But...if it wasn’t your idea,” Catra breathed, feeling colder than ever, “and it wasn’t my idea, then who...”

Every light in the palace dimmed. Familiar terror rushed through Catra. Glimmer and Bow appeared by her side, looking as worried as she felt. “Wildcat?” Glimmer asked.

“It’s her,” Catra gasped.

Lightning and shadows rushed into the chamber, and the screaming began.

“Princesses, protect the guests!” Catra ordered, throwing her jacket aside. “Everyone without magic, head for emergency exits, calmly!” She raced over to Frosta, dispersing lightning bolts with her meager sorcery. “Hey, Frostbite, where’s the Sword?”

“This – the All-Princess Ball is–” Frosta stammered.

“Under attack by Shadow Weaver,” Catra snapped, grabbing Frosta’s shoulders. “Look, I get it, my whole life was cowering

from her, but I won't let her hurt anyone else if you help me. Where's the Sword?"

"Chamber in the front kiosk where you checked it in," Frosta explained, almost calm.

Catra was all out of calm when she heard that, racing for the entrance while the princesses fought to defend the others. They weren't able to protect everyone, tendrils of shadow lashing everywhere, reaching for terrified civilians. *Stupid stupid STUPID!* Catra cursed herself, tears freezing behind her. Of *course* it was Shadow Weaver!

Who else thought like Catra in the Horde? Who taught Catra to think like that in the first place. The Rebellion Wildcat felt sick as she rushed to grab the Sword and save everyone.

When she got outside, Shadow Weaver was retreating into a tank, Sword in hand and Dreer at her side. Catra pivoted to rush at her, but a glance at the few remaining tendrils brought her attention to a flying scorpion thing with Adora, Scorpia, the rest of her squad–

–and Bow. Kind, brave, patient Bow, who never had a harsh word for Catra at her most vicious. The flying scorpion was just taking off. All of She-Ra's speed wouldn't help once it was in the air. That was Shadow Weaver's master stroke. A choice with no right answer.

The Sword, and She-Ra, or Bow, and the Rebellion's heart.

With a howl of frustrated fury, Catra raced towards Adora and the helpless Bow, hands tied and limp in Scorpia's arms. Lonnie's eyes went wide. "Adora! Get us up get us up get us UP–"

Catra reached them first. It was the farthest leap of her life, but she reached the flying monstrosity, clawing her way onto the small bridge.

Scorpia lashed out with her tail while Rogelio lunged. That one was almost too easy, Catra kicking the stinger into Rogelio. While

Scorpia gasped, Catra leaped onto Lonnie's head, kicking it into the console. Adora lunged while Tavor fired a bolt at Catra; the magicat dodged behind Adora, and the sorcerer stunned her. She grabbed Bow from Scorpia, who again lashed out with her stinger, but Catra was faster, leaping to get them both back to the ground.

Glimmer appeared beside them. "Bow!" she cried, throwing her arms around the archer and kissing him. "Thank you, Catra," she half-sobbed.

"No...prob…" Catra muttered, swaying. She looked down at her tail, which had an angry red welt on the end. "Heh. Good one...Scorp..."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Bow never felt so miserable in his life.

He knew it was partly because he'd come down from the greatest high of his life, dancing with Glimmer, his *girlfriend* Glimmer, while Catra made complete fools of the Horde and won over Princess Frosta.

If I'd just been a little more careful, we'd still have the Sword, and the war would be almost over, he thought, watching the unconscious Catra twitch. Only Glimmer's hand in his was any comfort.

"Ow…" Catra groaned, stirring. "My mouth feels like an ash pit."

"Catra!" they both cried, and the Best Friends Squad hug made Bow feel better in an instant. If Catra's purr was any indication, she felt the same way.

"The Sword?" Catra whispered.

"We will manage without it," Angella insisted as she walked in. Bow leaped to his feet, but Angella waved for him to sit. He did, grateful for the chance. "You are both still recovering from the Scorpioni's sting," the queen reminded him.

"You – you don't need me if I don't have the Sword," Catra said, managing not to whimper – barely.

Angella's lips tightened into a thin line. "Nonsense, Commander Catra," She crouched beside the bed. "Even had you not given us so much...restored the Alliance, recruited every Princess of Power, *saved Micah*…you are the greatest strategist in the Rebellion, and one of our finest warriors. Sword or no."

Catra stared, eyes wide as she purred again. It only lasted a moment, and the magicat sat up, shaking her head. "Me having the Sword doesn't matter. If Shadow Weaver turns Adora into She-Ra, the Rebellion won't last a year."

Glimmer huffed. "We can handle the blonde brick-brain," she insisted.

Catra groaned and facepalmed. "Sparkles, has Adora lost *one* engagement when I wasn't there?"

Glimmer looked away. "Salineas," she muttered, tone mulish.

"She wasn't in charge of that one, Glimmer," Bow reminded her as gently as he could.

"We'll get the Sword away from her," Micah said, the princesses behind him. "Shadow Weaver might be clever, but she's lost all understanding of teamwork or family." He strode over, placing a fatherly hand on Catra's shoulder. "I know what she's like, Catra. We'll save your friend."

"Look, I appreciate the thought," Catra muttered, sliding out of bed, "but I have to get the Sword back, now."

Angella took a breath to object, but Glimmer teleported to Catra's side first. "Okay. When do we leave?"

Catra's eyes widened in alarm. "'We?' Not a chance, Sparkles!" the magicat blurted. "The only way this'll work is if I go in alone, quick and quiet."

“Unless you get caught,” Entrapta pointed out. “Horde security tech is fascinating! But also dangerous.”

“We’re not letting you go there alone, angry cat girl,” Mermista smirked, arms crossed.

“Princesses stick together,” Perfuma agreed, smiling like the daymoon. Bow wasn’t sure he’d ever been more proud to be in the Rebellion.

Catra stared at them. “I’m not a princess!” she snarled, throwing her arms in the air. “I was the Champion of Power, and now I’m just a literal throwaway cat only Adora ever wanted!”

“No,” Frosta replied, striding to the front of the group. She crossed her arms, too. “I don’t know where this Champion thing came from, but the code of the All-Princess Ball is clear. She-Ra is the Princess of Power, and no matter what the Horde has done, you are She-Ra.”

“Face it, Wildcat,” Netossa joined in, Spinnerella holding her hand, “there’s no way we’re letting you do this alone.”

“You...guys…” Catra swallowed, blinking away tears. “Okay.” She smirked, some of the old Wildcat returning. “I guess it’s time for a little All-Princess Brawl.”

The cheer mended Bow’s wounded spirit.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora looked at the Sword, trying not to doubt Shadow Weaver, but afraid of her duty for the first time. “Are you sure, ma’am?” she whispered, jaw trembling a fraction. “That I’m not going to – to –”

“Turn out like Catra?” Shadow Weaver sighed and held her forehead in delicate fingers. “The very idea is absurd.” She activated the training room’s holograms, and bots became

princesses. “Scorpia is a princess, and loyal to the Horde. You can do the same.”

Adora took a breath, about to hold up the Sword. *But...* she wondered. “Then couldn’t we have won over Princess Frosta, Shadow Weaver?” she asked. “Why–”

In an instant, Shadow Weaver loomed over Adora. “Frosta doesn’t matter,” she snapped. Adora recoiled, desperate to control her fear. Her mentor regained her calm in moments, tucking an errant lock of Adora’s hair back in place. “Once Catra discovered my primary contingency, I was forced to resort to my backup plan. Is this not how I taught you to prepare?”

“But if we could have–” Adora tried again.

“Convinced Frosta?” Shadow Weaver sighed again, and Adora’s insides shriveled up. “Adora, dear, you are many extraordinary things, but I fear that a diplomat is not one of them.” Shame roared through Adora, remembering how easily Catra had taken her apart at the Ball. “Now. Raise the Sword. Say the words. *Claim your destiny.”*

“Yes, Shadow Weaver,” Adora agreed, surrendering and thrusting the Sword high. She imagined ‘Grayskull’ as the heart of Horror Hall, or Hordak’s sanctum. “For the honor of Grayskull!” Adora cried.

Power rippled around her, but did not flow into her the way it did Catra. Even so, Shadow Weaver straightened, hair quivering with excitement. “A reaction already,” she exulted. “Better than I hoped. Try again.”

Adora obeyed, repeatedly. She didn’t transform, but each time, the power seemed to surge more, come closer, flow deeper. Whatever ‘Light Hope’ might be doing weakened with each effort. “I – I think it’s working, Shadow Weaver,” Adora panted, teeth gritted with effort.

“Of course it’s working,” Shadow Weaver replied. “Again!”

A grapple line lashed out, grasping the Sword. “ENOUGH!” Catra roared, leaping into the room from a vent and pulling.

The attack caught Adora off-balance, but she held on anyway, barely clinging to the Sword. The hair princess, Entrapta, joined Catra and wrapped pigtails around Catra’s waist. Lights dimmed and klaxons blared, crimson lights flashing. The bizarre tug-of-war lasted a few more seconds, the grapple claws giving way before the people did. Catra and Entrapta stumbled back, those beautiful mismatched eyes going wide. “HA!” Shadow Weaver barked, blasting at the duo with garnet lightning.

Catra dodged, but Entrapta was too slow. The inventor screamed, at which point Catra did something utterly predictable to anyone other than Shadow Weaver, jumping into the lightning stream. “Catra!” Entrapta and Adora cried out as one, the princess reaching out with hand and hair.

To Adora’s amazement, Catra smirked. “Thanks, Shadow Heaver,” she quipped – then fired the grapple again. It conducted the electricity, surprising Adora enough that she lost her grip on the Sword. Catra caught it the moment the line retracted. *Catra,* was all Adora could think, amazed at her dedication even as the circumstances horrified Adora.

“NO!” Shadow Weaver wailed, redoubling her assault.

“Huh.” Catra convulsed in the cruel assault. “Turns out you really can get used to anything. I. AM. SHE-RA!”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“Adora is formidable,” Light Hope reported.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Yeah, and water’s wet. Got any other deep insights there, Lite Brite?”

“You must not lose the Sword again,” Light Hope replied, impassive as ever. “Until Adora can see the Horde for its evil, she

is the Rebellion's greatest foe. If she claims the Sword again, I will not be able to stop her from becoming She-Ra."

That analysis put Catra's sass in the same grave as her Princess Prom amusement. "Okay. That's actually useful. Terrifying, but useful. No pressure or anything."

Etheria came back into focus around them, and Catra transformed the Sword into a shield. "Mission accomplished, everyone. Time to go."

Shadow Weaver looked from klaxon to magicat. "You did this," she hissed, lightning bouncing away from the shield before she stopped firing.

"With a little help from my friends," Catra smirked. "The East Gate grew a weed problem, the furnaces have entered the ice age, and your sewers are revolting." Her smirk grew. "Almost as much as you." She scooped up Entrapta in a too-long arm – *well, not for She-Ra,* Catra thought – and smashed through the door shield-first. Shadow Weaver's scream of fury was the sweetest music.

Catra still sighed as Entrapta's hair snatched little bits of tech on their way out. *Not like I can go full speed with Traps under my arm, anyway,* she noted. Still, the plan had gone off without a hiccup.

Which meant it was time for things to go sideways.

Catra crashed through the final bulkhead, placing Entrapta on the skiff Bow had 'requisitioned,' when a racing shadow leaped at Glimmer. The princess yelped as the shadow became a bald, winged man, tall and muscular and clad in black Horde armor. His shadows lashed out like Shadow Weaver's, but Glimmer's scream told Catra that this guy's darkness magic was somehow more dangerous.

She-Ra plowed into him, knocking Baldy away from Glimmer. She nearly collapsed, barely hanging onto the skiff. Bow and Entrapta pulled her up, Entrapta steering while Bow held his girlfriend.

"Traps, go!" Catra ordered. "All forces, fall back to the rendezvous point!"

Baldy smiled. It made smirks look gentle. "Ah, the famous Catra, winner of the Blind War Games," he drawled, cracking his neck with a twist of his head.

Old memories came back, a cold pit settling in Catra's gut. "Vultak," she whispered. "You're supposed to be terrorizing civilians in the Meadowlands."

"You have inconvenienced the Horde one time too many, magicat," he replied, darkness swirling around his hands.

"That's me, Princess of Inconvenience," she agreed. Then they rushed at each other, darkness crashing into light. Their battle flashed across the bot-yards, speeds equal. *I could outpace him at full strength, but tanking Shadow Weaver's blasts took it out of me,* Catra admitted to herself. *Gotta disengage before the Best Dorks Squad comes back after me.*

Shoving down the terror, both for her friends and the realization of how much she loved them all, Catra came to a sudden halt, pivoting the shield to bash Vultak's face in. The buzzard was too fast, darting out of the way, but She-Ra turned it back into the Sword and flared light in all directions. Vultak screamed and recoiled, shielding his eyes. While the flash blinded everyone, Catra raced away. *Next time, though, I'm going to kick his tail up between his ears.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"You are not to engage with that – that *creature* again under any circumstances," Angella demanded, voice more shrill than Glimmer had ever heard it, "is that clear?"

Catra gave her a dubious glare. "That'll make it kinda hard to win a war when he's leading the other side," she pointed out.

“Mom,” Glimmer jumped in, “Catra only had trouble with him because Shadow Weaver gave her so much trouble. We can take him.”

Mom straightened, then slumped, wings drooping. Dad put an arm around her. “You don’t understand,” she whispered. “Vultak stalked me throughout the first Princess Alliance. His shadows were no match for my light, but so many others paid the price for his obsession. Ivy...Estra...Peekablue…” Angella shook her head. “As our daughter, he will likely target you more than any other.”

Catra’s eyes narrowed. “Sounds like I need to put this creep in the ground,” she hissed.

Bow stepped forward. “Your Majesty,” he replied, head high. “I’m just as worried for Glimmer as you and King Micah are, but I think we have to respect her courage and dedication.” Glimmer fell in love with him all over again. “We’ll just have to look out for each other, like we always do.” Glimmer took his hand, and the gentle squeeze she got in response made her feel invincible.

Angella collapsed into her throne, looking ancient even with her timeless features. “Just be careful,” she sighed. “All of you.”

Catra grinned. “I always am,” she said.

Outrage surged through Glimmer. “You never are!” she retorted. The other princesses all laughed.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver sealed her chamber door, then collapsed beside the Black Garnet, able to afford vulnerability at last. Drawing power from the great Runestone restored her eventually, but it was not enough.

It was never enough. And now Catra had defeated her – outwitted her, *Shadow Weaver* – in the heart of the Fright Zone. With a weary stride, she shuffled over to her viewing cauldron. “I need

leverage," she wheezed, pouring reagents into the pool of darkness. "Power, knowledge, hostages, something..."

A silhouette took form, slender and gentle. "What's this?" Shadow Weaver grimaced, glaring at the scrying pool. "Do you mock me now...oh. OH!" Shadow Weaver laughed.

And in the cauldron's image, Perfuma smiled...

Chapter End Notes

Woo-hoo! I've been looking forward to this one. It's a minor pet peeve of mine that in most Cat-Ra fics I've read, Adora suddenly turns into Catra and vice-versa at Princess Prom, so I wasn't having that. Still, I had to give our hero some challenges, and maybe some character growth?

Next time: Flowers for Hordak. Just how scary can Perfuma be, anyway?

Flowers for Hordak

Chapter Summary

> When Shadow Weaver targets Perfuma, who is in more danger: Plumeria's princess, or her friends?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"Now that we're done with the easy stuff–" Catra began.

Netossa snorted a chuckle. It was familiar enough to hurt. "You've got some weird ideas about 'easy,' Wildcat."

"–we can discuss the western front," Catra continued, eyes narrowing a fraction. The others chuckled while she zoomed in on the stupidly sparkly war map, keeping her eyes averted just enough to avoid being blinded by the thing. "Vultak slithered back to his Menagerie, but it looks like he's getting some heat from the Andreenids." She tapped the southern Meadowlands with a claw. "If there's any way to provide them support, we should."

Mermista leaned forward. "Salineas might be able to do something about that."

"Princess Sweet Bee is unlikely to join the Alliance, I'm afraid," Angella sighed, eyes tight with old pain. "Ever since Peekablue...disappeared…" Micah, Netossa, and Spinnerella all winced, "she has remained in the Meadowlands, determined to destroy Vultak once and for all." An image of the princess took form over the table, fortunately not as eye-stabbingly pink as the map.

Catra stared. "Wait, wasn't she at Prom? Come to think of it, wasn't her plus-one 'Peekablue' or something?"

"It was an odd request," Frosta explained, "but announcing her desired plus-one was within her rights as a princess and guest of the Ball."

"Bee has never given up on Princess Peekablue," Angella added, grasping Micah's hand. "I can hardly blame her." Another image, this one of a slender blue-skinned figure, appeared beside Sweet Bee.

Catra tried to shove down her (deep, howling, unrelenting) longing for Adora. "Okay, she goes on the list. Entrapta, think you can throw together some more scout bots for us?"

Entrapta cackled with even more insane glee than usual. "*Can* I!" she gushed. Then she paused a moment. "That means yes," she explained.

For an instant, Catra was tempted to smile. The empty green chair kept the temptation in check. "Okay. Quick update, Crimson Waste is apparently not a dead zone, but still lethal and not fun. Maybe we can trick Hordak into sticking his hand into that mess."

Glimmer's sigh was explosive. "Okay, I'm just gonna say it. Where's Perfuma?" she blurted. "Has she ever missed a meeting before?"

She's never been late *to a meeting, Sparkles,* Catra thought, clawing her nerves into tiny chunks. "She'll be fine. I'm heading to Plumeria as soon as the meeting's over to check on her."

Bow straightened. "The three of us can go," he insisted. "The Best Friends Squad sticks together."

Catra rolled her eyes to cover her swirling storm of worry and gratitude. "Whatever, Best Boy," she muttered, to several chuckles and one best boy blush. "With your permission, Your Majesty?"

"Meeting adjourned," Angella agreed. "Thank you all for coming." The foreign princesses filed out, followed by a gently bickering

Tossa and Spinny. “Catra, Glimmer, Bow. All of you, be careful. It is not like Perfuma to be absent for a full meeting of the Alliance.”

Catra shrugged, this one not covering anything up. *Petals'll be fine.*

She's got to be.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Glimmer forced herself to relax, which was more than Catra was doing.

Okay, that's not really fair, Glimmer admitted, *She's doing her best.* The magicat's ears were swiveling and twitching, her tail slashed past her legs, and her claws kept sliding in and out. All the human-like stuff was moving with that “I am a soldier” ferocity that Catra probably thought made her look in control. *Of course, put it all together and she's terrifying to, like, anyone else, but...* Glimmer looked at Bow, who was biting his lip.

He was as worried as Glimmer, which did *not* help Glimmer's nerves. At all.

The one thing the Best Friends Squad had going for them was that Plumeria looked normal. The trees were healthy, flowers in bloom, and the animals weren't spooked by anything except their worried apex predator best friend.

Seneschal came running up as they approached Plumeria's village-capitol. “She-Ra,” he gasped, leaning on his knees as he caught his breath. “Thank...goodness.”

They all stared at Seneschal for a moment, Catra blinking slowly. “Seneschal?” Wildcat asked, tilting her head sideways a fraction. “Hey, I've been meaning to ask, is that your name or your job–”

“They took Princess Perfuma!” Seneschal cried.

Suddenly, no one cared if it was his name or job.

“What do you mean, they took her?” Catra whispered, sounding fragile enough to shatter in a stiff breeze. “She’s – she’s *Perfuma.”*

“It was a strike team – that Scorpioni Captain, her team – and, and – the sorceress–” Seneschal babbled.

Catra took off like a falcon, dropping to all fours before Glimmer could even react. With a frustrated sigh, the princess put one hand on Bow’s shoulder and the other on Seneschal’s, teleporting to the Heart-Blossom.

Catra arrived seconds later, leaping atop the Heart-Blossom while Glimmer caught her breath. The magicat scuttled around the edge of the Runestone for a few seconds, stopping cold on its right side. “Hey, Seneschal,” Wildcat called, “did Shadow Weaver do anything to the tree-stone here?”

Seneschal shook his head, on the brink of tears. “Not herself, but…” he rubbed his eyes, a few Plumerians emerging from the woods. “The sorceress and her people captured Princess Perfuma before we could stop them. They fled, and we went after them, but then they came back, and...Perfuma did this.” He tapped his fingertips on the dark green scar marring the edge of the Heart-Blossom.”

Again, Catra’s eyes flew wide. *“Perfuma* did this?” she gasped. “Shadow Weaver must’ve – did Petals look different, or was there something weird about her besides what she did?”

Seneschal nodded, hugging himself. “Some of that evil red lightning played in her hair, and Perfuma’s smile, it looked fixed, false.”

Glimmer looked at Catra, horror gripping her inside. “What did Shadow Weaver *do?”* she gasped.

“I...don’t know,” Catra admitted.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora paced around the edge of the Black Garnet chamber while Shadow Weaver examined her mask in a mirror. The sorceress had fixed the Heart-Blossom shard next to the one from the Garnet, tiny dark vines growing from her palms. Shadow Weaver...sighed, relaxing just a fraction, but it was more than Adora had ever seen from her. "Are you all right, Shadow Weaver?" she asked

"Oh, I am renewed, Adora dear," Shadow Weaver assured her, stretching her arms out as though luxuriating in something. (It was a weird word, "luxuriating," but it had been in one of the books on princesses, and Catra used to...no, no sense in thinking about her, not now.) "The life energy from Plumeria's Runestone is strengthening my body in ways that I had scarcely hoped to believe possible."

"And you think this will make that weird princess...sane?" Adora asked.

Shadow Weaver chuckled and stroked Adora's hair. Adora managed to not flinch. "I know that it sounds preposterous, child, but I assure you, it is possible. Come." Shadow Weaver turned and flowed out of her sanctum, and Adora followed, obeying without question.

They reached the simulation room, the floor outside succumbing to the occasional shudder. Shadow Weaver opened the door, and Adora's mouth fell open a fraction. Perfuma was there, smashing through training bots with massive columns of vines, Scorpia by her side. Dylamug, Callix, and Dreer provided backup while Lonnie, Rogelio, Kyle, and Tavor watched in amazement. It took Scorpia's team only a few seconds more to finish with a time in the top ten. "Whoo!" Scorpia cheered. "You were amazing, Perfuma."

Perfuma blushed a fraction, brushing strands of hair from her face. "Thank you, Scorpia," she said, her smile shy as she clasped her hands in front of her. "I must confess to having developed a fondness for punching things with plants while I was still a Rebel."

Adora looked from Shadow Weaver to Perfuma and back. "Shadow Weaver, how…?" Shadow Weaver turned a cool gaze on the Force Captain, not accepting her non-question. "How did you get her onto our side without making her – not a princess?"

Shadow Weaver tapped the green shard on her mask. "The same magic that allows me to access the Heart-Blossom's power also grants me the ability to shield Cadet Perfuma from its corrupting influence." Perfuma gestured, growing small trees from cracks in the floor. She offered those strange ration orbs rebels called "fruit" to the assembled squads. "Her core personality, however," the sorceress drawled, "remains largely unchanged at the moment."

It was an effort not to chuckle. The slender ex-princess exuded sincerity to both Scorpia's squad and Adora's while she gushed about the virtues of eating plant life. "Well, she doesn't lack for enthusiasm, I'll give her that."

Shadow Weaver exhaled in what Adora recognized as annoyance. "True enough, I am afraid," the sorceress sighed. "I am placing her in Scorpia's squad for the time being, as the Scorpioni seems able to handle the princess. However, seeing as you and Scorpia are all but officially partners, I would recommend that you get to know the...woman." Shadow Weaver stared at Perfuma, eyeslits narrowing.

Adora saluted. "Yes ma'am," she said. Without another word, Shadow Weaver glided out, leaving the two squads to coordinate, or talk or whatever. Adora strode over to Perfuma, who smiled and waved. Scorpia nudged the former princess and whispered what Adora assumed was a correction, because Perfuma then attempted a salute.

It was an effort not to wince. *At least she's making an effort,* Adora told herself. "So! Perfuma. How are you adjusting?"

"Oh, much better than I expected, Adora – I mean Force Captain," Perfuma replied. Her smile, which had seemed friendly at first, never moved. It looked...artificial, somehow, as fixed as Shadow

Weaver's mask. "We always feared the Horde in the Alliance." Perfuma shrugged. "Catra, well, she didn't have much nice to say about life here, but everyone's been so welcoming!" She glanced at Scorpia, her hands tightening on one another.

"I'm glad to hear that," Adora said, smiling back in as friendly a manner as she could manage, "and when it's just our squads, you can call me Adora."

"Yeah," Lonnie chuckled, "it'd be a little weird calling her 'Force Captain' every time we wanted to talk after growing up together."

Adora swallowed. "So...you knew Catra, in the Rebellion?" Scorpia straightened, tail rattling just a bit.

"Oh, yes, she was very kind," Perfuma insisted, and Adora's heart clenched for a moment. "Catra always had this negative energy clinging to her. She wore it like armor, the poor dear, rough with words, but always generous with actions."

Why does that hurt so much? Adora wondered, her smile fading, but she refused to let it die. "Yeah, that sounds like Catra."

"Do you know why she left the Horde, Perfuma?" Scorpia asked, taking a protective step closer to Adora. Not for the first time (or the hundredth, to be honest), Adora was grateful to the big, loyal gal for her friendship.

Perfuma froze, smile vanishing. For an instant, Adora thought the blonde's hair turned a bit reddish. Then the moment passed, and her smile returned, exactly as before. "She didn't get along with Shadow Weaver," Perfuma said. "I'm not sure why. Catra didn't seem like she was lying, but my experience with your lead sorceress certainly does not match what Catra told me."

Adora nodded, her own smile vanishing as she crossed her arms. *It was all before the Sword,* she thought, stomach churning. *How? How did I not keep my promise?* She patted Perfuma on the shoulder. "Thank you, Cadet," Adora replied, "I really appreciate that."

"Oh, it's no trouble at all," Perfuma assured her, and Adora headed for the door and a shower she was desperately looking forward to.

That was how she missed the single tear that rolled past the princess' unmoving smile.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Hordak stared at the sheet of paper before him. "What is this?" he growled.

"A list of nutritional suggestions for personnel by species, biochemistry, and age, Lord Hordak," Force Captain Adora replied, saluting.

His first impulse was to dismiss the absurdity before him – no, to crumple it up, throw it in the child's face, and berate the Force Captain for wasting his time. There was just one small problem: the data matched up with the conditioned princess' advice. "I presume," Hordak grumbled, "that you are not suggesting I feed my soldiers these *things,* Force Captain."

"Of course not, Lord Hordak," Adora continued, her crisp salute never wavering, "but after some investigating, it appears that we can integrate the suggested nutrients into ration bar production. It would, I must admit, require us to triple the number of ration bar colors, but if Cadet Perfuma's analysis is correct, the Horde would more than make up in health and efficiency what we lose in extra work for ration bar creation." Her jaw twitched once. "Morale has also improved at least 25% among Horde soldiers who have had the opportunity to...partake of Perfuma's creations."

Hordak grunted once. *This benighted planet,* he thought, refusing to sigh. "Very well, Force Captain. You may implement the changes as a provisional effort." He set aside the new Cadet's paper and the Force Captain's extremely detailed accompanying chart. "Have the rebels made any efforts to retrieve our former princess?"

"Not yet, Lord Hordak," Adora reported, "but they will. Shadow Weaver's observations indicate they are planning a full assault on the Fright Zone. They appear to believe she did not come with us by choice.

Hordak did sigh, at that. *Because she did not,* he admitted, but said nothing to the naive soldier before him. "Shadow Weaver will have planned a counter-offensive by now. You have my permission to implement it. Dismissed."

"Yes, Lord Hordak." Force Captain Adora completed her salute, turned, and left with perfect discipline. *Shadow Weaver's efforts with this soldier begin to bear their promised fruit,* he noted. *The irony. Nevertheless, this magicat She-Ra remains an irritant. If Shadow Weaver cannot eliminate her, then I must take matters into my own hands.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

"They're moving, Your Majesty," General Juliet reported as she rushed in. "Princess Perfuma is with them."

Catra didn't quite relax, but a sliver of tension drained away. "Good, we can go with plan A, then," the Champion muttered.

The full Alliance – excepting the absent Perfuma – was in attendance, in preparation for the planned rescue. Angella was grateful that something had at last gone right. *It was beginning to feel like the collapse of the First Alliance,* she thought, keeping the terror buried deep.

General Juliet did not appear to share Angella's relief. "With respect, Champion, Shadow Weaver has led her forces to the edge of the Whispering Woods," she explained, calling up the map. Catra's eyes narrowed at the sight, as they always did. "The sorceress appears to have mimicked some of Perfuma's magic. They are simply willing the trees out of their way. If we don't stop them, the Horde will reach Brightmoon before day's end."

"Then we stop them," Catra insisted. Glimmer grinned and punched her palm with a sparkly fist. Mermista and Frosta nodded with grim determination. "Glimmer, Bow, you work the edges, keep soldiers busy until Perfuma's open. Then Glimmer pulls her out and we do the exorcism thing." She glanced over at Entrapta. "Traps, you're on bots as usual."

"Well, that is logical," Entrapta replied, pulling several odd devices out of her hair – *with* her hair, "but I have some ideas about Perfuma's status and maybe I could build a device that will free her so I was wondering if–"

"Traps," Catra cut in, ears pivoting back when Entrapta flinched. "Breathe. If you come up with a gadget, great, but right now your job is to keep bots off us. King Micah's got a tested exorcism spell we can use, okay?" Entrapta nodded, head drooping. Catra turned a look that Angella could only describe as 'ferociously encouraging' on the princesses. "Look, everybody, we're all worried about Perfuma. We have a plan. We *will* get her back. Okay?" The Alliance nodded back.

Guilt ate at the queen as she half-listened to Catra's plan, knowing that it would keep a small group at Brightmoon for its defense. Angella herself would be responsible for this defense, as ever. *In the end, what else have I done?* she despaired, watching the rest of their Champion's plan scheme fall into place, brilliant as ever. Dear Micah would accompany them to exorcise Perfuma alongside Lady Mally with Glimmer and Bow's assistance, while the other princesses, backed by a handful of soldiers (and Sea Hawk), kept the Horde occupied by combining their efforts in various ways. "That should be everything. Any questions?"

Angella stood. Catra's ears shot up and Micah turned worried eyes toward her, but none of the others – not even dear Glimmer – saw anything amiss. "Champion, how many of us do you believe should remain behind to defend Brightmoon?" the queen asked, hands clasped behind her.

“Your Majesty,” Catra said, swallowing as her tail lashed, “we should have as fallback point in case something goes wrong with the–”

“If we do not rescue Princess Perfuma, I am not certain that any fallback position will be relevant,” Angella cut in, steeling herself at the fear in Glimmer’s eyes as Catra’s tail lashed. “The Whispering Woods, our greatest defense, bend to her will. Casta, are you willing to remain here with General Juliet in case we require assistance?”

The sorceress-queen and general shared a glance. “Yes. Bring them home, Angella.”

Catra stared for a long moment, then held her head and groaned. “I hope you remember how to fight, Your Majesty.”

Angella’s smile was wan. *Sadly, yes,* she thought, but instead said, “The Archistrategos taught me warfare long ago, and I have used those skills countless times over the ages. A few years of sloth will not have diminished them.”

Catra raised an eyebrow. “‘Sloth.’ Right.” She looked Angella over, then nodded. “Okay, you’re high ground. You see the buzzard, swat him, otherwise, you’re overwatch, hit targets of opportunity and keep us up on what Shadow Weaver pulls, sound good?” Angella nodded. “Okay! Let’s go save Petals.”

“Yeah!” the youngsters cheered. Angella let herself dare to hope, no matter the fear in her heart (the one she called coward, unable to see her courage).

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver exulted to see the Whispering Woods bend to her will at last.

Trees shriveled and recoiled, bowing before her. Perfuma’s undeserved magic danced as Shadow Weaver wished, forcing the woods aside. Unlike the sorceress’ own efforts, however,

Perfuma's work did not diminish the plants she controlled. *It seems that one small fraction of resistance remains to the accursed brat,* Shadow Weaver through, allowing herself the annoyance before dismissing it. *No matter. She obeys, and her defiance will fall with Brightmoon.*

Shadow Weaver permitted herself a smile as she considered Adora, wearing the Garnet-powered harness she had made for the child, directing their division through the forest Adora had been taught to fear her entire life. Even the great General Sunder heeded her direction. *It is unfortunate that I must continue to deceive her in these small matters,* the sorceress mused, glancing at Perfuma again, *but she will come to understand. What matters is that Adora no longer heeds–*

"SHADOW WEAVER!" She-Ra roared, leaping down from the heavens themselves. Shadow Weaver retreated from the beast, watching in horror as Catra impaled her super-heavy tank with casual ease.

Shadow Weaver regained control a moment later. "Foolish beast," she crooned, casting vines at She-Ra and using them to conduct her lightning. The Champion of Power sliced through them, but that took all her attention. "Concentrate all firepower on She-Ra!"

Catra's smirk should have been a warning, but the crashing river smashed through the division before Shadow Weaver could recognize the danger. Then the water froze in an instant, trapping all their heavy equipment. "ADVENTURE!" the idiot sailor cried, accompanying Mermista and Frosta as they went straight up the force's middle. Frosta froze Perfuma's vines as they lashed out at the rebels.

Her Micah led a band of sorcerers, along with his daughter and the archer, towards Perfuma, while the princess-wives struck at her forces from the opposite angle, entangling her forces and creating a vortex of wind. They could breathe, but operations were all but impossible. Predictably, Hordak's latest improvements to their bots did not survive contact with the ridiculous hair

princess, turning them into Rebellion assets. “You’re a crap strategist, you know that, right Shadow Weaver?” Catra smirked, slicing her way closer to the sorceress.

“Adora, engage with this fool!” Shadow Weaver ordered, vanishing into the darkness. *It is time, you pathetic animal, that you learned just whom you are dealing with!*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

She-Ra snarled and leaped at Adora, planning to knock her aside and go after Shadow Weaver. That plan fell apart when Adora refused to be knocked aside, her armor crackling with crimson lightning. “The heck?” Catra demanded, turning the Sword into a staff and smacking Adora in the chest plate. That drove the blonde back...a few inches. “Are you Baby Weaver now?”

“If that’s what it takes to protect Etheria from the princesses!” Adora retorted, drawing her own staff and extending it to full size. It was basically a double stun baton on a training staff, surging with the same red energy.

“We’re the good guys, you idiot!” Catra howled, kicking Adora in the gut and getting a blow to her shin for her trouble. “How can you be okay with this?”

Adora shook off the blow, smirking as though nothing had changed. As if four years of war and pain didn’t stretch out between them. “Aw, what’s wrong, Catra?” Adora went into that slagging stance, the same ready position she’d used to beat Catra countless times in the simulator. “Can’t stand seeing Perfuma prove you wrong?”

Rage burned through Catra, hearing Perfuma’s unnatural movements as the flower princess fought her friends against her will. “Do you even *care* that Shadow Weaver brainwashed her?” Adora took a breath to respond–

Frosta screamed. She-Ra turned, eyes locked in horror on the sight of Shadow Weaver’s fingers slashing across the tiny princess’

arm like claws. Catra gasped. –*no*– Then she burst across the battlefield like a cannon blast. The Sword overflowing with light, She-Ra cut neatly though Shadow Weaver's offending arm, leaving it as cleanly severed as any bot.

Shadow Weaver screamed, propelled backwards by darkness and lightning, vines pulling her hand back onto her arm. Ice covered the severed limb. "Frosta, you don't have to–"

"That wasn't me," Frosta insisted, and that's when Catra saw it. A tiny blue-white sliver of the Fractal Flake came to life on Shadow Weaver's mask, opposite the Heart-Blossom piece across from the Black Garnet shard.

Catra poured life and power towards Frosta, replacing the drained energy in an instant. Above, Vultak laughed. "You should not make yourself so easy a target, fool child–"

Queen Angella didn't bother saying anything. She just slammed Vultak through the sky with a mace made of lavender light. It wasn't enough to restore Catra's smile; Shadow Weaver laughed as she reattached her arm with terrifying ease. "You're too *late,* false She-Ra!" Catra exploded towards the witch again, slashing through vines that added coatings of ice to the conducted lightning. "I am now the mightiest being on this world!" Still, she retreated as She-Ra advanced, slicing through all her attacks with the Sword. "What now, Champion of Power?"

"I'm going to cut your head off," Catra snarled, "let's see you heal *that."* Adora rushed to defend the abusive monster; She-Ra backhanded her into the woods, ignoring the shock from her old friend's armor.

"Catra! We got her!" Glimmer cried, bringing She-Ra to a halt.

This time, Catra smirked. "Sorry, I can't play with you now. It was fun distracting you, though." With that, She-Ra flashed across the battlefield in an instant, appearing beside Micah, Glimmer, Bow, and a gooped-up Perfuma. The king and princess had already

begun the exorcism circle, so Catra stabbed its edge, infusing it with the Sword's power. "Hang on, Petal – Perfuma," Catra whispered. "We've got you."

Drawing on all her might, She-Ra turned herself into a blur, prepared to protect her friends no matter what.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora groaned and deactivated the power-harness; after Catra's blow, it was more dangerous to Adora than any enemy. Staggering towards the knot of rebels holding Perfuma captive, she hid behind a tree and pulled out her staff, keeping it inactive for the moment. *Even after a princess defects, you still can't see through their lies, Catra?* The Force Captain sighed. *You were always the smart one...*

Shadow Weaver raced over, Operation: Avalanche a success. The king glared at the sorceress, looming over them atop a column of frozen vines. Crimson lightning ran up and down Shadow Weaver's arms. "Is this what you're reduced to, Light Spinner?" he demanded. Adora blinked. *Who's Light Spinner?* she wondered. "Torturing children wasn't enough, now you're controlling them with shadow puppets?"

Shadow Weaver laughed. It chilled Adora's blood more than all the ice. "Oh, Micah. The Rebellion never had the strength to win this war. You taught me that." Adora felt like her heart had stopped. *She – why didn't she deny it? What...what's going on?*

She-Ra slashed through the incoming column of wood and ice with her claws, Sword still embedded in the ground. "Forget it, Shadow Loser," Catra quipped, holding up claws so bright Adora almost couldn't look directly at them. She-Ra's brief smirk vanished. "I am never letting you hurt them again."

"As though you could *stop* me!" Shadow Weaver pounded Catra with spell after spell, Catra countering them with shining claws.

“When I return the Sword to Adora, with it shall come your broken body!”

Perfuma screamed.

With a cry of worry, stealth forgotten, Adora bolted from her cover, only to find Catra holding the plant princess. “I’ve got you, Perfuma! You’re okay.” Catra hugged her, She-Ra’s form melting away. “You’re okay.”

Perfuma shook her head while King Micah held back Shadow Weaver’s power, somehow bolstered by the Sword’s might. “I – I’m not – I’m so *sorry,* Catra – I thought I could fight her...”

“You did. You *won,”* Catra insisted, light still pouring from her like tears to fill the magic circle. “We’ve got you, Perfuma.”

“Y-you can call me Petals,” Perfuma hiccuped through a sob, “if you like?” Catra forced a laugh.

“Perfuma?” Scorpia breathed, reaching out a claw. The Force Captain recoiled when the princess did.

“Pull back!” Adora ordered, scowling at the sight of General Sunder frozen in a grapple with a sorceress. “All units, return to base!” The Whispering Woods had already begun healing, the princesses’ morale skyrocketed with Perfuma’s defection back to the Rebellion, and Catra was already in the process of reclaiming the Sword. The battle was over.

Though if Adora were honest with herself, none of those were the real reason she’d ordered the retreat.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra gave Perfuma one last hug, then watched as the flower princess went to the mind-healers – the “therapists” Angella had spoken of – and slunk back to her room.

Glimmer and Bow were already there, of course. “You okay, Wildcat?” Bow asked.

“Yeah,” Catra huffed, dropping into the nest of blankets her dorky best friends had made for her. The pair watched, practically vibrating with the effort not to blab at her. “...no,” Catra admitted. “Perfuma...”

“She just needs time,” Bow said, kind and gentle as ever.

“And this won’t happen again,” Glimmer assured her. “Entrapta sent Plumeria bots, Frosta’s loaned them some soldiers, and Aunt Casta’s got sorcerers there too. We’ve got this.”

Catra tried to hold in her gratitude – and couldn’t, hugging the two dorks with all the strength she had. “You...guys...” she sniffled. “Perfuma’s – *everyone’s* been so nice...so *kind...* I should’ve been there, done something...”

“Hey, even I can’t be everywhere, and I teleport!” Glimmer quipped, and Catra laughed through a sob in spite of how lame the joke was. “Besides, we did save her.” Catra nodded.

“Yeah.” Catra melted into their embrace, but there was still a cold void in her chest. “I have to give up on her, huh?” she muttered, and the other two froze. “Adora.”

“You don’t have to do anything you don’t want, Catra,” Bow whispered.

Catra huffed and hugged them closer instead of answering. *She was okay with this,* Catra thought, managing not to cry. *I can’t save her. I never could.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

“You okay, Adora?” Scorpia asked, forcing a smile.

Adora had long since lost track of how many times she’d been grateful for the big scorpion princess. “Me? Pssh, yeah, of course.

It’s okay if you’re not, though. I know you were starting to make friends with the princess.” The blonde’s eyes widened. “The other. Princess. I mean.”

Scorpia patted Adora’s shoulder with a claw. “I’ll get over it,” she insisted. “We have to, right? Got a job to do.” Adora just nodded, unable to swallow the lump in her throat, as Scorpia retreated to her bunk.

Adora did the same, the Force Captain’s quarters less welcoming than ever. She sat in the middle of the bed, pulling off her tunic and staring at the Horde symbol on the back. The world swirled beneath her, threatening to fall out from below. One question echoed in her mind, over and over:

What if Catra’s right?

Chapter End Notes

Reused 80s episode title is reused.

My headcanon for Runestone Shard use is that it requires the stone's princess to activate, hence Scorpia's value to Shadow Weaver. (I mean she's also an incredible fighter and hugger, but Shadow Weaver doesn't care about any of that.)

Also, yeah, I'm horrible with the drama here, I know, but does anyone think Good!Catra can *really* give up on Adora?

Next time: The Portal! But who activates it, and why, and what price must the Rebellion pay to close it this time?

A Beautiful Dream

Chapter Summary

> Princess Catriska Persis lost her mother when she was five, but has had the best life since then. Adopted by the Halfmoon royal family, Triss has rebuilt the Princess Alliance, is beloved by her people, counts Glimmer as her best friend, and has the most amazing girlfriend in the world – Adora, the She-Ra, Princess of Power. Everything is perfect. So why does it all feel so...wrong?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Princess Catriska D'riluth Persis yawned, stretched, and sat up, rubbing her eyes and glancing at the clock, its mock-freezefire numbers displaying a scandalously early time. *Nope,* she decided, flopping back into bed.

Weird dreams do not *help,* Catriska thought, musing on the strange vision she'd had...

Entrapta, kidnapped by Shadow Weaver and the Horde. A desperate rescue attempt, made all the more painful by...someone else's...previous capture? It started out okay, but...

"Catriska?" There was a knock on her door. "Triss, *Hijita,* Glim-Glim's coming to pick you up," Queen Selina called.

Triss sighed and rolled over. "Like, in four hours, Mom," she groaned.

Selina laughed. "She's bringing your girlfriend," the queen reminded her.

Those words pulled Catriska to her feet, tail straight out and flared. "I'mup!" she blurted. Mom laughed again and padded off,

no doubt to harass poor Felicia.

Triss sighed, then bathed, after which she pulled on what her little sister called her "working princess clothes," a mix of jumpsuit and dress jacket. She finished it off with her arsenal belt, which held her clawsword, brightpaw, and lineshield. After a moment, she groaned and added her war boots, open at the toes for her claws, but otherwise "protecting" her feet. *Mom'll worry otherwise,* Triss thought, heading through the palace's halls, *and so will–*

Adora, her new Garnet armor shattered, was prone beneath Catra – She-Ra – another shock-staff sliced to pieces. Catra held the Sword over Adora's heart with one hand, able to end the fight with a single thrust. "Catra?" Adora whispered, tears shining in wide, terrified eyes. I have to I have to I *have* to – *Catra thought, trying to will herself to strike, to save Entrapta, but* – I can't! *she despaired, just before shadows swallowed everything.*

Princess Catriska was so shaken by the waking nightmare that Felicia actually pulled off a successful ambush, knocking Triss over and pinning her. "Ha! Gotcha, sis!" the younger princess exulted, scruffing the older magicat. Felicia's tail lashed behind her with glee.

Triss groaned. "Congratulations, kitten. You ambushed me when I'm up way too early after a nightmare."

Felicia leaped off, eyes wide and ears back. "Omigosh Triss I'm sorry–"

"Relax, kitten," Triss insisted, Changing to rise to all fours, then Changing again to stand upright. "I'm fine." She grinned. "Besides, ambushes work best when the enemy least expects them."

Felicia leaped over to hug Catriska – then leaped back, letting go and pouting. "I'm not a kitten!" Triss laughed and hugged her kid sister back, mussing her hair just a bit. "So...I hear you're making the big push today?"the younger princess prodded.

Catriska shook her head. “Quit worrying, ‘Licia,” she insisted, rounding a corner to head outside. “Even if we win, there’ll be plenty of losers out there for you to hunt when you’re of age.” Together, they gazed across the capitol.

Towering spires covered in lapis lazuli pulled streams through the air to fill overhead aqueducts, forming shining arches of liquid that left tiny rainbows in their wake. Long buildings of crimson brick were lit by crystals called tiger’s eyes, soft golden light shining between red bands, lighting stone columns. Above them, archways of sand-colored stone held up bridges between the buildings overhead. Magicats rode graceful skiffs, elegant driftwagons, and the dragon-horses known as Takdryl. “Yeah,” Felicia agreed. “Everything’s perfect.”

Catriska smiled, putting an arm around her adoptive sister’s shoulders. “Everything’s perfect,” she agreed.

SHIFT

Together, the royal family sat in their thrones, just as Princess Glimmer arrived with *her* adopted sister, Adora – the She-Ra, Princess of Power, even if she had arrived as herself. The living sparkle-bomb bounced in place once, grinning at her fellow princesses, then managed a perfect curtsy. “Your Majesties,” Glimmer said, Adora managing alongside her.

“Princess Glimmer,” Selina replied, nodding with a placid expression. Then all six royals grinned, the magicats rising from their thrones as Cloudfoot stamped the floor with his staff. Retainers went about their business as the regal figures went about committing a messy group hug.

Then Catriska grinned, pulled Adora to one side, and gave her a quick kiss. “Hey, Adora,” she whispered, smirking at the cocky heroine.

“Hey, Catra,” Adora whispered back. Catriska rolled her eyes at the frankly ridiculous nickname–

Catra regained consciousness in Hordak's sanctum, bound to a pillar with manacles, ropes, and shadows. Hordak manipulated a machine with controls more complex than Catra could follow. Entrapta dangled overhead, held in place with crimson lightning and more shadows, binding even her pigtails. Shadow Weaver stood beside Hordak, looking at an enormous arch formed from weird tech. Adora stood between them, left only in her usual uniform, looking unsure as her eyes darted from Rebel to sorceress. The Sword was inserted into a slot atop the arch, crackling with power...

"–tra? Triss!" Adora blurted, holding Catriska's shoulders. "Are you okay?"

Felicia sighed, though the others looked worried. "She had a weird nightmare last night. Probably Shadow Loser again."

Catra shrugged. "I'm fine," she insisted, shaking her head clear. "Let's get to Brightmoon, Sparkles." Glimmer groaned at her nickname, getting Catriska to smile. "Relax. Everything's perfect."

SHIFT

Catriska blinked – *Did I just think of myself as Catra?* she wondered – and looked around the Princess Alliance war room. The princesses chatted with excitement, all eager to bring down Horror Hall once and for all. Perfuma was holding Scorpia's pincer – *Honestly, big gal, can you at least try not to get kidnapped again?* Triss grinned, thinking of the last time Perfuma had rescued her – but the others seemed as relaxed as anyone could be just before a major operation.

Catriska stood, examining the map, and the chatter died down. The Menagerie remained an impenetrable fortress for the time being, as Peekablue had warned them, but the last remnants of the Fright Zone were under Shadow Weaver's control, and Triss could work with that. "Entrapta, are your new bots ready?" Catriska asked, frowning at not already knowing the answer.

"Probably!" Entrapta gushed. Mermista groaned, eliciting smiles from Triss and Netossa. "At least 94% of them are fully operational, and you deemed 90% a sufficient success rate for strategic reasons. Hordak wanted to add ramming functionality, but it seemed excessive to me."

"Mmm," Catra nodded, staring at Horror Hall on the map. "Maybe for the Menagerie. Hordak's enthusiasm is...welcome."

"You can't!" Entrapta cried. "The First Ones systems that keep us in this dimension will create a resonant feedback! Reality will collapse!"

Hordak turned a concerned look toward one screen, but Shadow Weaver only chuckled. "Ah," the witch said, "but that will take time. Time the supposed Sword-bearer can use to repair the damage." She floated over to the switch, turning her expressionless glare on the helpless Catra. "I wonder what it will cost you to undo this."

Hordak looked up, alarmed. "Shadow Weaver, wait!" he barked.

Shadow Weaver didn't wait. She threw the switch, and everything turned white–

"–ot again – *Catra!"* Adora cried, her panic heartbreakingly familiar. Catriska found, to her undying embarrassment, that Adora was cradling her bridal-carry style, while crouched beside the chair Triss had clearly fallen out of. The other princesses were gathered around her in a semi-circle, except for Entrapta dangling from the ceiling by her–

–another friend captured helpless SCARED not again not again–

–hair, while Frosta stood on the table to look at Catriska from above, growth spurt be damned. "Is she dead? Please don't be dead," Frosta blurted.

Catriska groaned and sat up. "I'm not dead, Frostbite," she replied, grabbing the table's edge and pulling herself upright to

avoid further embarrassment. *Calm down, woman,* she told herself. *Perfuma's fine. Entrapta's fine.* She sat back in her chair, treating it like a second throne. "Everyone, relax," Catriska insisted. "I'm okay. Everything's perfect…"

Entrapta dropped back into her chair, mumbling something about 'shifting data' as she tapped at her pad. *I keep saying that. Weird,* Catra thought–

SHIFT

Everything was not perfect.

"For the honor of Grayskull!" Adora cried. A Sword of light formed in her hand as she transformed into She-Ra, Catriska's usual stare not for its usual (ogling) purpose. *That seems...wrong...*

"Soon, First One," Vultak laughed, soaring above his forces, "You will be as dead as Grayskull *and* its honor! *For the Horde!"*

The Princess Alliance struck at the Fright Zone's walls with all its vast power, from rivers and glaciers to waves of vines and beams of light. Lord Vultak and his vizier, the wicked Shadow Weaver, lashed out with dark powers, even as what remained of the Horde's legions marched out to face them.

It all seemed suitably epic, a final confrontation worthy of song and story, right up to the point where Horror Hall vanished, consumed by a column of white light that lanced into the heavens.

Catriska stared upward in horror, jaw dropping as the tear in reality consumed one of the nightmoons. The entire battle came to a halt, both sides watching the world-wound with disbelief, except for Shadow Weaver. Inexplicably, the sorceress laughed. "Run, little She-Ra! Run along and play 'hero!'"

"What are you talking about?" Adora demanded, Catriska just having the wherewithal to leap to her beloved's side.

Shadow Weaver stopped laughing, eyeslits going wide before narrowing on the Princess of Power. Behind her, Vultak cried out just before the white light devoured him. "Adora," she hissed. "This is your perfect world? I am very disappointed in you, child."

"Fall back!" Catriska cried, waving the princesses back. "Entrapta, any ideas?"

"I'm picking up multiple anomalies – oh," Entrapta whispered. "I understand now. The data…" she looked up at Catriska. "There is an unstable portal in our world, and as long as it's open, it'll keep destabilizing reality, until there's nothing left."

"So how…" Triss looked up at Shadow Weaver, who moved away from the white instability as though driven from it somehow. "...'wonder what it will cost you....' the Sword," she gasped. "That's why Adora's She-Ra form didn't seem right. The Sword's powering the portal."

"But whoever shuts down the portal can't leave," Entrapta continued. "They'll be trapped between realities, possibly forever."

"No!" Adora gasped, gripping Catriska's arm. "There has to be another way!"

"I'm sorry," Entrapta whispered. When Catra reached out for Entrapta, though, her hand passed right through the genius. "The portal...it's following you, Catra." Traps lowered her hand and hair with a sad smile. "It was nice being friends with you."

"Traps!" Catra cried, but it was too late – she was gone. *That's right. Catra. My name isn't Catriska. I'm not a princess. I found the Sword, and...* Horror rushed through Catra, and she looked at Adora, eyes wide. There was no sign of the other princesses.

"Catra, what's going on?" Adora pleaded, still holding on. "Why is everything falling apart?"

Catra looked down. "Because I'm the worst She-Ra ever," she snarled, hands balled into fists. The white nothing was roaring

closer to them. “Because I left you–”

Flashes roared through Catra’s mind. She saw a sky full of stars. Razz’s Mara reached out to her. Shards of time and possibility rained down around her. Micah rescued Catra from Shadow Weaver in Halfmoon, and she grew up Catriska, free and unbroken. *Wait, I really am Catriska?* she wondered. Adora convinced Catra to stay in the Horde, and they ruled its remnants after a brutal civil war. Another Catra who stayed went mad, more broken than ever, taunting an Adora who really was She-Ra at the end of everything. Yet another Catra had narrowly avoided that fate, only to be possessed by the broken Catra thanks to–

“Shadow Weaver,” Catra blurted, looking up. “SHADOW WEAVER!” she screamed at the wounded sky. “You said I could fix this, that it would hurt me to fix it! Fine, tell me how! How do I fix this?”

With a laugh, Shadow Weaver took form from Adora’s shadow. The blonde leaped back, reaching for the Sword of light, but it would not come. “Well, if you are going to make this *easy* for me,” she mocked, “then I will help you, after a fashion.”

The ground cracked between the students and their tormentor, a wall of deadly light springing up between them. “NO!” all three cried, the very earth falling apart around them.

Adora grimaced. “You don’t need her,” she insisted, and even at the end of the world, Catra’s joy at those words gave her wings. “You’re the most clever person I’ve ever known. How do we get to the Sword?”

Catra looked around, eyes narrowing at the approaching light. “The portal...it hasn’t just been following me,” she realized. “That’s why everything’s been jumping around.”

“I...I don’t understand,” Adora said, scowling. “Jumping? What, like Glimmer?”

Catra grinned. “Something like that.” She held onto Adora’s hand. “Hang on. This could get weird.” With that, the magicat

concentrated, picturing the Sword, and–

SHIFT

The world was a single plane of violet grass and a swirling storm of rocky platforms surrounding a massive vortex of dark clouds. At the center of the vortex floated the Sword, hanging just below a disc of white oblivion, much like the wall of shining death around Catra and Adora. They looked at each other, Adora in confusion, Catra with determination.

Then, just in case the situation weren't horrible enough, Shadow Weaver took form in the clouds above, flinging Angella towards them. With a gasp, both princesses rushed to catch her, Catra reaching her first with magicat speed, then cushioning her fall with earth magic. *How am I doing that?* Catra wondered, even as she reached the stunned Queen of Brightmoon. *Did I really connect to a Runestone? How real is this?* She didn't ask any of that out loud, checking Angella's pulse. With a sigh and a smile, the queen guided Catra's fingers away from her neck, then stood. "I am well, Catra," she explained.

Catra's eyes widened. "You – you remember," she whispered.

Angella nodded. "How do we fix this?"

"Get me up there," Adora insisted, straightening to attention. "I'll pull out the Sword."

Catra gasped. "No," she breathed.

"'No?' Why?" Angella asked, looking between the two younger women. "What is going to happen, Catra?"

Adora answered instead. "Whoever pulls out the Sword gets stuck here," she explained, expression grim. "I remember too. I remember what I was – *who* I was. It has to be me."

Angella's eyes went wide, but Catra just sighed. "No," Catra said, and the earth rose up to grip Adora, pinning her in place. Above

them, Shadow Weaver laughed, a mocking echo at the end of the world.

Adora yelped, then struggled in the literal grip of the stone holding her. "Catra, what–?"

"I'm not letting you do this, Adora," Catra replied, amazed at how calm she was. She didn't want to die – she choked on fear from the idea – but living in a world without Adora? *There's no comparison,* Catra realized. "You were always supposed to be She-Ra. I'm a mistake."

Adora thrashed, eyes wide and overflowing with tears. "No – Catra, *no,* that's not true!"

With a tenderness Catra thought she'd forgotten, she stroked Adora's cheek. "It is. It's the only thing Shadow Weaver was ever right about. You – you're supposed to be the hero, and if I'm not the monster, it's because you save me. I saw it, the pieces of the worlds, none of this was supposed to happen. I should have stayed. You should have found the Sword. This – this whole world is a mistake, and it's all my fault."

Angella hugged Catra from behind, and the magicat froze. "Do you want to know a secret?" the queen asked, paralyzing Catra more than the gentle embrace. "I...am...a coward."

Before the queen could say another word, Catra whirled around, out of Angella's grip, and pinned her with earth as well. Angella gasped and struck at her bonds with her light magic, but Catra countered with the magical darkness that moved the earth. "You?" Catra's laugh was broken and helpless. "*You're* a coward? I...I can't let you do this."

"Catra–" Adora blurted.

"Please!" Angella cried.

Both struggled in their bonds, but Catra held on, with help from the Sword...and Shadow Weaver? "Losing you...either of you…"

Catra let tears she'd held back for so long stream free, smiling at the best friend she'd left behind, and the woman who'd taught her what 'mother' meant. "...I couldn't live with that." She clutched her forehead, laughter falling from her throat in broken shards. "I'm even stalling, saying goodbye when I know this hurts you...letting *Shadow Weaver* help me...I'm so pathetic."

"Catra, no!" Angella cried, her power almost breaking free of the combined magic holding her back. "It is a mother's place to sacrifice for her daughter."

"Oh, stop being dramatic, Angella," Shadow Weaver mocked. "Catra would never sacrifice herself for anyone."

Those words burst through Catra's spine like lightning. "I love you both," she whispered, "so much." With that, she formed platforms of stone to reach the main pillar above, leaping with speed like She-Ra's. Each cry of despair below felt like daggers between her ribs, but pain was an old friend.

Shadow Weaver's mask-images stopped swirling above, the clouds forming an image of her eyeslits to stare at Catra. "You cannot," Shadow Weaver hissed. "You lack the strength, the conviction."

Catra chuckled and shook her head. "You can stop with the reverse psychology, Shadow Loser," she quipped, taking the Sword in hand and bracing herself. "I'm going to do this."

"That...you know I still win," Shadow Weaver rasped, eyeslits narrowing. "She-Ra will be mine. Etheria will be mine!"

Catra shook her head. "No. Adora will remember. She'll never be yours again." Taking a breath, she called on the power of She-Ra, pleading with the magic to give her strength.

Wait.

If one person has to stay behind, but She-Ra's a person...maybe I can beat this thing after all. With a smirk, Catra focused part of herself – picturing the corrupted Catra, her face and arm lost to

the portal – and part of She-Ra, glowing and loving and invincible – and focused them on her hand, on the hilt, on the wound pouring ruin on all she loved.

With a fierce cry, Catra pulled the Sword free and held it aloft. "I – am..." she trailed off. *No. Whether this is my salvation or my end, I'm going to do it right.* As realities crashed together, fragments of possibility roaring around her, Catra straightened, pointing the Sword at the portal. *This is where Adora came through,* she realized. *Where this thing stole her life, and gave me mine. It's time I gave back.*

"For the honor. *Of. GRAYSKULL!"*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Shadow Weaver groaned and braced herself on a console, forcing herself upright. Hordak glared, but she could handle him, she always did. The mighty 'Horde Lord' was simple enough to mollify with the right obeisances. The absurd rescue squad, consisting of Glimmer, Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta, and the two male companions, stared in horror at the ruins of the portal device. Entrapta sobbed, still bound above them all. Beneath her mask, Shadow Weaver smiled. The Sword was nowhere to be seen. The smile vanished; neither was Adora.

"SHADOW WEAVER!" Angella cried from above, blazing like the daymoon. *This is bad,* the sorceress thought, eyes wide. She managed not to tremble, barely, as Angella wept tears that burned like miniature infernos. "I swear, by the Maker, you will pay for what you have done to Catra!"

"Fff...fuh." The entire battle stopped, from the advancing, furious plant princess to the Horde reinforcements rushing in through the shattered doors. "For." One furred arm – her left, for some reason – reached up from the wreckage of the portal, Sword in hand. *No. Impossible!* Shadow Weaver railed, while the quivering arm managed to hold the Sword off the ground. "The honor." With a cry of pure hatred, Shadow Weaver gathered crimson lightning –

but Perfuma's cry overcame hers, followed by a column of vines as wide as a tank smashing the sorceress into the far wall. "Of." Catra gasped, shifting a chunk of metal off her back. "Grayskull!"

It began as a spark no greater than one of Angella's gleaming tears, shining from the other side of Catra, the one still buried in rubble. She-Ra seemed to struggle, a flickering torch on the verge of extinction. With each moment, however, it grew, desperate shimmer becoming fierce glow. Catra shoved the top of the portal device away, and Shadow Weaver knew she'd been outmaneuvered.

Catra's head and arm were consumed by the unreality of the void, manifestations of the nature of Despondos. The glow, the light, was a portion of She-Ra that matched the wounds Catra had suffered to escape, like a fox gnawing off a paw to escape a bear trap. Kyra's useless daughter had sacrificed a portion of herself to leave most of She-Ra in the gap between dimensions...but retain enough of a spark for both to escape their doom. As for She-Ra, the deep magic was too strong for even that trap to hold. The glow became a storm of light and wonder, embracing and healing Catra's wounds, while the Sword restored She-Ra, returning her whole to Etheria.

(Shadow Weaver would never imagine or accept the notion that Catra was as much a part of the miracle as the Runestone.)

With a roar of triumph, Catra became She-Ra once more, her appearance transformed yet again. Her top was still red, but the golden symbol was more like a moonburst, with a heart-shape over her chest mimicking the archer's half-shirt. It extended from her golden belt, with a white lining framing leggings that were now blue from waist to feet, wings on her boots mimicking the pathetic symbols on the back of Micah's daughter. Most infuriating of all, Catra now mimicked Adora's ponytail, though at least her animal's mane was tamed at last.

Shadow Weaver ground her teeth. The accursed beast was stronger than ever.

With a cry of triumph, Catra darted above, her form a blur of azure and gold, returning to her friends with Entrapta cradled in one arm. "Thanks for the rescue, ladies," She-Ra said with a smile, looking around. Her smile faded, becoming one of alarm. "Adora?" she whispered.

"She lives," Angella insisted, "I swear it, but we must leave, now!"

"NO!" Shadow Weaver howled, firing the most powerful bolt she'd ever cast, weaving Fractal Flake cold in with her Garnet lightning. She-Ra parried it with a casual swing of the Sword. Catra made it look *easy,* the Shakarran take her.

"Everyone out of the pool!" Catra retorted, pointing the Sword high once more. The shaft of golden might pierced the roof, as well as every other between them and the sky. Before anyone could react otherwise, Angella surrounded the Rebellion's fools in a sphere and carried them off.

Once it was too late, of course, Hordak's reinforcements arrived, led by the extremely odd duo of Vultak and Scorpia. "Whoa! Now that's a mess, huh?" the Horde princess blurted. Shadow Weaver groaned and held her forehead.

Hordak grunted. "It is not...a complete loss," he said, as though it were an admission. "We managed to reach Horde Prime with our signal, and the She-Ra is wounded. We will resume normal operations once security is restored."

"I will begin planning our next assault at once, Lord Hordak," Shadow Weaver agreed, relieved that her mercurial 'master' was in a forgiving mood.

"See that you do, Shadow Weaver," he hissed. "Though..." his eyes softened, oddly, taking on a yellowish cast for a moment. "I give you leave to see to Force Captain Adora. No doubt she requires assurance after the portal incident."

Shadow Weaver blinked. *Never reject free influence,* she reminded herself. "Of course, Lord Hordak," she agreed, bowing and

retreating before his temper could reassert itself.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora stared at the sketches of Catra and herself in the metal of their cot frame. Somehow, she wasn't crying. *No. I don't deserve to,* she thought, brushing tender fingertips across the images. *I am going to* fix *this, Catra. I promise.*

The lights dimmed, and Adora immediately leaped to attention. "Shadow Weaver," she said with a crisp salute.

"Ah, Adora," Shadow Weaver drawled. "At ease." Adora relaxed into that position. "How are you, after the...incident?"

Adora kept her expression and breathing even, hoping that Shadow Weaver couldn't tell how badly her heart pounded. "It's like...a bad dream, after waking up. I can remember, flashes, I guess?" She shrugged. "I mean, it was surreal even for a dream, which is weird because it actually happened, right?" *Oh Stars I'm babbling–*

Shadow Weaver chuckled. "Yes, Adora, it happened. And while events were not as...advantageous as I hoped, they have weakened Catra's bond to She-Ra. We strike tomorrow at first light."

That's not much time, Adora thought, but managed a grim nod. "Yes, ma'am," she agreed. "I'll just get my squad in order and–"

"No need," Shadow Weaver replied, her tone cool in an instant. Adora froze. "Tavor will handle the details this time," she continued, using the concern in her voice Adora was now (almost) sure was false. "Tomorrow is a big day, after all."

Adora blinked. "It is?"

"Oh, yes," Shadow Weaver assured her, and for the first time, Adora could swear she sensed the old sorceress smiling beneath her mask. "Tomorrow, we destroy the Rebellion, once and for all."

Adora nodded, saluting again as Shadow Weaver left. *She definitely suspects something, but that's okay. She won't beat Catra in one day, and...I am never letting my friends down again.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

She-Ra looked out across the kingdom of Brightmoon, still processing so much of the last day.

The ghost of a smile haunted her expression. *Huh. "Processing." Not a word we had in the Horde, huh?* she thought, remembering Perfuma exulting in having slapped Shadow Weaver right across Hordak's sanctum. Then remembering Entrapta's eyes lighting up and taking about how 'classy' the term sanctum was.

Angella holding Catra – still in She-Ra form – and sobbing, begging her not to sacrifice herself.

"A mother's place…." Don't ask me to lose you. I can't. I can't, Catra wept, tears streaking silently through her fur. It had all been so *close.* From atop the castle's highest tower, the Champion of Power looked out on beauty she had never imagined existing. *How did I get here? I don't deserve any of this. Not one meal, not a single night's sleep.*

The familiar burst of light and bell-like echoes erupted behind Catra. "You were right, Bow!" Glimmer cried, throwing herself at She-Ra into a hug as fierce as the princess.

Bow followed, though he respected Catra's space. "You okay, Wildcat?" he asked, voice as gentle as his heart.

Catra looked up, and both friends gasped. "You...guys…" She stood, jaw quivering, then threw herself into hugging them both. "I've never told you how lucky I am to have you as best friends, have I?" she whispered.

Glimmer chuckled. "Hey. We knew," she quipped, returning the hug with as much passion as the moment before.

"Catra," Bow continued, still accepting the hug. "Are you *okay?"*

With a huff and a chuckle, she let them go. Glimmer turned a slightly aggrieved look on her boyfriend, like Catra gave good hug or something. "I'm fine," she insisted.

Glimmer turned that look on Catra, crossing her arms. "Seriously, Catra? We've talked about you doing the 'I'm fine' masking, remember?"

Catra mock-glared back. "No," she retorted. Bow chuckled as Glimmer double-facepalmed, groaning. "Okay, yeah, that took a lot out of me. It's why I'm She-Ra, I need to stay in this form for a while." She looked at her right arm, the Sword in bracer form there, literally holding Catra together. "The portal messed me up, but I'll get better."

"Are you sure there's not anything else?" Bow asked, still gentle.

Catra flinched anyway, looking back out over Angella's kingdom. "I...I love her, Bow."

"Adora," Bow said. It wasn't a question.

Glimmer, on the other hand, gasped. "Adora? Seriously?" she blurted.

"She was *there* for me, Glimm," Catra whispered, leaning on the railing. "Shadow Weaver hurt me, so many times, and...Adora saved me. That was my whole life. Shadow Weaver hurting me, everyone else throwing me at her so it wouldn't be them, and Adora keeping me alive. And I left her there." She shook her head. "I thought I could give up on her after Perfuma, but...I can't. She's not like those versions of me that stayed and broke."

"We've talked about this! You had to get out, you tried to help Adora, and you don't know what you'd be if you stayed," Glimmer sighed, as explosive as her blurt.

"I do," Catra said, ears and tail drooping. "I saw them, in the portal. A few got better, but most of them, of *me,* became monsters. Adora still thinks the Horde's good, Glimmer. Shadow Weaver – she knows how to get into your head, twist you around inside until you think up is down and in is out." Catra curled up on herself, wishing she didn't have to be so *big* just then. "I have to save her, guys. I have to." She turned around at last, eyes wide as she watched Glimmer deflate and Bow straighten. "Help me? Please?"

"Of course we will, silly," Glimmer insisted, taking her hand.

"We're the Best Friends Squad," Bow agreed, as if that explained everything.

And maybe it did.

"Come on," Glimmer added. "You need to rest." Catra nodded, and Sparkles teleported them to Catra's room, the trip always easier in She-Ra mode–

–and Adora was *sleeping in Catra's bed,* snoring and drooling and the most beautiful thing she had ever seen.

And, because (Catra was sure) she wasn't allowed to have nice things, Glimmer screamed and pounced, blasting Adora right out of the bed.

"Huh? WHAH?!" Adora yelped – and turned a bracer she was wearing into the *Sword of Protection!* Catra was still frozen in place when Adora cried, "For the honor of Grayskull!"

Stars, and I thought she was beautiful before, Catra thought, staring as Adora became a white-and-gold version of Catra's own, most recent She-Ra form. Glimmer and Bow screamed and clung to each other. "She kept the She-Ra thing?" Glimmer cried. "Catra, do something!"

"Catra?" Adora glanced around for an instant before her gaze landed on Cat-Ra, eyes going wide. "Oh. Oh, wow. That's...I

mean, you look, you look good," Adora continued, managing a wavering smirk. "Finally embracing your inner She-Ra?" Then her smile vanished, and she rubbed her cheek where Glimmer hit her. "Hey. Ow. Who hit me?"

"Um, maybe *me,* Horde Scum?" Glimmer snapped, teleporting in front of Catra.

"Wait wait wait, what?" Adora babbled, looking around. This scan took a little longer, ending when her eyes landed on Catra's sketchbook. "Oh. *Oh!* This isn't – I'm not – Bow, could you explain alternate timelines to them, please?"

Catra sighed. *Because this day wasn't long enough, right?*

Chapter End Notes

> It has begun! The Turn Right/SCOP crossover is here, and both sets of Catras and Adoras are going to face revelations of all sorts. (More the SCOP Catradora than the TR Catradora, of course, but it's not all one-sided.)
>
> Turn RIght's next chapter (35, for those visiting...*from the future)* will focus on our visiting heroines, as they deal with a world unlike anything they were prepared for, then return here for a climactic showdown between Cat-Ra and the most powerful Shadow Weaver of a thousand worlds! It will all be here (in a month or so, if I'm honest) for Chapter Six: Reunion.

Reunion

Chapter Summary

> Continuing from A Beautiful Wish and Turn Right's ItC: Opposite Day. About the first half of this chapter is covering Opposite Day from different perspectives and moments, and the rest is, well, a reunion! *g*

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Bow bit his lip. *Serious thinking mode, activate,* Catra mused while he explained. "...guys, alternate timeline theory states that major decisions – or even minor ones, if they have major repercussions – can create different branches, each possibility existing on a different – time frequency, I guess?"

"Thanks, Best Boy," Catra said with a smirk. Bow, predictably, blushed.

"Something like that," not-Adora agreed. "My Catra, she's kind of vulnerable to that stuff because of a thing that happened in the Crystal Castle. It let me apologize to her and get her to join the Rebellion, but because of that, we keep ending up in these…" she trailed off, smile growing as she looked at Cat-Ra again. "…'fragments' where she stayed in the Horde. But not here!" Not-Adora laughed, because of *course* she did. "Here, you're She-Ra, and let me guess. I stayed in the Horde like an idiot, right?"

"Close enough, She-Dora," Glimmer quipped.

Catra groaned and double-facepalmed. "Only you would be happy about something like that, Adora." *Why are you* like *this?*

"The last three worlds we've been to, Catra was the bad guy, and she was...*really* good at it." Adora's smile vanished. "And that's not even counting the portal Catra – Void-Catra – Shadow Weaver

used to possess my…" Adora made a fist. *Oh, Stars,* Catra thought. "Doesn't matter. Maybe now she'll finally see how *good* she is!"

"Good luck, She-Dora," Glimmer sighed, glaring at Cat-Ra. "'"We've been trying to convince ours that she's a hero, and a friend, and *loved,* for *four years,* and it still hasn't stuck."

Catra's eyes went wide. *Sparkles...Glimmer...* Then pain spiked through her, and She-Ra *shattered,* like breaking glass. "Catra!" the others cried as Catra curled up reflexively.

"Okay...I'll admit," Catra admitted, hissing in spite of herself, "this isn't good."

"I'll heal you," Adora swore, "and then we'll get you to the infirmary."

"Wait, we can heal?" Catra blurted. *I have to learn that!*

Catra just barely noticed Bow nodding through blurred vision. "Hey, good Adora? If you're here because your Catra keeps falling into different timelines, where *is* your Catra?"

Adora gasped. "Oh no."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora stared at the stack of mines in the armory. "Heat bombs," she muttered, holding back memories of the princess party.

Other-Catra smirked. Adora hadn't realized how much she *missed* that. "Heat bombs," she echoed. "Like, all the princess pals except Sparkles have problems with fire or heat. Even Net-head–"

"'Netossa,'" Adora corrected absently. "*She left* me!" *Catra – this Catra – said,* Adora remembered, trying to decide how she felt about that.

Other-Catra laughed, and that almost broke Adora. *By the Horde, I missed that too,* the blonde realized. "I know, Adora," she sighed, shaking her head. "Has it been so long you forgot I do that?"

Adora smirked back, nudging Catra shoulder-to-shoulder. "I remember that *someone* has to keep your head from getting too big."

Catra smirked back. "Says the hair poof that walked like a Force Captain," she quipped, nudging back. They laughed together. "Besides, Nets has the Rebellion's one brain cell most of the time. Horde, that Sword turned you into an idiot."

"So what I'm hearing is, I'm *not* an idiot?" Adora shot back, smirk growing.

"Hey, don't get crazy on me," Catra retorted. They laughed again. *I...don't remember the last time I laughed this much,* Adora realized. "Of course that'd be your takeaway."

The moment didn't last. Catra's smile vanished, replaced with a fierce expression of relentless determination. Her ears weren't flat, but they'd pivoted back in what Adora thought of as 'hunt mode,' when Catra was at her most brilliant. "We can't just throw bombs at the problem. I tried that, and they threw some stupid rainbow princess crap back at us."

Adora stared. "Rainbow...princess...crap?" she stammered.

Other-Catra nodded. "I had Brightmoon. I *had* them. Then the plant princess showed up, and fish girl, and the ice brat, and they all did some sparkly chevron stance, and it was – I swear to Hordak, Adora, you threw a magic rainbow wave at me."

"The other me," Adora muttered. It all sounded so *impossible.*

Catra sighed, going over the heat bombs. "The other you. Yeah," she muttered back.

They stood there for a while, just counting heat bombs and processing. It was all so much. Almost too much. *No. It can't be too much yet. I won't let it,* Adora swore. *I have to figure out what I'm doing. I won't abandon anyone this time.* There was the slight problem of a fiercely dedicated Rebellion Catra and a fiercely dedicated Horde Catra, but...*I'll think of something.*

I have *to.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Not-Adora's eyes flew wide. "I almost forgot! You rescued Micah, but Peekablue's alive – probably, different timeline – but in the other worlds, Vultak had her in the Menagerie!"

Catra grimaced as she hung on to Angella's ship made of solid magic light. Her *flying* ship of solid magic light. *At least Sea Gull can't set it on fire,* she thought, claws almost digging into her palms right around the railing. Sea Hawk looked particularly grim without Mermista by his side. *The Runestone princesses have to protect their kingdoms–*

Catra's line of thought snapped in half when Vultak's tower came into view. *The Menagerie,* she thought, forcing back a shiver. *We'll save the animals later. Focus on what we can do, not what we can't. Abused princess first.*

With fierce twin cries, Ado-Ra and Cat-Ra leaped down and smashed through Vultak's roof, landing in his control room. Vultak squawked and leaped back, gaping at the She-Ra duo.

Peekablue was kneeling beside where Vultak had been, arms bound behind her, a collar with a – a *leash* dangling from it–

Catra lost it. The world literally tinted red as she screamed and rushed Vultak. "White Alert!" he cried, and his monsters rushed in.

Spinnerella howled with a rage Catra had never even imagined her having. Wind howled around her, tearing the air from the

Horde's forces. Adora didn't waste any time using her magic to calm the beasts, her power even freeing a few of them.

Guards and bots rushed in. Catra rushed back through them like a human lightning bolt, slashing through bots and throwing soldiers into walls before they could make ready, let alone take aim. The rest of the team raced to Peekablue's side. Sea Hawk sliced her free with two swipes of his magic saber while Angella basically *exploded* the collar off Peekablue's neck without leaving a mark. "We've got you, Peekie!" Netossa cried, shielding the rest of the rescue team while Spinnerella and the She-Ras drove off Vultak and his beasts.

Weird to think of more than one She-Ra, Catra mused, still amazed at how perfect her coordination was with an Adora she'd just met.

That's just it, though, isn't it? Catra thought, punching Styrax and a giant beetle into a wall while She-Dora blasted Vultak aside with a beam-slash from her sword. *Whatever else has changed, she's still...Adora.* Catra chuckled, stepping backwards towards the others while Micah and Glimmer worked on a teleport circle together. "Almost done!" Micah warned, looking up. "Adora, over here!"

With a frustrated snarl Catra understood more than she could say, Adora leaped back, landing beside Catra. Together, father and daughter completed the spell, and the team vanished in a whirl of rainbow light, reappearing in the field outside Brightmoon.

Glimmer pumped a fist in the air. "Woo-hoo!" she cheered, while Netossa and Spinnerella hugged a sobbing Peekablue. "You were *amazing.* It was, like, two She-Ras? Pfft, go home, evil." Catra fist-bumped Adora, while Bow took Glimmer's hand and Micah looked over the three other princesses. Angella swooped down, her expression an almost perfect mix of guilt and relief. Glimmer's joy drained away as she took in the ragged Peekablue, still holding onto her two friends. "Um, is she gonna be okay?"

Micah stood and hugged his daughter. “Someday, baby girl,” he whispered. “She just needs time.”

“Um, about that,” Adora jumped in, rubbing the back of her neck, “now that we’ve rescued Princess Peekablue, my Catra’s still probably in the Fright Zone?”

Peekablue stopped crying as if switched off, sitting upright. “No,” she gasped. “Your Catra is with the Horde.” Adora stared, gaping. “Not like that!” the princess added, waving one hand in denial. Then her eyes glowed royal blue. “Shadow Weaver...she wanted a Catra you once met, loyal to Hordak, in a harness...and...a ‘super pal trio?’ That can’t be right.”

“No, it is,” Adora blurted. “Can – I’m sorry, but can you tell me if she’s okay?”

Netossa glared, but Peekablue put a hand on the fierce princess’ shoulder. “It’s okay, ‘Tossa. Please, I want – need – to help.” She met Adora’s gaze. “I can connect your minds, but...She-Ra,” she continued, looking at Catra, “I don’t know if I can keep you out.”

Catra shrugged. “Then don’t,” She-Ra agreed. “Let’s do this.”

Peekablue took a deep breath and nodded–

At first, it reminded Catra of the portal, a field of grass swaying in the breeze, hanging in nothing. But that ‘nothing’ was a swirling rainbow of color and chimes, vibrant light yet soothing in rhythm. The other Catra, wearing some Brightmoon livery but with a mix of something more primal, stood in the center, staring around her. “Whoa – what – where are we?” Catra-1 blurted.

(Catra got the number from context, thanks to Peekablue.)

Adora-1 rushed over and kissed Catra-1, hugging her close. “I was so worried,” Adora whispered.

Catra-1 chuckled. “Hey, Adora,” she whispered back.

Cat-Ra couldn't help but smile. "Love," she replied, one tear escaping down her jawline. "You're in your love." She chuckled. "Peekablue chose a place Shadow Weaver could never find you."

Catra-1 laughed. "Wow, you're sappy," she quipped as the pair released each other. Cat-Ra laughed back, waving at the *everything* around them. Catra-1's eyes widened, ears darting up. "Sh-shut up!"

Cat-Ra smirked. "What? I didn't say anything."

Catra-1 huffed. "You know what? You're Catra-A." Adora-1 looked at her in confusion. "This timeline jumped the track, so I'm not giving it a number," she explained. "The others were all in order, more or less, plus this is the world where you stayed, so 'A' for Adora, too."

"Yeah, not important right now," Cat-Ra replied, raising an eyebrow. "Your Adora wants you away from Shadow Weaver, and I don't blame her."

"Where are you, Catra?" Adora-1 asked, holding her Catra's hand.

Catra-1 smirked again. "On my way to the Whispering Woods with Adora-A, her squad, Scorpia, and about half the heat bombs in the Fright Zone." Catra-A gasped. "Hey, I had to come up with a plan that sounded good. Look, I think their Adora's ready to bail, finally," she continued, throwing Catra-A a glare, "but I want to make sure she's committed."

Adora-1's jaw tightened. "How?"

"By being me," Catra-1 explained, smirk growing as she put one hand on her hip. "Well, Horde-me. She was already on her, like, fourth second thought, and watching me be mean has definitely shaken her."

Cat-Ra growled, taking a step towards her counterpart. Adora-1 stepped between them. "Define 'mean,'" she hissed.

"Relax," Catra-1 insisted, holding up her hands. "I'm just snapping at everyone, coming up with plans that sound horrible. I haven't hurt anyone, and those heat bombs should keep Shadow Weaver busy – even with all the extra powers – long enough for us to get the All-Dorks Squad out of the Horde."

Adora-1 sighed, but the sound was so fond it almost made Cat-Ra cry. *I really do miss her that much, don't I?* she realized. "Catra," Adora-1 complained.

Catra-1's expression turned serious in an instant. "Trust me, Adora," she pleaded. Adora nodded without hesitation. Catra-1 nodded, then turned to Cat-Ra. "Listen, Me-Ra," she quipped, "I can keep your Shadow Weaver busy with my Adora's help, if you think you can reach your Adora."

Catra-A flinched, looking away. "I...I don't know," she muttered. "I've tried so many times, but I keep messing it up."

Catra-1 slid her hand out of Adora's, then walked over to Cat-Ra. *Stars, am I really that small?* Catra-A wondered, looking down at her non-transformed counterpart. "Believe in her," Catra-1 insisted. "Believe that she's still the dork who patched you up, who promised to look out for you, who always believed in *you."*

Cat-Ra took a deep breath, then let it go. "Okay." She looked at Adora-1, her fellow She-Ra. "Come on. Let's go save us."

Adora's laugh was...*everything.*

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra-1 put the finishing touches on a harness like Catra-3's while the local Adora held the chest piece in place. "My Catra left, but you didn't," Adora-A asked suddenly. "Why not?"

Catra scoffed to hide her sudden bout of terror. *I'm only going to get one shot at this,* she thought. "I thought you needed me. I was wrong, *obviously."*

“But...why didn’t you leave with your...me?” Adora asked.

Catra slipped, her hex driver jumping off a bolt. “I wasn’t good enough for you to leave for me,” she hissed, casting a quick spell. Adora stared at the scars the glowed from almost *every part* of Catra’s body. She hated how vulnerable that made her look. *It’s for Adora,* she reminded herself, *even if she’s not my Adora.* “Why should you have been good enough for me to leave for *you?”* Catra finished tightening the bolt.

Adora went pale as she nodded. “I’m not,” she whispered. “Excuse me for a minute.”

Catra-1 froze, all her fury melting away as the blonde walked towards the transport. “Adora?” she gasped. Adora threw up almost silently, but Catra’s senses were too sharp for Adora to hide anything from her. *It’s to save her,* Catra reminded herself. That almost made it stop hurting.

She focused on being angry as she organized unloading heat bombs, checking her combat harness one last time. *One slip, and Shadow Weaver will figure it out,* she thought, risking a sideways glance at the serene witch. *If she hasn’t already.* She looked over Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle. None of them looked happy with the situation, sharing familiar glances. *We learned to talk with our eyes, because the witch was always listening,* she remembered. *We just weren’t as good at it as we thought.*

Scorpia walked over, whistling in what Catra assumed was an attempt at innocence. She didn’t bother snapping at her. *This Scorpia never became friends with–* she thought, but then Scorpia started talking. “You know, I always kinda liked our Catra,” she admitted.

Catra indulged in a glare, tail lashing. “Are you serious? What is wrong with you?”

“Nothing!” Scorpia blurted, half-jumping in place. “I, I, I just thought she was nice for, you know, a Rebel. It was always fun

fighting her, too."

"That part's the only thing you said that makes sense," Catra growled, testing a grapple-whip just to be sure. Scorpia yelped. "I've never been 'nice.'" She shook her head. "Maybe the stupid Sword kills brain cells or something."

"It doesn't," Adora insisted, striding over in her own combat harness. It crackled with crimson lightning, making Catra twitch. "She's been behind most of the Rebellion's strategies."

Catra couldn't help preening just a little. "Well, duh. I'm probably smarter than any of those annoying, sparkly princesses even with half a brain." Adora chuckled, and a shiver ran down Catra's spine. *Sekhmet. What is wrong with me?* she wondered, clenching her fists. *It's so...easy, being the old me.*

"I...just…" Adora-A looked over at Shadow Weaver. The sorceress was moving the Whispering Woods out of the way, a few trees at a time, then literally freezing them in place. "...do you really like being in the Horde? I mean, you were always the one who wanted to leave."

Catra huffed. "Looks like we never get to the top together, but I made it without you, Adora," she pointed out, walking over to the transport. Tanks rolled into position behind it. "You can make it without me."

Adora grabbed Catra's hand. Scorpia gulped, but her eyes did that weird stars-thing Bow's could sometimes. "But are you happy?"

With a snarl, Catra yanked her hand away. "Is anyone happy in the Horde, Adora?" she demanded.

Adora looked at Scorpia, and Catra sighed, ears and tail drooping...until Scorpia glanced at Shadow Weaver. "Well, I used to be, before...before," Scorpia muttered, rubbing her pincer tips together.

"Shadow Weaver!" Cat-Ra roared, landing in her path like a thunderbolt. The local Best Friends Squad joined her, as did Perfuma and Mermista. "Still trying the same old tricks?"

"Oh, Catra," Shadow Weaver mocked, "you never learn." She snapped her fingers, and Catra-1 used her harness to swing over. "I think you'll find that this situation is not one you're prepared for."

"That's what you think!" Adora-1 cried, leaping at Shadow Weaver as She-Ra.

"What?!" Shadow Weaver cried, racing back on a platform of vines. "Impossible!"

Catra-1 laughed. "Oh, Shadow Weaver," she mocked right back, "you always think you know everything, and you're never right." With a savage yank, she used her Earthshadow to control the transport, driving it right at the sorceress. When Shadow Weaver swallowed it up in most of her vine-mass, Catra-1 smirked and snapped her fingers.

The explosion impressed even her.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra-A rushed toward her Adora, not daring to use her super-speed in case her She-Ra form shattered again. The rest of Adora's squad joined her, Scorpia looming behind them. "Adora," she gasped, skidding to a halt, "I know I've sucked at this, and I'm – I'm *sorry* – because I always made it about us, but it's not. I get that now. Please, the Horde is hurting people, *everyone,* and you can't want to be a part of that!"

Adora lowered her staff, pulling off her lightning vest. "You're right," she sighed, throwing the vest aside.

Lonnie gasped. "Adora, are you serious?" she cried, darting beside the blonde with arms thrown outstretched. "The Horde is our home!"

“A prison’s not a home, Lonnie,” Catra replied. Lonnie snarled at her, stun batons out.

Scorpia put one gentle pincer on Lonnie’s shoulder. “Lonnie. It’s true. They’re...the stuff we’ve been doing, that Shadow Weaver’s been doing, it’s what they say the princesses do.”

“And what have they done – what has Catra done – besides protect people?” Adora said, dropping her staff. “From us?”

Lonnie froze, looking at Kyle and Rogelio. The big guy shrugged, holstering his baton. Kyle just nodded. “Has fighting Catra like this ever felt right to you, Lonnie?” Kyle asked. Lonnie took a shuddering, angry breath. Cat-Ra just caught a glimpse of Tavor aiming a spell at Adora.

“Look out!” Catra cried, rushing between Tavor and Adora. The spell shook the fractured She-Ra magic down to her core, leaving the mighty Champion of Power shaking and frozen.

With a cry of absolute fury, Adora kicked her staff back into her hand and slammed it into Tavor’s skull. He went down with a quiet whimper.

The world flickered and wavered in Catra’s sight. “Heh. Nice one...Adora…” She-Ra vanished, and Catra-A couldn’t help taking a nap on the spot.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Both Adoras stared in horror as Cat-Ra collapsed, the terrible void-wound still running down her neck and arm from her eye. Shadow Weaver screamed and threw the ruins of the transport off of her with shadows and vines. “Treacherous mongrel!” the sorceress cried, gathering all her powers around her hands. “I will skin you and gift your pelt to Vultak for his wall!”

”No,” Adora-1 replied, shocked at the calm in her voice. “You’re done.” She couldn’t move as fast as Cat-Ra, but She-Ra granted her speed far beyond anything the shaken Shadow Weaver could

manage. She sliced through vines, ice, lightning, and all three Runestone shards with two quick slashes of the Sword. The eruption of magic threw Shadow Weaver back, crumpling. Adora-1 transformed the Sword into its shield form, preparing to block the gathering blast Shadow Weaver was hiding with her semi-crumpled body.

Adora-A fired stun bolts from her staff, disrupting Shadow Weaver's spell and driving her even further back. "Weren't you listening? We're *through* with you! You'll never hurt Catra again!" Scorpia and Lonnie stepped between Adora-A and the few remaining Horde soldiers as Rogelio and Kyle got Adora-A's back.

The Horde ran. It was almost ordinary by then for She-Ra.

Catra-1 rushed to the local Catra's side. "Oh crap. That's not good."

Glimmer looked at Adora's Catra with wide, tear-filled eyes. "Please, tell me you can do something," she whispered.

Catra frowned. "If my Adora couldn't heal this, then I can only think of one other place they can help her. Halfmoon."

Glimmer's fear melted into confusion. "What-moon?" she asked.

Bow got it, though. "The ancient home of the magicats? You know where it is?"

Catra nodded. "I kept a skiff out of the fight in case we needed to move wounded." She shook her head at Catra-A. "Never thought I'd be loading a She-Ra me onto it. Seriously, am I this dumb, or does the Sword really kill brain cells?"

"Hey!" Adora-1 objected, letting She-Ra go.

"The Sword kills brain cells," Adora-A added, throwing in a smirk of her own. "Definitely."

"HEY!" Adora-1 blurted. The others laughed – even Catra-A.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

‘Beautiful’ didn’t even begin to describe Halfmoon.

It was just like Catra’s vision had been in the portal-world. Towering spires covered in lapis lazuli pulled streams through the air to fill overhead aqueducts, forming shining arches of liquid that left tiny rainbows in their wake. Long buildings of crimson brick were lit by crystals called tiger’s eyes, soft golden light shining between red bands, lighting stone columns. Above them, archways of sand-colored stone held up bridges between the buildings overhead. Magicats rode graceful skiffs, elegant driftwagons, and Takdryl dragon-horses.

And the people – *her* people! Magicats of every size and varied gender stared as they passed, with fur in all kinds of colors, muscular ones, slender ones, fierce ones, gentle ones – they were real and vibrant and *alive!* It was a *miracle.*

Catra just hoped that they could spare a bit of miracle for her. She-Ra was out of reach, and all of her friends’ healing magic could only hold back the void covering her arm and face. “Hey, stay with us,” Catra-1 grumbled, stroking her fur and doing something to the void-energy that kept it from hurting. “You still don’t remember anything? Princess Felicia? Uncle Percy? ...mom?”

Catra shook her head. “Nope. Maybe I have to see them.”

“That’s what triggered our Catra’s memories,” Adora-1 agreed. Their Adora held onto Catra’s good hand as if to anchor her in life through sheer willpower. Glimmer and Bow hovered over her, and if Catra were feeling better, she’d make a joke about them hovering on a skiff. *Entrapta would probably get it,* she mused, glancing at her old friend. The tech princess was muttering at full speed while going over a tracker pad. *Maybe not.*

“This is ridiculous,” Catra groaned. “Look, just burn one of my lives, I’ve got seven left.”

“Not a chance,” Glimmer insisted. “Besides, what if it doesn’t work?”

Before Catra could quip back, a slender magicat woman with purple fur and blue eyes rushed over. “Catriska!” she cried, then froze, looking between her and Catra-1.

“Hey, Felicia, long story, short version, she’s your Catra – Catriska – but Shadow Weaver wiped her memory, I’m her from another timeline and led us here,” Catra-1 explained.

Felicia looked between the two Catras, eyes wide. “What happened?”

“Portal,” Catra-A groaned. “Hordak. Shadow Weaver. I’m She-Ra, had to fix it.”

Felicia broke into a wide smile. “You’re She-Ra? Who am I kidding, of *course* you’re She-Ra! Who else would it be?”

“Catriska!” A man’s deep voice cried out as he leaped onto the skiff. He was a big, muscular magicat, gray furred with white points, and his golden eyes matched Catra’s one–

Pain lanced through Catra’s head, and she dreamed.

“Catriska C’yra D’riluth!” Mom huffed, shaking her head while Triss hid under a pile of sheets, giggling. “I’m going to ground that girl until her First Change, I swear...”

The dream jumped.

“That’s it, Triss – extend, swing, retract, aim, jab *– perfect!” Catriska beamed as she went through Uncle Percy’s clawsword drill side by side with him.*

Again.

“Look, Triss-sis, I caught it!” Felicia cheered, the small fish flopping in the kitten’s claws while Catriska watched with pride.

Again.

Catriska laughed. "Again, Uncle Percy! Again!

Sir Percival laughed back, playing with the compressed hilt. "Well, if my favorite niece insists," he quipped.

"That's cheating. I'm your only niece," Catriska noted with a pout. Kyra smiled and hugged her daughter.

Etheria came back into focus.

Catra-A blinked and looked around. She was in some kind of infirmary, with a bed that was surprisingly comfortable for how soft it was. Adora, Glimmer, Bow, Perfuma, Mermista, Felicia, Percival, her and Adora's weird timeline clones, and two older magicats she did not recognize.

Until she did, her memories filling in younger versions of their faces. "Princess Selina? Baron Claudus?" Catra asked, mouth falling open.

"Queen and king now, I'm afraid," Selina replied with a sad smile.

Catra groaned, sitting up. She was careful to use her left hand to push the sheets back – except that exposed her undamaged right arm. "Wh...what?" she asked, glancing down at it. Her muscles bulged briefly, fingers shrinking, before returning to normal.

"Normally, Bubasti undergo a sacred ritual to guide our people through the First Change," Selina explained, patting Catra's now-normal hand. "In your case, your condition was serious enough that we flowed the knowledge in with the healing of your memories. That allowed us to heal the void damage with the help of the alien She-Ra."

Catra-1 smirked, because of course she did. "Told you. Halfmoon." She and Adora-1 became translucent. "Scut," she muttered, looking through her body. Felicia's ears shot up in alarm. "Relax,

we’re fine, just going home. Just remember, you two are always stronger together, no matter what Shadow Loser says.”

“No matter how bad things get, you’ll be okay as long as you have each other,” Adora-1 insisted with a smile. “That’s your real promise.” With that, they were gone.

Catra huffed out a sigh. Adora took her hand and gave it a squeeze even Catra couldn’t pretend wasn’t comforting. “Where are Lonnie and the boys? Scorpia?”

“Entrapta and Frosta brought them home,” Glimmer explained. “To Brightmoon, I mean.”

Catra nodded. She put the dozens of jumbled emotions – remembering her mom and what happened to her, getting Adora back, the ways Shadow Weaver had used them, finding Halfmoon and what was left of her family – in a box in the back of her mind. “Okay. Status?”

“Wh – you need to rest, Catra!” Bow blurted.

“Maybe the Sword really does kill brain cells,” Adora quipped with that infuriating (sexy) smug grin.

“Sh-shut up!” Catra yelped, pushing Adora back. The others all laughed. *Stars. I have to do everything around here.* She turned to let her feet drop to the floor, preparing to get up.

For some reason, the room was rocking beneath her like the Dragon’s Daughter V. “Oh, no you don’t,” Glimmer ordered, pushing Catra back towards the bed.

Catra pushed back, but then Felicia helped, and Bow, and Adora, and the whole palace was spinning just a little and *Stars* was she tired and maybe she could rest just a little...

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora looked out over the magnificent city. *It really is beautiful,* she thought, watching hover-wagons and winged dragon-horses fly lazily in the distance. *What am I* doing *here?*

Princess Glimmer strode over with a forced confidence so familiar that it made Adora's heart ache. "So! Adora. Force Captain Adora. I mean, not Force Captain any more, ha ha!" She swung her arms, burning off nervous energy the way Adora and Catra both used to do. *Does Catra still do that?* Adora wondered. "How are you, y'know, adjusting, to all this?"

"Me? Pfft, you've never been to Halfmoon either," Adora said with a smirk, which vanished instantly. "Wait, have you?"

Glimmer's smile vanished with Adora's. "No, no, I just mean, you know, being with the rebels. The good guys!" She waved. "And I know the Horde said they're the good guys but–"

"It's okay, princess. Your High...ness?" Adora asked.

"Glimmer is fine!" she blurted.

Adora nodded, sighed, and looked out over the city again. "I'll be honest, it's a lot. I didn't want to believe...my whole life, everything we were ever taught about the world, the Horde, you...but it's all lies," she said, making a fist. "All they did was lie to us about – about everything! And Shadow Weaver, she always acted like she cared about me, but all that stuff about Catra, and the threats, and – why did I ever think that was normal? It wasn't even normal in the *Horde!"*

Glimmer walked over, hand hovering with a quiver over Adora's shoulder. Adora shrugged, and Glimmer put the hand there. It was...nice. "Catra told me once that 'normal is what you know' when she was trying to explain the Horde." The princess let go, then leaned on the railing beside Adora. "I used to think that people in the Horde were evil because evil people just...you know, joined. Catra helped me – all of us – see what Shadow Weaver and Hordak are doing to you. I mean, kids?" She shook her head.

"I couldn't help but think, what if I'd grown up in the Horde? If Shadow Weaver had gotten me? I would've been just the same as you guys."

"Catra knew," Adora whispered. "Catra always knew, even when Shadow Weaver stole her life right out of her *head."* Adora pounded the railing with a fist, leaving a faint crack. "And – and that other time world, where I found the Sword and got to be the hero while Catra stayed for me then just...how could she think that's better? It's not right!" Adora deflated. "It should be right."

Glimmer sighed and nodded. "It's a mess."

Catra strode out, smirking. "Lots of stuff is screwed up," she said, wearing a crimson magicat top and blue slacks with gold trim. "That's where we come in."

"Catra!" they cried as one, hugging her. "Are you okay?" Adora added, looking her over.

"Yeah," Catra said, her smile softer than it had been since they were kids. "It's been rough, but I'm in one piece again."

Glimmer chuckled. "Yeah. I should...check on Bow." Before either of them could say anything, she vanished.

The two ex-Horde soldiers blinked, looked at each other, and laughed. "Now will you take the Sword, Adora?" Catra asked, transforming it from the bracer on her arm and offering it to the blonde again.

Adora looked at it. "No," she said, pushing it back with one gentle hand.

Catra's smile vanished. "Look, Adora–"

"I don't deserve it," Adora insisted.

"Core-scut," Catra cursed. "I could've dragged you to Brightmoon two years ago when I tied you up in our first fight. I told myself it

was because you wouldn’t cooperate, but it was really because I was afraid not to be special any more. This is yours.”

Adora’s smile felt more real than anything she’d done in ten years. “You respected my choices, even when they were wrong. Do you have any idea how much I love you for that?” Catra froze, jaw dropping. “Those other versions of us had that whole ‘getting married’ thing they’re doing. I don’t understand that, but I know I don’t want to wait another day. Another minute!”

Catra huffed. “What does that have to do with–” she began.

“Their Catra can do She-Ra stuff without the Sword,” Adora explained. “Being a better soldier isn’t about deserving.” She took Catra’s free hand. “I’m going to trust that when we’re ready, I can do that too. The Sword is a thing. It’s a cool thing, and I want you to have it.”

Catra quivered for a second. “I *really* want to kiss you,” she admitted.

Adora kissed her instead.

After four years, they were both home at last.

Chapter End Notes

dies of embarrassment AGAIN

It's been far too long since I updated this. I'm probably only going to do one more chapter of this so I can focus on Turn Right (and my professional work), but I want to thank everyone who came along for the ride. Assume that Catradora defeats Horde Prime and finds Eternia in the years that follow Shadow Weaver getting hers.

And Shadow Weaver *will* get hers.

Judgement Day

Chapter Summary

> Some Shadow Weavers can find redemption by admitting to how far they fell. SCOP's Shadow Weaver is not one of them. The final battle between Cat-Ra and the Runestone Weaver will decide the fate of Etheria – and the universe!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shadow Weaver adjusted her mask, staring at the empty slots where fragments of the Heart-Blossom and Fractal Flake once rested. *This is a minor setback,* she insisted to herself. Reality intruded in short order. *Losing Adora, however, is not. May that mongrel beast suffer a thousand dooms for taking her from me!* The sorceress took in a long, deep breath, then let it go. *I will regain the Runestone shards. Once I possess all five – or even six, with the Sword of Protection – I will be all-powerful. The magic will at last be mine!*

"Hey, Shadow Weaver."

Shadow Weaver whirled in shock, shadows and lightning already summoned to hand, and watched in disbelief as Catra sauntered into her sanctum. Her tail swayed with calm nonchalance, ears twitching with curiosity. The Sword of Protection rested on Catra's wrist in bracer form. "Y'know," she continued, "I hated this place for a long time, but now that you're, well," she snickered and waved at Shadow Weaver's still-disheveled frame, "this, I gotta admit, I see the appeal." She ran a single claw along the panel at the base of the Black Garnet.

"Do you now," Shadow Weaver hissed. She gathered magic, pulling ether and darkness and power into her through the Spell of Obtainment –

Wait.

Catra noticed the change in her demeanor, ears pivoting up instead of back. "That's not the Sword of Protection," Shadow Weaver noted, straightening. "I sense magic in you, but not remotely on a par with She-Ra." Her eyeslits narrowed. "Either you are distracting me for those idiotic princesses, or..."

The form of 'Catra' melted away, to reveal a blonde Kamelian in a black body suit and stylish bootlets. Even Shadow Weaver, who had not cared about physical attractiveness for decades, was forced to admit they cut an exquisite figure. They bowed. "So, did you like it, darling?"

"Hmph," Shadow Weaver replied, but couldn't help a chuckle. "Before I consume your life energy, tell me why it matters whether or not I 'liked' your mimicry."

The Kamelian sighed, tail curling with dramatic force. "Oh come now, honey, you're not going to kill me out of hand when you might be able to use me." Their smile was razor teeth with the shape of a crescent blade. "Double Trouble, at your service. For the right price."

Now *that* got Shadow Weaver's attention. "A spy. A mercenary one, at that." She stroked the base of her mask, as she would have with her chin once. "And skilled enough to convince me you were a girl I raised, one who has become my nemesis."

"Indeed," Double Trouble said, placing a hand on their chest. "You've been having a great deal of trouble with those princesses the last few months, haven't you?" Shadow Weaver's smile vanished. *Adora,* she thought, fury and frustration roaring through her. The Kamelian's grin sharpened. "Of course, if something were to throw them off their game, disrupt their happy little princess club, bring to Brightmoon a little *chaos*...well. I'm sure a clever sorceress like yourself could find ways to leverage some infighting."

Shadow Weaver looked her ‘guest’ over and considered her options, while lengthening her shadow to cover all the exits. *They are likely skilled enough to escape through pipes, let alone vents. Although their bargain might be worth the trouble.* She paced around the shapeshifter. Their smug calm might have convinced her to accept their offer if it didn’t infuriate her so. Inspiration struck as she thought about the creature’s abilities. *Besides. I have another idea, one that does not risk being outbid.* “An interesting proposition,” she replied, stopping to face Double Trouble just within arm’s reach. “As it happens, I have need for someone capable of reaching the inner sanctums of the princesses.” She held out her hand, and a curved dagger flew to it. Double Trouble didn’t flinch. “All I require are tiny slivers of the Runestones. Three shards from each, the size of the Black Garnet fragment on my mask.”

Double Trouble pouted. “The infiltrations won’t even be a challenge. I presume your carving knife will prevent the stones’ magic from giving me away?”

“Of course,” Shadow Weaver snapped. “I’m not an idiot. Speaking of which.” She grasped the Kamelian’s arm. They tried to pull away, but found that her magic prevented them from changing form. Or moving anything besides their eyes, really. It satisfied her to watch those eyes go wide with terror even as the smile remained fixed and powerless. “Taking the carvings will be somewhat unpleasant. Runestones tend to...exude something of their element when cut. Then again, I think you’ll find that my bargaining position is stronger than you realized.” Their breath and heartbeat quickened, helplessness finally instilling the terror that her aura had not. “Oh, come now.” She indulged in another smile of her own, certain the actor could see it in the mask’s eyeslits. “I’m not going to kill you out of hand...when I might be able to use you.”

Double Trouble couldn’t scream while Shadow Weaver’s sorcery overwhelm their thoughts and will, so she laughed in the scream’s place.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra took a deep breath. "Okay. Let's start today's council meeting with a quick summary of the current strategic conditions."

Mermista snorted. "Uh, is no one, like, gonna say anything about Catra *purring?"* she asked. Frosta snickered.

Adora sat up straighter at Catra's side, smiling, while the magicat fought a blush. "I am not!" Catra objected.

"Aw, it's almost like you like me or something," Adora quipped, smile growing.

Catra groaned. "Don't push your luck, dork," she retorted. "Strategic. Conditions."

Glimmer chuckled, holding hands with Bow under the table (as if even the other humans in the room couldn't tell). "Alliance winning everywhere, Horde losing everywhere, Fright Zone desperate and building something big, summary complete," Brightmoon's princess rattled off.

Aaand Catra was distracted from being frustrated with (her) Adora (situation) by being frustrated with Glimmer. "We are *not* winning *everywhere.* Vultak stalled the Meadowlands campaign with three armored divisions, and we haven't been able to advance into Scorpion Hill."

"But you've freed most of my people," Scorpia gushed, pincers clasped and smile bright. "I mean, I think we're doing great."

"Trust me," Peekablue said, her voice quiet, "we all know how dangerous Vultak is." Catra's tail lashed behind her, unable to push aside how long the unfortunate Gar princess had been Vultak's captive.

"Yeah, and those tank divisions have cost them any hope of advancing in the east," Netossa reminded her, pointing out how far the battle lines had moved from the Whispering Woods. The

eastern Rebellion had pushed Hordak's forces all the way back to the Fright Zone's ramparts. "So the real question is, are we ready to knock Hordak off his throne?"

Angella smiled, clasping her hands at her waist. "A question that we pose to you, She-Ra, our expert in anti-Horde strategy."

I will not blush, d'ast it, Catra swore, her fur flat against her cheeks. Micah's smile grew. "Okay. My biggest concern right now is Shadow Weaver."

Perfuma shuddered, and Scorpia slid her chair closer to the plant princess. "That...sorceress...is terrible and cunning," Petals said, composing herself with a shake of her head, "but she has lost the stolen fragments of our Runestones."

"Yeah, thanks to Ado-Ra and other you," Glimmer quipped, grinning.

Catra shook her head. "Listen. Now that she knows she can use more than one Runestone at a time, Shadow Weaver's going to be obsessed with the power."

Adora snorted. "Being obsessed with power is pretty much her whole personality," she added. Micah's nod of agreement was downcast and grim. Even Catra's chuckle was harsh.

"My point is, going after Hordak means going through Shadow Weaver," Catra pointed out. "Even if she doesn't stop us from going in – I'd call that a 50/50 guess at this point – she'll definitely try to kill us before we can escape."

Frosta leaned forward, jaw set tight. "Why would she protect Hordak? Haven't you been saying this whole time she doesn't care about him? Or anybody?"

"Yeah, but *nobody* likes her. She needs Hordak to keep the Horde loyal," Catra explained, nails tapping on the war table. "Shadow Weaver wouldn't be able to keep more than a tenth of the army loyal as Horde Lord. It doesn't matter either way, though. Any

plan to bring down the Horde has to take them both into account."

Felicia tapped the image of the Meadowlands on the holo-map. "What about Vultak? Couldn't Shadow Weaver put him on the throne? Or use him to keep the army in line?"

Catra shrugged. "I don't know much about Vultak. From what I can tell, he's been happy playing god in his tower away from all the fighting." She carefully didn't stare at Peekablue. "Thing is, he won't want to lose that, and he'll lose everything if we win. So, like I said, toss-up."

Adora blinked. "Is that the same as 50% odds?" she asked.

Catra chuckled. "Right, you're still new. Yeah, toss-up is a weird Brightmoon word for that."

"It's not *weird,"* Glimmer insisted, pouting just a bit.

I'll explain it to Adora later, Catra decided. "Look, point is, Shadow Weaver's going to be a pain in the tail no matter what our plans are, and she's not going to leave the Fright Zone as long as she only has one Runestone shard. So, short version, I want to double security on all the Runestones. Take me to–" Catra cleared her throat. "I mean. With your permission, Your Majesty, I would like to see the Moonstone."

Adora snickered while Angella smiled like her namesake. "Of course, Catra. Come."

"Everyone else with a Runestone," Catra said while she followed Angella, "either send word or check back."

Scorpia held up a pincer. "Um..."

"You don't 'have' a Runestone, even if the Garnet is yours by right," Catra explained, rolling her eyes but her smile fond.

Adora's snicker turned into a full-blown chuckle. "What? 'Yours by right?' You've really turned into a princess, Princess."

Catra cheek fur flattened enough for her blush to show. "Sh-shut up!" she blurted, shoving Adora's shoulder. Adora shoved back. They laughed.

Catra's laughter stopped when she caught an unfamiliar mix of scents. "Holy Saz, what…" The magicat rushed to the Moonstone, darting around it.

Glimmer teleported to Catra's side while the others rushed over. "Catra, what's wrong?" she asked.

"Smells that don't belong here. Can't tell if it's one person or three," Catra explained.

Micah's eyebrows skyrocketed. "*You* can't tell?" He immediately drew a magic circle and gasped. "Oh no. Kamelian."

Catra looked at him from around the Moonstone. "A what now?"

Angella's wings wilted. "The one species on Etheria to have lost more members than yours," she explained. "They are natural shapeshifters. Hordak feared their powers, so he targeted their kingdom first. The Horde shattered their society and scattered their people almost immediately after he took the Scorpion Kingdom."

"That's bad," Catra muttered, her nose leading her to the bottom of the Moonstone. Someone – the Kamelian, presumably – had cut three neat slices out of the base, each the size of Shadow Weaver's Garnet shard. Catra scowled. "That's worse."

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Hordak turned one final bolt into place. At long, *long* last, the portal device was truly complete. *And yet it will not function without the Sword of She-Ra, according to Entrapta,* he mused. The thought of the genius princess did…problematic things to

Hordak's emotional state. *No. I must return to Lord Prime. I* will *return to Lord Prime. He is the Light. All else is shadow.*

As though on cue, Shadow Weaver strode in with a clearly brainwashed Kamelian. Vultak and...Admiral Scurvy?...followed her. Hordak's eyes narrowed. There were five Runestone Shards on the witch's brow, and her eyes glowed blue and gold like mockeries of the She-Ra's. "Ah, there you are, 'Lord' Hordak," Shadow Weaver said, her tone more insubordinate than ever.

"Vultak. Scurvy. I did not order your presence," Hordak noted. The men both smiled. Hordak frowned back. "Explain yourselves. Quickly."

Scurvy laughed without mirth. "You hear that, Vultak? He wants us to explain ourselves!"

"You are a failure, Hordak," Shadow Weaver accused, floating past the clone and toward his throne. "It is time for someone more… familiar with Etheria's unique properties to take command."

Hordak stared at the witch for a long moment. Then he laughed, though unlike Scurvy, the Horde Lord was a touch amused. "I would ask if this were a joke, but you *are* the joke." Shadow Weaver's eyes narrowed to slits. "I have been preparing for your betrayal since the day you came to my domain." Signals went out to those Hordak knew were loyal. Another gift of Entrapta's…time in the Horde came to life in his armor. Reconfiguration systems activated, preparing for his defense. "No Runestones will save you. The Horde will not follow you."

Hordak could almost see Shadow Weaver smile through the mask. "Will it not?" she asked, then snapped her fingers. The Kamelian changed shape into Hordak himself. *Mm. Almost clever,* he mused while she continued. "You have hidden from your own followers for almost two decades, Hordak. They do not see you as a person. You are a symbol of what duty requires of them. I would hardly require the greatest actor the Kamelian people ever produced to replace you." She snapped again, and the Kamelian returned to

their natural state. Shadow Weaver stroked the terrified shapeshifter's hair. "Though I have that very person, as it happens."

Octavia, Grizzlor, and Callix burst in. "Lord Hordak, what's wrong – you!" Octavia blurted, pointing a stun rod at Shadow Weaver. "Took you longer than I expected, witch."

Even through the slits, Hordak could see Shadow Weaver roll her eyes. "Oh, for Ether's sake." She vanished in a burst of multicolored light, reappearing behind Hordak's loyalists. Ice formed and melted, then waves loomed overhead. "I wield all the might of Etheria. You have no power that can stand before me. Not one."

Hordak formed the cannon on one arm and the shield on the other. "Vultak. I have completed the portal machine." That got both shadow-wielders' attention. "Would you betray Prime now, on the cusp of our triumph?"

Vultak stared at the device for several seconds. Shadow Weaver and Admiral Scurvy both fidgeted. "It...still requires the Sword of Protection," he noted.

Hordak scoffed. "Whom do you think has a better chance of taking it? Me, or the sorceress?"

With a shrug, Vultak put civil war into motion. "The magicat fears Shadow Weaver. She doesn't fear you."

"Her?" Hordak waved in dismissal at Shadow Weaver. "Why would She-Ra fear her?"

"When someone puts that many scars on a child," Vultak explained, pouring cold horror through the Horde Lord, "it writes terror into their soul."

Hordak stared at Shadow Weaver in horror. "You…what?"

Shadow Weaver huffed. “You gave me a generation to mold. Do not pretend that you now care what I did with one unruly mongrel.”

Hordak roared and opened fire on the sorceress. “Die,” he snarled while chaos erupted around them. *“Die. DIE!”*

Shadow Weaver didn’t die.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Adora couldn’t help the occasional glance of amazement while She-Ra carved through bots.

She’d always known that Catra had made the rainbow magic her own. It had given Adora hope that her friend was still in the Princess of Power long before the alternate Catra helped her see the Horde’s evil. But even with the other princesses performing battlefield miracles, from Mermista washing away an entire company to Frosta halting five tanks in place with a single gesture, She-Ra was in a class by herself.

Adora couldn’t help a smirk at the sight of Catra’s scowl, standing atop the biggest robot the Horde had ever fielded with her Sword in its metal skull. “This doesn’t make sense,” she muttered.

Scorpia chuckled. “Well, Adora handled most of our strategy,” she explained, causing Adora to blush, “so, yeah, I don’t think Shadow Weaver’s really doing so good right now.”

“Maybe it’s a distraction,” Frosta argued. “We show up here, then bam!” The child princess punched her palm. “She hits…I dunno, Dryl?”

Entrapta held up a tracker pad with one hair tendril. “Nope!” she cheered, the rest of her attention in the guts of a robot with First Ones crystals inside it. “No major Horde activity anywhere outside the Fright Zone.”

That got the attention of the former Horde soldiers. "Wait," Adora blurted, "does that mean there's activity *inside* the Fright Zone?"

"Like, how do you even know that?" Mermista asked, her fierce gaze belying her bored tone.

"Oh, my Horde bot control virus is enjoying unprecedented success," Entrapta explained, still working on her captured bot. "I suspect that Hordak has stopped updating his anti-virus software, since I'm pretty sure he and Shadow Weaver are trying to kill each other." She stroked the bot's outer shell with one actual hand. "I think I'll call you...Susan. You feel like a Susan."

Catra raced to Entrapta's side so quickly, Adora almost thought she'd learned to teleport. "Let me see that!" Entrapta 'handed' the pad to She-Ra. The others gathered behind her almost instantly. "Whoa..."

The Fright Zone was consumed in battle. The Horde was split almost evenly, with a slight majority of soldiers following the Hordak who was fighting Shadow Weaver. Another Hordak stood by Shadow Weaver's side with Vultak, Scurvy, a bald woman with a tentacle harness, and Dylamug. Scorpia gasped. "Dylamug and Callix are fighting?" she asked.

Catra looked at Adora in confusion. "They were always partners, teammates," Adora explained. "I think they're both from wherever Hordak came from?"

"They're from *spaaace!"* Entrapta gushed.

"Uh...huh," Catra grunted. Adora worried while Catra watched the battle. *She doesn't seem sure what to do with this.* Adora frowned. *Well, that's fair. Neither do I.*

After almost a minute of this, Catra swiped down on the pad and called Queen Angella. The monarch looked up in surprise from...was that paperwork? *I'll never get over how normal she is,* Adora thought, remembering holograms of a monster in training simulations. "Catra? Is something wrong?"

"N – I don't think so," Catra replied. "The Fright Zone is melting down. Figuratively, but it could end up literal the way Hordak and Shadow Weaver are going at it."

"Shadow Weaver is in rebellion…against Hordak?" Angella sounded as surprised as the princesses clearly felt. Adora was… less surprised. "That is unexpected."

"She's using her shapeshifter to mimic Hordak. I should've thought of that." Catra muttered the second sentence. Adora rubbed Catra's back, eliciting a gentle purr. "Shadow Weaver hasn't switched sides, not with Vultak and Scurvy backing her. It's an attempted coup."

Entrapta let out a thoughtful hum. "Maybe we could work together with Hordak?" she suggested. The others looked at her in shock, Catra in particular, but Adora…*Maybe she has a point?* she wondered.

Catra was having none of it. "Uh, how about no?" she snapped. "Hordak started all of this. None of us would be living with this messed-up war if he hadn't killed and lied his way into an army in the first place." Entrapta's hair and expression both wilted. That softened She-Ra's expression. "Look, Traps, I get it, Hordak builds impressive stuff, but he's the bad guy."

"He's a clone," Entrapta explained, eyes wide and pleading.

Mermista raised an eyebrow that was far too dry for a water princess. "Like, a what now?" she asked.

"A grown copy," Adora explained. "He told us once when we were working on the portal. 'A clone of the emperor of the known universe,' he said. Etheria's in some…alternate dimension separate from thousands of other planets."

Catra's expression gentled further, eyes gazing into the distance. "'What happened to the stars?' Razz asked that once…"

“Isn’t it worth a try, She-Ra?” Perfuma asked, hands clasped. “If we can have peace without more violence?”

Catra snorted. “This is justice, Petals,” she replied. “Hordak gave Shadow Weaver the power to do all the things she did. I say we let the two beat the crap out of each other and thrash whoever’s left.” Frosta let out a little cheer and punched her palm again.

“What about the cadets?” Adora almost whispered. That froze Catra on the spot. “They’ve been lied to their whole lives. Don’t you want to help them, at least?”

Catra grimaced and looked away for several seconds. Then she groaned and buried her face in her free hand. “I hate having a conscience,” she sighed.

Glimmer threw a hug around the magicat. “It’s got good perks,” she pointed out.

“We can handle this,” Bow added. “We’re the Best Friends Squad.”

Catra shook her head. “Okay. Let’s go – I can’t believe I’m saying this – save Hordak.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Catra was not having fun.

Oh, it was certainly possible that this would turn into a good day eventually. The Princesses of Power had smashed through the first wave of Shadow Weaver’s bots, with Entrapta taking control of an entire company of them on her right flank.

The problem was that Shadow Weaver and Vultak both had serious magic. What had appeared to be a mockery of Catra’s eyes was actually shards of the *Tenantin,* meaning Shadow Weaver could manipulate earth and flame in addition to using all the powers of the surface Runestones. She could even teleport, to Glimmer’s towering frustration. “Ugh! Hold still, you miserable witch!” the princess howled, firing beams of light from her staff.

Shadow Weaver merely chuckled and parried with the same magic.

Hordak finally worked his way over to the Rebellion forces helping him, signing a request for explanation with one hand while providing cover fire with the other. "Entrapta thinks you might be worth salvaging," Catra hissed, swatting a tank blast back down its own barrel with the Sword. "Also, most of these soldiers are brainwashed cadets who don't know any better, so Adora wants to save them."

Hordak shocked Catra by nodding in – agreement? Understanding? She didn't care so long as he didn't stab them in the back. "Fall back to Doom Tower," he ordered, his forces obeying without (much) question.

"You heard the man," Catra called, "Frosta, Perfuma, 'Tossa, Felicia, I want layered ramparts from here to the rally point." She smirked at Adora. "Heh. 'Doom Tower.' And you didn't know we were the bad guys."

Adora's blush was exquisite. "It's what I grew up with, okay?" she complained, providing covering fire for the four princesses in question while Mermista and Glimmer pushed Shadow Weaver's forces back – literally, in the mermaid princess' case.

They retreated in something resembling good order, setting up around the seat of Hordak's power. Shadow Weaver was already tearing down the ad-hoc ramparts, but it was taking her time with four princesses resisting her. Besides, Hordak's loyalists were throwing considerable firepower at the advancing forces. Catra turned her attention to Hordak and his main Force Captains. She cut off a growl halfway in and took a breath to master herself. "Okay, Hordak, you're about to get your one chance to not end up in a cell – or on my sword." Octavia and Callix glared. Grizzlor's smile was feral, reminding Catra of her own examples of grinning fury. "Entrapta and Adora think you might be worth talking to. Prove it."

Hordak sighed and held up a hand. His commanders backed off. "You know that Shadow Weaver must be stopped." He paused, his eyes...turning yellow? "According to Vultak, you know that better than anyone, She-Ra."

Catra's ears flipped back. Adora and Scorpia tensed. Glimmer teleported to She-Ra's side, staff glowing with magic and clearly ready to fry Hordak. "What does Vultak have to do with it?"

"I completed a perfected portal earlier today," Hordak explained. "It compensates for Despondos' – unusual properties. When I informed Vultak of this and asked him which of us you would fear more, he explained that Shadow Weaver…harmed you, in your youth."

Catra stared for a long moment. Then she laughed. "Right. She 'harmed' me." Adora – all her friends, really – looked at her with concern. "Do you know how many electric burn scars I have? Because I don't. Micah lost track after the first 700." They all stared, Rebellion and Horde alike. "And somehow, you didn't know this. I mean," she continued, hint of a broken chuckle in her voice, "Adora had to live with it to keep me alive. I get that now. But you?" All humor left her, only a glare and furious Swordlight remaining. "You made her your second in command. You *gave her children.* And you're just figuring all this out now?" Hordak bowed his head.

"He was never a child," Callix blurted, stepping forward.

Most of the others blinked. "I don't get it," Frosta said. Catra waved in her direction, trying to express *what she said* through her confusion.

"A clone can be raised from infancy," Callix explained, "but that would take decades Lord Prime deems better spent in his service. So his clones are programmed with enough knowledge to serve him and decanted fully grown."

Catra gasped. "Wait, so you mean Hordak was 'born' grown up – with nothing but this Prime guy in his head?" Callix nodded. Catra looked at Entrapta. The inventor princess was looking at her with huge puppy eyes. She looked at Adora. Same. Scorpia? Same. Perfuma...same, somehow. The others were more skeptical, but most of them seemed willing to give him a chance. *Not even Felicia seems…well, she's not* completely *against it, anyway.* She-Ra sighed. "Fine. So, any ideas, Hordak?"

"Shadow Weaver is the true threat," Hordak said. Catra scoffed. *Duh.* The clone's eyes flashed red for a moment. "My point is, her magic is beyond standard military strategy to counteract. If the princesses can keep her occupied, I can bring the soldiers to heel. The only real problem is that most of her forces believe I am the imposter."

"We take down Shadow Weaver," Catra filled in for anyone who didn't get it, "and the Kamelian drops their disguise, war over." She looked him up and down. "That does mean the war's over, right?"

Hordak looked away. "Horde Prime will find us one day. My pale imitation of his army will end its attempts to give this world to him."

Glimmer glared at him. "That's a sudden change of heart," she pointed out. "Why?"

"Vultak was one of the Beloved centuries before my creation," Hordak said, eyes dimming once more. "I never imagined that anyone in Prime's inner council would accept the crimes Shadow Weaver has committed. If being lost here forever is my punishment...so be it. I will serve the light of civilization. If Prime is not that light, then his faith is lies."

Not great, but enough for now, Catra decided. "Okay. Vultak and the cyborgs are a problem–"

“Oh, Aunt Estra isn’t a cyborg,” Entrapta cut in, smile wavering. “Her harness reads neural output that allows her to control her tentacles.”

Catra blinked. “Huh. Okay. Bow, Sea Hawk, Octavia, Callix, you’re with Entrapta, take down ‘Aunt Estra’ and the Scurvy guy. ‘Tossa, Spinny, can you take Vultak?”

Netossa’s eyes lit up with her lethal grin, while Spinnerella’s smile was far gentler. “Catriska, honey,” Netossa said, “I’ve been waiting my entire adult life to take that buzzard down.”

Catra nodded. “Right. Scorpia, Grizzlor, you’re with Spintossa. Everyone else, on me. Let’s bring Shadow Weaver down.”

They charged towards the avatar of Obtainment with all her stolen glory. Catra had never been more proud to count herself among the Princesses of Power. “So, why are Netossa and Spinnerella dealing with Vultak?” Glimmer asked. “Shouldn’t we, I dunno, swap princesses?”

Catra grinned at her best friend. “Are you volunteering, Sparkles?”

Glimmer grinned back. “Not a chance, Wildcat.”

“Exactly.” They reached the howling vortex of power that Shadow Weaver had become. “Princesses, counter-magic!” Catra ordered. They all obeyed, each princess turning her power against Shadow Weaver’s stolen might.

Shadow Weaver snarled, eyes narrowing at the sudden assault. “Who dares?” she demanded, raking crimson lightning at the allies.

Catra turned the Sword into a shield and blocked them all. “Who else? Hey, Shadow Weaver.”

With a frustrated scream, Shadow Weaver unleashed lightning and shadow entwined on the Princess of Power. She-Ra returned

fire with a beam of light, itself braided energy of blue and golden radiance. "Freak! Stray! *Mongrel!* Why. Won't. You. *DIE?!*

"I'm stubborn like that," Catra retorted, shining kindness dueling with grasping hatred. "What is your deal with my people?"

"You Bubasti," Shadow Weaver sneered. "Yours is a civilization with glory unearned and sloth inborn. For all her false kindness, Kyra was the embodiment of that corruption!"

"So you *were* jealous of Mom," Catra grumbled, circling.

"Jealous? Hah!" Shadow Weaver fired a crimson thunderbolt at She-Ra that Catra parried with the Sword. "I merely recognized the truth – the First Ones were right about you magicats!" The sorceress followed up with a freezefire blast. "You never deserved such innate sorcery. I earned every scrap of knowledge *and* power that I claimed!" She-Ra melted it away with a beam of Swordlight. "How are you doing that? Even She-Ra cannot withstand all the might of Etheria!"

"I'm not alone," Catra explained, gesturing toward the princesses with her free hand. Each was neutralizing one of Shadow Weaver's elemental magics. Mermista and Frosta were even pushing toward the cruel sorceress. "And you? You're nothing but a thief," She-Ra snarled, remaining on defense while Shadow Weaver cast spell after spell at her. "You used a kid to get the Spell of Obtainment. You groomed Adora to be your puppet from *infancy.* And when those weren't enough, you brainwashed a shapeshifter to steal pieces of the Runestones!" She shattered a burst of raw force with a perfect thrust. "You're a leech, Shadow Weaver, and I'm here to *cut you off."*

"No!" Shadow Weaver cried, pouring her shadows into all her magic. "I can drain them all! I am the greatest sorceress that has ever lived! You cannot overcome me even with all the might of She-Ra, and your pathetic wit could never overcome my genius!"

“Is that so?” Micah asked, turning visible right next to the Kamelian ‘Hordak.’ A triple-circle of violet light formed underneath them both.

Shadow Weaver’s eyes flew wide. “–no–” she gasped, trying to form one last spell, but the sorceress was already well beyond her limits. Micah’s counter-magic spell freed the Kamelian from Shadow Weaver. With a cry of horror and grief, they changed into a slender, elegant blonde reptilian in a black body suit. Glimmer teleported over, got the Kamelian out, then reappeared by her father’s side. They held hands, pointing Glimmer’s staff at Shadow Weaver, and fired a beam of shimmering light.

“And that’s your teleportation gone,” Catra explained, smirking while Shadow Weaver stared in terror, “which means you’re done. This is for Fred.” In a blur of impossible speed, She-Ra shattered all seven shards, and the mask with them.

“NOOOO!” Shadow Weaver fell to her knees, magic roaring out of her in great streams of ether. Catra pointed the Sword at her throat. “…mercy…”

“Like, you don’t deserve any,” Mermista snapped.

Felicia glared. “Not after everything you’ve done.”

“But we will show you mercy anyway,” Perfuma said.

“Because that’s what the good guys do,” Frosta added from atop an ice pillar.

Glimmer teleported to Catra’s side. “And we are the good guys.”

Catra’s smirk melted into a gentle smile. “Killing me is the best thing you ever did,” she said, golden light flowing around her free hand. “These princesses, the ones you spent a lifetime lying about? They gave me everything. If all I can give them is peace, that’ll be enough.”

"That is all we can ask," Perfuma joined in, her smile at peace for the first time since Shadow Weaver brainwashed her.

"But even you can find a place here," She-Ra whispered, extending the glowing hand to Shadow Weaver, "if you're willing to take it."

The scarred face and broken eyes no longer terrified Catra. Somewhere within, a frightened child shivered in fear, but the rest of her was surrounded by people who loved her. *No matter what happens next, it's*– Shadow Weaver reached out with a trembling, uncertain hand. *…over?* Catra leaned over to help the sorceress–

–but Shadow Weaver grabbed the Sword's hilt instead, her other hand gripping a bundle of shards from all the other Runestones! "Ha! FOOL!" A burst of scarlet power threw the other princesses back, but Catra was trapped in a battle of power for control of the Sword of Protection. The form of She-Ra collapsed, leaving only the magicat in her place. "Friendship. Goodness. Love. *Bah!"* Shadow Weaver's darkness crawled up the blade and over Catra's hand. "I spent a 'lifetime' teaching you better than that, but you never listened. Now you will pay the price for your lack of vision!"

Even the power of She-Ra wavered in the face of all Etheria's Runestones. Catra shuddered, knees threatening to buckle. Darkness covered everyone, swallowed everything. She couldn't even sense Adora.

Adora.

No. Catra was wrong. She couldn't see Adora, or hear her, or pick up her scent, but Catra could *feel* her out there. *Even when we were fighting each other, we still loved.* Light sparked in the shadows, blue and gold and *invincible.* None of Shadow Weaver's spells or bolts or voids could extinguish that light, two yet one. The darkness recoiled from the light – the Swordlight of She-Ra – and Catra was the Swordlight. *Adora was right. It's not the Sword. It was never about the Sword. We are the light. And I...*

"I."

Shadow Weaver threw all her strength into taking the Sword. "You cannot," she whispered.

"Am."

"You are not strong enough!" Shadow Weaver wailed.

"SHE-RA!"

And she was.

The Swordlight flung Shadow Weaver back like a bug thrown aside by a storm. Catra emerged from the eruption as She-Ra once more, glaring at her former captor. "Fine. You made your choice." Once more, she pointed the Sword at the sorceress. "Now live with it." Her weapon glowed with the endless glory of the Swordlight.

"A luxury you will not enjoy, magicat," Shadow Weaver snarled. "I still hold shards of every Runestone on Etheria, and I have yet more to spare. Your precious Swordlight is but a moment's spark, while my darkness is eternal–"

A Sword of pure golden light pierced Shadow Weaver's chest from behind. Catra's eyes widened when she followed the second Sword to Adora, who had maneuvered behind their former keeper. "No," Adora whispered. "You're done."

The Spell of Obtainment imploded, taking Shadow Weaver with it. The only proof that she had been there were slivers of mask and Runestone.

Adora stared at where Shadow Weaver had been for several long seconds, her eyes alight with pure fury. Then she collapsed, her Sword of magic disappearing, and sobbed into her hands. Catra rushed to hold her. "It's okay, Adora. You're okay. It's over."

"I…she…" Adora looked up at Catra, even as the other princesses descended to hug them both, "she was a monster. She deserved… but I'm…why am I sad?"

Catra pulled Adora in, holding her tight. "Because you're good," the magicat whispered. "No matter what she did to change you, Adora, you were always good, and you always will be."

They held each other, crying in sorrow and relief at the end of the world.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

The beginning of the new world came with the following dawn.

Adora looked out from one of Brightmoon's many, *many* balconies. *Stars. I'm starting to wonder if having a balcony is some kind of princess right or something.* The view of the daymoon rising over the Whispering Woods was expectedly beautiful. It salved the First One's wounded heart. *Still wrapping my head around that,* she thought, looking at her hand. Swordlight flickered in the palm for a moment. *I came from...wherever the First Ones are. Kidnapped to be the She-Ra. Will it ever make sense? Will anything?*

The purring from her – *their* bed stuttered. Catra grumbled and flopped over, kneading the covers. Adora's heart swelled to overflowing. *Yeah. That. That will always make sense.*

Adora lost track of how long she stared at her beautiful girlfriend, ears twitching and tail curling. It had to be at least several minutes given the moving daymoon light, but it felt like seconds until Catra's golden eye opened and glared. "Are you being weird?" she asked with a huff.

Adora nodded. "You knew I was weird when you chose me," she retorted, tossing of a smug grin.

"Ugh. It is way too early for you to be this full of yourself." Catra threw a pillow at Adora, who caught it with ease. "Come back to bed. She-Ra deserves her blanket heater."

“You’re talking in the third person and calling *me* weird?” Adora quipped, hands on her hips. “Dork.”

“Nope, only one dork per relationship, and that’s you,” Catra accused, both eyes now glaring half-heartedly. “Not warm enough. Get in bed.”

Adora’s smile faded as she came to sit on the bed’s edge. “Why isn’t anyone upset with me?” she asked, voice small and eyes locked on her feet.

Catra stared for a long moment. Then she groaned, sat up, and hugged Adora. “Because Shadow Weaver threw away like a *million* chances to make the right choice. The only one who’s upset about it is you. That’s okay, though. We’ll get through it.”

Adora nodded. “It’s okay to not be okay. Still wrapping my head around that.” She closed her eyes. “She taught me to lace my boots.” Catra said nothing, just holding her. Adora was grateful beyond words for that. “I know she was horrible, and cruel, and selfish. She hurt you, all the time. But…”

“She was the only mom you ever knew,” Catra finished for her. Adora nodded. “And you – stopped her – to save me.” Catra cleared her throat. “I. Um. Thank you.”

Adora hugged Catra back. “We’re not okay,” she said, tears falling on Catra’s fur, “but we will be.”

“No matter how bad things get, we’ll be okay as long as we have each other,” Catra insisted. “That’s our real promise, and you never broke it.”

Adora’s trickle of tears became a flood. “I love you,” she whispered, “so much.”

“I love you too.” Catra’s tail curled around Adora’s wrist. “Always.”

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Epilogue One

Catra smiled (but she did *not* tear up no matter what anyone says, thank you Glimmer) while Adora hugged her real mom. Who was an actual queen, of course. "You did good, Hordak," she whispered to Darla's co-engineer. The clone just huffed and looked away.

"Ooo, family drama," Double Trouble gushed. "Looks like fun!"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Save it for the bad guys, Menace," she warned them.

Double Trouble took in a breath to argue, but Glimmer sparkled dangerously, and they gave it up in an eyeblink. "So, what's a Skeletor when he's at home?" they asked.

"No idea," Catra shrugged, "but if we have to rattle some bones to get Eternia into the war against Horde Prime, then let's get rattling."

Glimmer slapped Catra's arm. "Give. Your Fiancée. A moment," the sparkly princess warned while dad and the Kyle-like kid brother joined in the hug.

"Yeah, yeah," Catra muttered, looking away to hide her blush. "Guess I'm meeting the parents." She would rather have been fighting Skeletor *and* He-Ra or whoever, but…it was for Adora. This was for Adora.

And when Adora turned, wriggling out of the hug enough to turn eyes filled with tears of joy on Catra, hand held out to join them, the She-Ra knew that she would do anything to see that smile as often as she could for the rest of her life.

-SR- -SR- -SR-

Epilogue Two

“Accursed mongrel!” Horde Prime snarled, glaring from within his latest war-body. This one looked like some stitched-together abomination copied from Mumm-Ra and Darkseid. Even Catra had to admit it was impressive, at least from a purely technical standpoint. “No magicat stray could shake my empire! What are you?”

The inert body of Unicron shuddered beneath them. Near the metal monstrosity’s artificial horizon, Optimus, Saturn Girl, and Lion-O led the forces holding off the Beloved. Princesses and Masters gathered behind the twin She-Ras. Catra looked at Adora, only barely keeping herself from becoming distracted by her sheer beauty and wonder. Her fellow She-Ra wore armor nearly identical to Catra’s own, except in white where Catra’s was red and blue, and she had a half-skirt in place of the cape. They grinned at each other. “Man, I get asked that a lot. What do you think, Adora?”

Adora let out that snorting laugh that always melted Catra’s heart. “Um, duh, you’re She-Ra.”

“Well, yeah, but so are you,” Catra pointed out. The other princesses chuckled.

“You speak folly! I have crushed a thousand She-Ras over the aeons,” Horde Prime snapped, toxic green light burning in his eyes. Cruel white fire gathered around his arms. “What makes you so special?”

Catra stared for a moment, mouth agape. “You still don’t know after all this?” she asked. Then she laughed. “I, I mean, seriously, the whole *universe* knows at this point.” Catra became serious in an instant. “I’m the woman Adora loves. That makes me invincible.”

Adora’s gaze was uncharacteristically cool as she glared at Horde Prime. “And I’m the woman Catra loves, so, same.”

“Love? Love. Madness.” Horde Prime shook his head. “I have crushed love a hundred trillion times on as many worlds. Yours

will not overcome my perfection. Prime always rises again. So it has ever been, and so it always shall be.”

Catra looked at Adora. Adora nodded back, and they turned their full attention to the architect of all their childhood pain. “No,” Catra whispered, and they both held their Swords aloft. “You’re done.”

They charged, rainbow light from a thousand allies shining at the end of the world, and its beginning, yet again.

Chapter End Notes

> Me: hates it when my favorite fics take months to update, especially when it's only one chapter away from being finished.
>
> Also me: takes six months to finish SCOP
>
> Also also me: *DIES*
>
> I'm so sorry this took so long. Bell's Palsy *sucks.* As wonderful as a lot of my life has become, this summer was truly horrible at times. (Spent 12 hours waiting for a five minute urgent care visit because I was going literal days without sleep. Turned out it was anxiety. That was...not fun.) Anyway, I also apologize for how truncated SCOP turned out to be -- I really wanted to do the Cat-Ra concept justice -- but I hope this finale provides some satisfaction, at least.
>
> Also, for fans of the Turn Right timelines, the final epilogue offers some hints of where Turn Right itself is headed in the months to come. I hope you all enjoyed this ride. Two down, one to go.

End Notes

Standard "classic She-Ra riffs" note: Leena, Hemli, Poltan, and Greenfield are all from She-Ra '85, though about as closely related as the rest of SPOP is to its inspiration.

I was hoping to fit in the "one year later" thing here, but Catra's rant was cathartic for *me,* so how must it have felt for her? *g*

Next time: One Year Later. Adora finally makes Force Captain, but the Whispering Woods Wildcat has been busy...

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!